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INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING OF EQUITY SHARES ON THE MAIN BOARD OF THE BSE LIMITED ("BSE") AND "NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED ("NSE") AND TOGETHER WITH BSE, THE "STOCK EXCHANGES") IN COMPLIANCE WITH CHAPTER II OF THE SECURITIES AND EXCHANGE BOARD OF INDIA (ISSUE OF CAPITAL AND DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS) REGULATIONS, 2018, AS AMENDED ("SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS").



SYMBIOTEC PHARMALAB LIMITED

(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)



(Please scan this QR Code to view the Red Herring Prospectus and Abridged Prospectus)

Our Company was incorporated as 'Symbiotec Pharmalab Private Limited' as a private limited company under the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated September 20, 2002, issued by the Registrar of Companies, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh. Subsequently, in the interest of business expansion and issuing fresh shares to the public to meet requirements of funds for a project being undertaken by the Company which would have resulted into increase in the members of the Company beyond fifty, our Company was converted from a private limited company to a public limited company, pursuant to the Board resolution dated September 22, 2005 and a resolution passed in the extraordinary general meeting of our Shareholders held on October 18, 2005 and the name of our Company was changed to Symbiotec Pharmalab Limited, and a certificate of change of name dated October 27, 2005 was issued to our Company by the Registrar of Companies, Madhya Pradesh & Chhattisgarh. Further, considering the absence of public involvement in the shareholding pattern and the management of the Company, our Company was converted to a private limited company pursuant to the Board resolution dated April 23, 2014 and a resolution passed in the extraordinary general meeting of our Shareholders on May 22, 2014 and the name of our Company was changed to Symbiotec Pharmalab Private Limited and a certificate of incorporation, consequent upon conversion to a private limited was issued by the RoC on July 25, 2014. Thereafter, as part of the Company's strategic vision for future growth and expansion, our Company was converted into a public company, pursuant to the Board resolution dated September 11, 2025 and a special resolution dated September 12, 2025 passed in the extraordinary general meeting of our Shareholders. Consequently the name of our Company was changed to Symbiotec Pharmalab Limited and a fresh certificate of incorporation dated September 26, 2025, consequent upon conversion to a public company, was issued by the Registrar of Companies, Central Processing Centre. For further details on the changes in the name and registered office of our Company, see "History and Certain Corporate Matters" on page 265 of the Red Herring Prospectus dated August 18, 2026 ("RHP") to be read with Addendum to the RHP dated August 19, 2026 ("Addendum").

Corporate Identity Number: U24232MP2002PLC015293; Website: www.symbiotec.com
Registered and Corporate Office: 385/2, Pigdamber, Rau, Mhow, Indore – 453 331, Madhya Pradesh, India | Contact Person: Salil Jain, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; Telephone: +91 731 667 6405; Email: secretarial@symbiotec.com

THE PROMOTERS OF OUR COMPANY: ANIL SATWANI, KASHISH SATWANI, SUSHIL SATWANI AND SATWANI HOLDINGS LLP

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF OUR COMPANY FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A SHARE PREMIUM OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE) ("OFFER PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹17,570.00 MILLION ("OFFER"). THE OFFER COMPRISES A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH AGGREGATING UP TO ₹1,500.00 MILLION BY OUR COMPANY ("FRESH ISSUE") AND AN OFFER FOR SALE OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH ("OFFERED SHARES") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹16,070.00 MILLION, COMPRISING OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH AGGREGATING UP TO ₹1,440.00 MILLION BY SATWANI HOLDINGS LLP (THE "PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER"), UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH AGGREGATING UP TO ₹9,880.00 MILLION BY ROSEWOOD INVESTMENTS AND UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH AGGREGATING UP TO ₹4,750.00 MILLION BY INDIA BUSINESS EXCELLENCE FUND – III (THE "INVESTOR SELLING SHAREHOLDERS"), AND TOGETHER WITH THE PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER, THE "SELLING SHAREHOLDERS" AND SUCH OFFER FOR SALE OF EQUITY SHARES BY THE SELLING SHAREHOLDERS, THE "OFFER FOR SALE"). THE OFFER WILL CONSTITUTE [●]% OF THE POST-OFFER PAID UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY.

THE OFFER INCLUDES A RESERVATION OF [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH AGGREGATING ₹30.00 MILLION (CONSTITUTING UP TO [●]% OF THE POST OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY), FOR SUBSCRIPTION BY ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES (THE "EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION"). THE OFFER LESS THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION IS HEREINAFTER REFERRED TO AS THE "NET OFFER". THE OFFER AND THE NET OFFER SHALL CONSTITUTE [●]% AND [●]%, RESPECTIVELY, OF THE POST-OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY. OUR COMPANY, IN CONSULTATION WITH THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS, MAY OFFER A DISCOUNT OF UP TO [●]% (EQUIVALENT TO ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE) TO THE OFFER PRICE TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING UNDER THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION ("EMPLOYEE DISCOUNT").

THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARE IS ₹2 EACH. THE OFFER PRICE IS [●] TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES. THE PRICE BAND, THE MINIMUM BID LOT AND THE EMPLOYEE DISCOUNT WILL BE DECIDED BY OUR COMPANY, IN CONSULTATION WITH THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS AND WILL BE ADVERTISED IN ALL EDITIONS OF FINANCIAL EXPRESS, A WIDELY CIRCULATED ENGLISH NATIONAL DAILY NEWSPAPER, IN ALL EDITIONS OF JANSATTA, A WIDELY CIRCULATED HINDI NATIONAL DAILY NEWSPAPER AND INDORE SAMACHAR, A HINDI DAILY NEWSPAPER (HINDI ALSO BEING THE REGIONAL LANGUAGE OF MADHYA PRADESH, WHERE OUR COMPANY'S REGISTERED AND CORPORATE OFFICE IS LOCATED), AT LEAST TWO WORKING DAYS PRIOR TO THE BID / OFFER OPENING DATE AND SHALL BE MADE AVAILABLE TO BSE LIMITED AND NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED FOR UPLOADING ON THEIR RESPECTIVE WEBSITES IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS.

DETAILS OF THE OFFER FOR SALE BY THE SELLING SHAREHOLDERS AND WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION PER EQUITY SHARE			
NAME OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDERS	TYPE	MAXIMUM NUMBER OF EQUITY SHARES OFFERED / AMOUNT (₹ IN MILLION)	WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION PER EQUITY SHARE (IN ₹)*
Satwani Holdings LLP	Promoter Selling Shareholder	Up to [●] Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each aggregating up to ₹1,440.00 million	49.43
Rosewood Investments	Investor Selling Shareholder	Up to [●] Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each aggregating up to ₹9,880.00 million	147.21
India Business Excellence Fund – III	Investor Selling Shareholder	Up to [●] Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each aggregating up to ₹4,750.00 million	147.21

*As certified by M/s. A B M S & Associates, Chartered Accountants by way of their certificate dated August 18, 2026.

PRICE BAND: ₹938 TO ₹988 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH.

THE FLOOR PRICE IS 469.00 TIMES OF THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES AND THE CAP PRICE IS 494.00 TIMES OF THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.

BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 15 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 15 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH THEREAFTER.

WEIGHTED AVERAGE RETURN ON NET WORTH FOR LAST THREE FINANCIAL YEARS IS 10.99%.

THE PRICE TO EARNINGS RATIO (P/E) BASED ON DILUTED EPS FOR FISCAL 2026 OF THE COMPANY AT THE UPPER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS AS HIGH AS 52.00 TIMES AND AT THE LOWER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS 49.37 TIMES.

DISCOUNT OF ₹90.00 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 IS BEING OFFERED TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING IN THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION.

The details of the Fresh Issue, Issue Size and the post Issue market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

Particulars	At Floor Price of ₹ 938 per Equity Share		At Cap Price of ₹ 988 per Equity Share	
	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each	Up to Amount (₹ in million)	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each	Up to Amount (₹ in million)
Fresh Issue	1,602,541	1,500.00	1,521,261	1,500.00
Offer for Sale	17,132,195	16,070.00	16,265,181	16,070.00
Total Issue Size	18,734,736	17,570.00	17,786,442	17,570.00
Post-Issue market capitalization of the Company	64,337,392	60,348.47	64,256,112	63,485.04

BID/OFFER PROGRAMME

BID/OFFER OPENS TODAY

BID/OFFER CLOSES ON: THURSDAY, AUGUST 27, 2026*

*The UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 p.m. on Bid / Offer Closing Date.

We are a research and development-driven, science-based pharmaceutical and biotechnology company with capabilities across three platforms - organic chemistry, biotechnology and complex injectables. Operate as a contract development and manufacturing organisation variably for specialty pharmaceutical and nutraceutical companies globally, offering products and services across the three platforms in which we also manufacture our own products.
The Offer is being made through the Book Building Process in accordance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations.
The Equity Shares of our Company will get listed on the main board of BSE and NSE. BSE shall be the Designated Stock Exchange.
QIB Portion: Not more than 50% of the Net Offer Non-Institutional Portion: Not less than 15% of the Net Offer Retail Portion: Not less than 35% of the Net Offer.
EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION: UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹30.00 MILLION

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST ONLY RELY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RED HERRING PROSPECTUS AND THE TERMS OF THE OFFER, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE OFFER AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THIS PRE-OFFER AND PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE OFFER AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES/REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE VALUATION OF OUR COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS TO THE OFFER ("BRLMS").

In accordance with the recommendation of committee of Independent Directors of our Company, pursuant to their resolution dated August 18, 2026, the above provided price band is justified based on quantitative factors/Key Performance Indicators ("KPI") disclosed in the "Basis for Offer Price" section on page 146 of the RHP vis-a-vis the weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA") of primary and secondary transaction(s) as applicable, disclosed in the "Basis for Offer Price" on page 146 of the RHP.

RISK TO INVESTORS | For details, refer to section titled "Risk Factors" on page 28 of the RHP.

1) Revenue dependence on sale of Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients ("APIs"):

We derive almost all of our revenue from the sale of API products, including corticosteroid and steroidal-hormones. In addition to manufacturing API products that we sell, we offer our services as a contract development and manufacturing organisation ("CDMO") for specialty pharmaceutical and nutraceutical companies. Any reduction in demand for API products, and our top products in particular, or a temporary or permanent discontinuation in our manufacturing operations for such products, could have an adverse effect on our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows.

Particulars	Fiscal 2026		Fiscal 2025		Fiscal 2024	
	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from operations (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from operations (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from operations (%)
Sale of APIs (A)	8,350.05	96.07%	7,447.54	99.10%	7,162.47	100.00%
Sale of complex injectables (B)	330.50	3.80%	-	-	-	-
CDMO services (C)	10.94	0.13%	68.00	0.90%	-	-
Total (A+B+C)	8,691.49	100.00%	7,515.54	100.00%	7,162.47	100.00%

2) Audit and inspections risk: We operate in a highly competitive industry where regulatory standards are not only extensive but also continuously evolving. We are required to comply with regulations and quality standards stipulated by regulatory authorities and certain of our customers. Our manufacturing facilities and products are subject to periodic inspections and audits by these regulatory authorities and customers. If we are not in compliance with the requirements prescribed by such authorities or terms stipulated in contracts with our customers, we may be subject to regulatory actions, including issuance of warning letters, imposition of sanctions, amendment or withdrawal of our existing approvals, product seizure, interruption of our operations, or claims resulting from non-compliance with contractual obligations.

3) Dependence on export markets: As of March 31, 2026, revenue from external customers outside India contributed 67.04%, 55.19% and 59.97% of our revenue from operations in Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Our inability to handle risks associated with our export sales could adversely affect our sales to customers in foreign countries, our results of operations, financial condition and cash flows.

Particulars	Fiscal 2026		Fiscal 2025		Fiscal 2024	
	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from operations (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from operations (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from operations (%)
Revenue from external customers - India (A)	2,865.05	32.96%	3,367.75	44.81%	2,867.23	40.03%
Revenue from external customers outside India (B)	5,826.44	67.04%	4,147.79	55.19%	4,295.24	59.97%
- Europe	2,529.86	29.11%	2,271.07	30.22%	2,124.20	29.66%
- United States	1,140.00	13.12%	302.02	4.02%	642.60	8.97%
- China	82.90	0.95%	115.58	1.54%	22.19	0.31%
- Rest of the world*	2,073.68	23.86%	1,459.13	19.41%	1,506.25	21.03%
Revenue from operations (A+B)	8,691.49	100.00%	7,515.54	100.00%	7,162.47	100.00%

* Rest of the world includes Asia (other than India and China) and Africa.

4) Tariff and anti-sourcing risk: Revenue from the United States represented 13.12%, 4.02% and 8.97% of our revenue from operations for Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024. The imposition of tariffs or other anti-sourcing measures by the United States could increase our costs, affect the competitiveness of our products and adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows.

5) Customer concentration risk: We derive a substantial portion of our revenue from certain key customers, with our top ten customers accounting for 57.59%, 55.90% and 61.65% of our revenue from sale of products in Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Any loss of, or reduction in orders from, these customers could adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows.

Particulars	Fiscal 2026		Fiscal 2025		Fiscal 2024	
	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from sale of products (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from sale of products (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of revenue from sale of products (%)
Top five customers	3,475.98	43.01%	3,037.13	42.27%	3,154.83	48.51%
Top ten customers	4,654.71	57.59%	4,015.76	55.90%	4,009.50	61.65%

6) Geographic concentration risk: As of March 31, 2026, we operated the Rau Facility and the Pithampur Facility in the state of Madhya Pradesh in India. In addition, our Ujjain Facility and our Mhow Facility, which we have commissioned and where we have started R&D and pilot-scale operations as of March 31, 2026, are also located in Madhya Pradesh. Any adverse developments affecting Madhya Pradesh or its surrounding regions could adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows. A slowdown, interruption or shutdown in our manufacturing operations could have an adverse effect on our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows.

7) Supplier concentration risk: We depend on certain suppliers for raw materials for our operations. Purchases from our top ten suppliers accounted for 25.50%, 18.41% and 50.33% of our total expenses in Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Any loss of such suppliers or non-performance of their obligations could adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows.

Particulars	Fiscal 2026		Fiscal 2025		Fiscal 2024	
	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of total expenses (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of total expenses (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of total expenses (%)
Top five suppliers	1,501.96	21.16%	850.41	13.97%	2,293.90	38.81%
Top ten suppliers	1,810.15	25.50%	1,120.78	18.41%	2,974.31	50.33%

8) Competition risk: We operate in a highly competitive market. We face competition both within our API manufacturing business and in our role as a CDMO, which we have recently commenced. An inability to compete effectively may adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows.

9) Dependence on imported raw materials: We procure a portion of our raw material requirements from different countries, including China and the United States. Any adverse developments in these countries, or the laws governing our imports from these countries, could disrupt our raw material supply and adversely affect our results of operations, financial condition and cash flows

Particulars	Fiscal 2026		Fiscal 2025		Fiscal 2024	
	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of total expenses (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of total expenses (%)	Amount (₹ million)	Percentage of total expenses (%)
Raw materials sourced domestically	781.35	11.00%	915.79	15.04%	785.62	12.84%
Raw material imports	1,868.82	26.32%	1,197.36	19.67%	3,275.61	55.43%
- United States of America	59.77	0.84%	39.10	0.64%	20.02	0.34%
- China	1,695.24	23.88%	1,024.32	16.82%	3,119.82	52.79%
- Other countries*	113.81	1.60%	133.94	2.20%	135.76	2.30%

*Other countries include countries such as Singapore, Malaysia and Germany.

10) Product development risk: Our success depends on our ability to develop and commercialise new products in a timely manner. Our research and development ("R&D") efforts are central to our ability to build, scale, and sustain complex manufacturing technologies across platforms. If our research and development efforts do not succeed, or the products we commercialise do not perform as expected, the introduction of new products may be hindered, which could adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows. In order to remain competitive, we must develop, test and manufacture new products, which must meet regulatory standards and receive requisite regulatory approvals.

Particulars	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Research and development expenses (₹ million) (A)	296.95	311.43	205.09
Total expenses (₹ million) (B)	7,099.02	6,088.49	5,909.85
Research and development expenses, as a percentage of total expenses (%) (A/B*100)	4.18%	5.12%	3.47%

11) Risk related to transfer of shares: The Investor Selling Shareholders, India Business Excellence Fund – III, together with its co-investors, namely, Mahendra Fulchand Sundesha and Namarayan Nathmal Saraf jointly with Indra Saraf will transfer 203,866 Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each for a consideration of ₹200.00 per Equity Share aggregating to ₹40.77 million and Rosewood Investments will transfer 1,508,478 Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each for a consideration of ₹200.00 per Equity Share aggregating to ₹301.69 million, immediately prior to the filing of the Red Herring Prospectus, to our Promoter, Satwani Holdings LLP pursuant to the upside sharing arrangement as provided for in the Investment Agreement which will be undertaken at a price lower than the Offer Price and will result in an aggregate increase of 2.73% in the pre-offer shareholding (on a fully diluted basis) of Satwani Holdings LLP.

12) The Selling Shareholders will receive the entire proceeds from the Offer for Sale. We will not receive or benefit from any proceeds from the Offer for Sale portion.

13) The weighted average cost of acquisition per Equity Share acquired by our Promoters (which includes the Promoter Selling Shareholder) and Selling Shareholders, as on the date of the Red Herring Prospectus is as follows:

S. No.	Name of Promoter	Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each held as on date	WACA per Equity Share (in ₹)
Promoters			
1.	Anil Satwani	2,810,896	276.00
2.	Kashish Satwani	2,750,896	273.04
3.	Sushil Satwani	1,233,938	72.37
4.	Satwani Holdings LLP ^A	11,277,374	49.43
Selling Shareholders			
1.	Rosewood Investments	19,042,092	147.21
2.	India Business Excellence Fund - III	11,386,687	147.21

As certified by M/s. A B M S & Associates, Chartered Accountants by way of their certificate dated August 19, 2026.

^AAlso participating as the Promoter Selling Shareholder.

14) Weighted Average Return on Net worth for past three Fiscals i.e. 2026, 2025 and 2024 is 10.99%

15) Weighted average cost of acquisition of all equity shares transacted in the one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus

Period	Weighted average cost of acquisition per equity share (in ₹) ^A	Cap Price is 'x' times the weighted average cost of acquisition	Range of acquisition price per equity share: lowest price – highest price (in ₹) ^B
Last one year preceding the date of this Red Herring Prospectus	440.00	2.25	0-988
Last 18 months preceding the date of this Red Herring Prospectus	432.98	2.28	0-988
Last three years preceding the date of this Red Herring Prospectus	432.98	2.28	0-988

^AAs certified by M/s. A B M S & Associates, Chartered Accountants by way of their certificate dated August 19, 2026.

^BAdjusted for sub-division of equity shares.

16) The details of the Price/Earnings (P/E), Earnings per Share (EPS), Return on Net Worth (RoNW) and Net Asset Value (NAV) per Equity Share for our Company and peer group for the year ended 2026 appear hereunder:

Name of the company	Face value (₹ per equity share)	Closing price on August 17, 2026 (₹)	Revenue from operations for Fiscal 2026 (in ₹ million)	EPS (₹) for Fiscal 2026		NAV (₹ per equity share) for Fiscal 2026	P/E ratio as on August 17, 2026	RoNW for Fiscal 2026 (%)
				Basic	Diluted			
Symbiotec Pharmalab Limited	2	988.00*	8,691.49	19.10	19.00	184.69	52.00*	9.48%
Listed Peers								
Concord Biotech Limited	1	1,513.40	10,549.00	24.78	24.78	NA	61.07	14.00%
Divi's Laboratories Limited	2	8,495.00	105,600.00	96.75	96.75	631.00	87.80	16.50%
Cohance Lifesciences Limited	1	444.70	22,685.50	4.69	4.68	NA	95.02	7.00%
Laurus Labs Limited	2	1,799.00	68,129.00	16.47	16.45	NA	109.36	16.80%

As certified by M/s. A B M S & Associates, Chartered Accountants, pursuant to certificate dated August 19, 2026.

*Determined based on the Cap Price

For further details and relevant footnotes, please refer to page 150 of the RHP.

17) The BRLMs associated with the Offer have handled 83 public issues in the past three years, out of which 26 issues closed below the offer price on listing date.

Name of BRLMs	Total Issues	Issues closed below IPO price on listing date
JM Financial Limited*	30	11
Aventus Capital Private Limited*	4	1
Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited**	25	8
Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited*	8	2
Common issues handled by the BRLMs	16	4
Total	83	26

...continued from previous page.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS

1. The Company has not undertaken Pre-IPO Placement.
2. The details of Secondary Transfer made on August 17, 2026 are set forth below:

S. No.	Date of transfer	Name of Transferor	Name of Transferee	Number of equity shares transferred	Percentage of pre-Offer share capital of our Company	Face value per equity share (₹)	Transfer price per equity share (₹)	Nature of consideration	Total consideration (₹ in million)
1.	August 17, 2026	Anil Satwani	Motilal Oswal India Excellence Fund – Mid to Mega Series III	340,000	0.54	2	988.00	Cash	335.92
2.	August 17, 2026	Satwani Holdings LLP		165,000	0.26	2	988.00	Cash	163.02
Total				505,000	0.80				498.94
3.	August 17, 2026	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Satwani Holdings LLP	197,244	0.31	2	200.00	Cash	39.45
4.	August 17, 2026	Rosewood Investments		1,508,478	2.40	2	200.00	Cash	301.69
5.	August 17, 2026	Mahendra Fulchand Sundesha		4,282	0.01	2	200.00	Cash	0.86
6.	August 17, 2026	Namarayan Nathmal Saraf jointly with Indra Saraf		2,340	Negligible	2	200.00	Cash	0.47
Total				1,712,344	2.73				342.47

3. Our Investor Selling Shareholders, Rosewood Investments and India Business Excellence Fund – III have, pursuant to separate share purchase agreements each dated August 19, 2026, entered with the transferees set out in the table below, transferred an aggregate of 6,557,619 Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each, representing 10.43% of the pre-Offer paid up Equity Share capital of our Company, on a fully-diluted basis (“Sale Shares”) at a price of ₹988.00 per Equity Share, as follows:

S. No.	Nature of Transaction	Name of Transferor	Name of the Transferee	Date of Transfer	Whether transferee is connected, in any manner, with the Company, the Promoters, members of the Promoter Group (including the Promoter Selling Shareholders), the Directors, the Key Managerial Personnel, the Subsidiaries, and group companies and their respective directors and key managerial personnel*	Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each transferred	Percentage of pre-Offer share capital of the Company on a fully diluted basis, after the transfer of Sale Shares (%)	Transfer Price per Sale Share (₹)	Total consideration (in ₹ million)
1.	Secondary Sale	Rosewood Investments	Think India Opportunities Master Fund LP	August 19, 2026	No	1,771,255	2.82	988.00	1,750.00
2.	Secondary Sale	Rosewood Investments	Dymon Asia Multi-Strategy Investment (Singapore) Pte. Limited	August 19, 2026	No	1,012,145	1.61	988.00	1,000.00
Sub-total (A)						2,783,400	4.43	-	2,750.00
1.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	ValueQuest Founders Conviction LVF	August 19, 2026	No	1,771,255	2.82	988.00	1,750.00
2.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	VQ Fastecap Fund II	August 19, 2026	No	253,035	0.40	988.00	250.00
3.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	WhiteOak Capital India Opportunities Fund	August 19, 2026	No	506,071	0.81	988.00	500.00
4.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	WhiteOak Capital Equity Fund	August 19, 2026	No	50,607	0.08	988.00	50.00
5.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	WhiteOak Capital Healthcare Opportunities Fund	August 19, 2026	No	50,607	0.08	988.00	50.00
6.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Singularity Equity Fund I	August 19, 2026	No	454,395	0.72	988.00	448.94
7.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Waterfield Flagship Fund II	August 19, 2026	No	151,820	0.24	988.00	150.00
8.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Eterna Prima - Scheme II	August 19, 2026	No	101,215	0.16	988.00	100.00
9.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	1729 Growth Fund I	August 19, 2026	No	101,215	0.16	988.00	100.00
10.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Jaya Chandrakant Gogri	August 19, 2026	No	101,215	0.16	988.00	100.00
11.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Anshul Goel	August 19, 2026	No	50,605	0.08	988.00	50.00
12.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Piyush Jalan Family Trust	August 19, 2026	No	50,605	0.08	988.00	50.00
13.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Arvind Kapur	August 19, 2026	No	50,605	0.08	988.00	50.00
14.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Landmark Capital Markets Private Limited	August 19, 2026	No	50,605	0.08	988.00	50.00
15.	Secondary Sale	India Business Excellence Fund – III	Aluka Kavitha	August 19, 2026	No	30,364	0.05	988.00	30.00
Sub-total (B)						3,774,219	6.00	-	3,728.93
Total (A+B)						6,557,619	10.43	-	6,478.93

*For the purpose of this confirmation, (i) ‘connected with’ is deemed to mean that (a) there are no common directorships or common key managerial personnel between the Subject Persons and the investment manager of the transferees; and/or (b) there is no more than 1% equity investment interest by the transferees and investment manager of the transferees in the Subject Persons and also of the Subject Persons in the investment manager of the Purchasers and (ii) ‘Subject Persons’ shall mean, collectively, the Company and its Promoters and members of the Promoter Group (including the Seller), Directors, Key Managerial Personnel and Subsidiaries of the Company and their respective directors and key managerial personnel.

4. Investors should read this advertisement along with the RHP and the abridged prospectus, filed with the ROC and submitted to SEBI and Stock Exchanges, the pre-Offer and Price Band advertisement each dated August 18, 2026 and addendum to the RHP dated August 19, 2026 before making an investment decision with respect to the Offer.



You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of JM Financial Limited

BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE

The “Basis for Offer Price” section on page 146 of the RHP has been updated with the above price band. Please refer to the website of the BRLMs: www.jmfi.com, www.avendus.com, www.motilaloswal.com and www.nomuraholdings.com/company/group/asia/india/index.html for the “Basis for Offer Price” updated with the above price band.

AN INDICATIVE TIMETABLE IN RESPECT OF THE OFFER IS SET OUT BELOW:

Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors):

Bid / Offer Period (except the Bid / Offer Closing Date)	
Submission and revision in Bids	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. IST
Bid / Offer Closing Date	
Submission of electronic applications (Online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) – For RIBs	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Bank ASBA through Online channels like internet banking, mobile banking and Syndicate UPI ASBA applications where Bid Amount is up to ₹0.50 million)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Syndicate non-retail, non-individual applications)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 3.00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 1.00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Syndicate non-retail, non-individual applications where Bid Amount is more than ₹0.50 million)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 12.00 p.m. IST
Modification / Revision / Cancellation of Bids	
Upward revision of Bids by QIBs and NIBs*	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST on Bid / Offer Closing Date
Upward or downward revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RIBs and Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST on Bid / Offer Closing Date

*UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5.00 pm on Bid / Offer Closing Date.

*QIBs and NIBs can neither revise their Bids downwards nor cancel / withdraw their Bids.

Bid/Offer Programme	
ANCHOR INVESTOR BID/OFFER PERIOD OPENS AND CLOSES ON	Friday, August 21, 2026 ⁽ⁱ⁾
BID/OFFER OPENS ON	Monday, August 24, 2026 ⁽ⁱⁱ⁾
BID/OFFER CLOSES ON	Thursday, August 27, 2026 ⁽ⁱⁱⁱ⁾

ASBA

Simple, Safe, Smart way of Application!!!

*Applications Supported by Blocked Amount (“ASBA”) is a better way of applying to Issues by simply blocking the fund in the bank account. For further details, check section on ASBA.

Mandatory in public issues. No cheque will be accepted.



UPI - Now available in ASBA for Retail Individual Investors and Non-Institutional Investor applying in public issues where the application amount is up to ₹500,000, applying through Registered Brokers, Syndicate, CDPs & RTAs. Retail Individual Investors and Non-Institutional Investors also have the option to submit the application directly to the ASBA Bank (SCSBs) or to use the facility of linked online trading, demat and bank account. Investors are required to ensure that the bank account used for bidding is linked to their PAN. Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with CDDT Notification dated February 13, 2020, issued by Central Board of Direct Taxes and the subsequent press releases, including press releases dated June 25, 2021 and September 17, 2021 and CDDT circular no.7 of 2022, dated March 30, 2022 read with press release dated March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Investors in the Retail Portion; (ii) Non-Institutional Investors with an application size of up to ₹0.50 million in the Non-Institutional Portion. For details on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Form and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section “**Offer Procedure**” on page 451 of the RHP. The process is also available on the website of Association of Investment Bankers of India (“AIBI”) and Stock Exchanges and in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Form and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of the Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displayed on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedPiyees&intmid=35 and <https://www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedPiyees&intmid=43>, respectively as updated from time to time. For the list of UPI apps and banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through the SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited has been appointed as the Sponsor Bank for the Offer, in accordance with the requirements of SEBI ICDR Master Circular. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLMs on their respective email IDs as mentioned below. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll-free number: 18001201740 and mail Id: ipo.upi@npci.org.in.

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF THE STOCK EXCHANGES

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid / Offer Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days after such revision in the Price Band, subject to the Bid / Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of force majeure, banking strike or similar unforeseen circumstances, our Company may, in consultation with the BRLMs, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid / Offer Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid / Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid / Offer Period, if applicable, shall be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the BRLMs and at the terminals of the Syndicate Members and by intimation to Self-Certified Syndicate Banks (“SCSBs”), Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Bank(s), as applicable.

This Offer is being made through the Book Building Process, in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the Securities Contract (Regulation) Rules, 1957 (“SCRR”) read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations and in compliance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations wherein not more than 50% of the Net Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers (“QIBs”, and such portion, the “QIB Portion”), provided that our Company, in consultation with the BRLMs, may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors on a discretionary basis (“Anchor Investor Portion”). 40% of the Anchor Investor Portion shall be reserved as under: (i) 33.33% for the domestic Mutual Funds; and (ii) 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from the domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds at or above the price at which allocation will be made to Anchor Investors (“Anchor Investor Allocation Price”) in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations. Any under-subscription in the reserved category specified in clause (ii) above may be allocated to domestic Mutual Funds. In the event of under-subscription or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the QIB Portion (other than the Anchor Investor Portion) (the “Net QIB Portion”). Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Mutual Funds only, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price, and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to QIB Bidders (other than Anchor Investors) including Mutual Funds subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. However, if the aggregate demand from Mutual Funds is less than 5% of the Net QIB Portion, the balance Equity Shares available for allocation in the Mutual Fund Portion will be added to the remaining Net QIB Portion for proportionate allocation to all QIBs. Further, not less than 15% of the Net Offer shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders (out of which one-third of the portion available to Non-Institutional Bidders shall be reserved for Bidders with an application size of more than ₹0.20 million and up to ₹1.00 million and two-thirds shall be reserved for Bidders with an application size of more than ₹1.00 million, provided that the unsubscribed portion in either of the aforementioned sub-categories may be allocated to Bidders in the other sub-category) and not less than 35% of the Net Offer shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Bidders in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received from them at or above the Offer Price. Further, Equity Shares will be allocated on a proportionate basis to Eligible Employees applying under the Employee Reservation Portion, subject to valid Bids received from them at or above the Offer Price. All Bidders, other than Anchor Investors, are required to participate in the Offer by mandatorily utilising the Application Supported by Blocked Amount (“ASBA”) process by providing details of their respective ASBA Account (as defined hereinafter) and UPI ID in case of UPI Bidders (as defined hereinafter), as applicable, pursuant to which their corresponding Bid Amounts will be blocked by the SCSBs or by the Sponsor Banks under the UPI Mechanism, as the case may be, to the extent of respective Bid Amounts. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Offer through the ASBA process. For further details, see “Offer Procedure” on page 451 of the RHP.

Bidders/Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN, UPI ID and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID available for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorized the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Offer. Bidders/Applicants are

advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders/Applicants’ sole risk. Investors must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with the notification issued by Central Board of Direct Taxes notification dated February 13, 2020 and read with press releases dated June 25, 2021, March 30, 2022 and March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

Contents of the Memorandum of Association of our Company as regards its objects: For information on the main objects of our Company, investors are requested to see “History and Certain Corporate Matters” on page 265 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Offer. For further details, see “Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection” on page 538 of the RHP.

Liability of the members of our Company: Limited by shares.

Amount of Share Capital of our Company and Capital Structure: As on the date of the RHP, the authorized share capital of our Company is ₹300,000,000 comprising of 150,000,000 Equity Shares of face value ₹2 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up share capital of our Company is ₹125,469,702 comprising 62,734,851 Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each. For details of the capital structure of our Company, see “Capital Structure” on page 106 of the RHP.

Names of the Initial Signatories to the Memorandum of Association of our Company and the number of Equity Shares subscribed by them: The names of the initial signatories of the Memorandum of Association of our Company along with their allotment are: Anil Satwani, Manohar Satwani and Kashish Satwani were the initial subscribers to the MOA. For details of the share capital history and capital structure of our Company see “Capital Structure” on page 106 of the RHP.

Listing: The Equity Shares offered through the Red Herring Prospectus are proposed to be listed on the Stock Exchanges. Our Company has received ‘in-principle’ approvals from BSE and NSE for the listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to letters each dated February 4, 2026. For the purposes of the Offer, BSE Limited is the Designated Stock Exchange. A copy of the Red Herring Prospectus has been filed with the RoC and a copy of the Prospectus shall be filed with the RoC in accordance with Sections 26(4) and 32 of the Companies Act, 2013. For details of the material contracts and documents available for inspection from the date of the Red Herring Prospectus until the Bid / Offer Closing Date, see “Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection” on page 538 of the RHP.

Disclaimer Clause of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (“SEBI”): SEBI only gives its observations on the Draft Red Herring Prospectus and this does not constitute approval of either the Offer or the specified securities stated in the Offer Documents. The investors are advised to refer to page 424 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of the SEBI.

Disclaimer clause of the NSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Draft Red Herring Prospectus has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Draft Red Herring Prospectus. The investors are advised to refer to page 427 of the RHP for the full text of disclaimer clause of NSE.

Disclaimer clause of the BSE (Designated Stock Exchange): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Draft Red Herring Prospectus has been cleared or approved by the BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Draft Red Herring Prospectus. The investors are advised to refer to page 427 of the RHP for the full text of disclaimer clause of BSE.

General Risks: Investments in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in the Offer unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their entire investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved. The Equity Shares have not been recommended or approved by SEBI, nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the Draft Red Herring Prospectus. Specific attention of the investors is invited to “Risk Factors” on page 28 of the Red Herring Prospectus.

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS				REGISTRAR TO THE OFFER	COMPANY SECRETARY AND COMPLIANCE OFFICER
 JM Financial	 Avendus[^] Next is the only level	 Motilal Oswal Investment Banking	 NOMURA	 MUFG MUFG Intime	Salil Jain, 385/2, Pigdamber, Rau, Mhow, Indore – 453 331, Madhya Pradesh, India; Email: secretarial@symbiotec.com
JM Financial Limited 7th Floor, Energy Appasaheb Marathe Marg Prabhadevi, Mumbai 400 025, Maharashtra, India Telephone: +91 22 6630 3030 E-mail: symbiotec.ipo@jmfi.com Investor Grievance email: grievance.ibd@jmfi.com Website: www.jmfi.com Contact Person: Prachee Dhuri SEBI Registration No.: INM000010361	Avendus Capital Private Limited Platina Building, 9th Floor, 901, Plot No C-59, Bandra Kuria Complex, Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 051, Maharashtra, India Telephone: +91 22 6648 0050 E-mail: symbiotec.ipo@avendus.com Investor grievance email: investorgrievance@avendus.com Website: www.avendus.com Contact person: Sarthak Sawa / Ananya Chawla SEBI Registration No: INM000011021	Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited** Motilal Oswal Tower, Rahimthulla Sayani Road, Opposite Parel ST Depot, Prabhadevi, Mumbai – 400 025, Maharashtra, India Telephone: +91 22 7193 4380 E-mail: sp.ipo@motilaloswal.com Investor Grievance E-mail: moaipredressal@motilaloswal.com Website: www.motilaloswal.com Contact Person: Kunal Thakkar/Vaibhav Shah SEBI Registration No.: INM000011005	Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited Ceejay House, Level 11, Plot F, Shiv Sagar Estate, Dr. Annie Besant Marg, Worli, Mumbai – 400 018, Maharashtra, India Telephone: +91 22 4037 4037 E-mail: symbiotecipo@nomura.com Investor Grievance E-mail: investorgrievances-in@nomura.com Website: www.nomuraholdings.com/company/group/asia/india/index.html Contact Person: Vishal Kanjani / Chirag Shah SEBI Registration No.: INM000011419	MUFG Intime India Private Limited (Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited) C-101, Embassy 247, L.B.S. Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai 400 083, Maharashtra, India Telephone: +91 810 811 4949 E-mail: symbiotecpharmalab.ipo@in.mpmms.mufg.com Investor grievance email: symbiotecpharmalab.ipo@in.mpmms.mufg.com Website: www.in.mpmms.mufg.com Contact person: Shanti Gopalkrishnan SEBI Registration No: INR000004058	Bidders may contact the Company Secretary and Compliance Officer, the BRLMs or the Registrar to the Offer in case of any Pre-Offer or Post-Offer related problems, such as non-receipt of letters of Allotment, non-credit of Allotted Equity Shares in the respective beneficiary account, non-receipt of refund orders or non-receipt of funds by electronic mode. For all Offer-related queries and for redressal of complaints, investors may also write to the BRLMs.

[^]In compliance with the proviso to regulation 21A(1) and explanation (iii) to regulation 21A(1) of the SEBI Merchant Bankers Regulations, and regulation 23(3) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited will be involved only in marketing the Offer. Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited has signed the due diligence certificate and has been disclosed as a BRLM for the Offer.

**In compliance with the proviso to regulation 21A(1) and explanation (iii) to regulation 21A(1) of the SEBI Merchant Bankers Regulations, and regulation 23(3) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited will be involved only in marketing the Offer. Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited has signed the due diligence certificate and has been disclosed as a BRLM for the Offer.

AVAILABILITY OF RHP: Investors should note that investment in Equity Shares involves a high degree of risk and investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the Risk Factors contained herein, before applying in the Offer. Full copy of the RHP shall be available at the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, the website of Stock Exchanges at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com the website of our Company at www.symbiotec.com and the website of BRLMs, i.e., JM Financial Limited at www.jmfi.com, Avendus Capital Private Limited at www.avendus.com, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswal.com and Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited at www.nomuraholdings.com/company/group/asia/india/index.html.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS: A copy of the Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of our Company at www.symbiotec.com, the BRLMs, i.e., JM Financial Limited at www.jmfi.com, Avendus Capital Private Limited at www.avendus.com, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswal.com and Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited at www.nomuraholdings.com/company/group/asia/india/index.html respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID CUM APPLICATION FORMS: Application forms can be obtained from the Registered Office of our Company Symbiotec Pharmalab Limited, Tel: +91 731 667 6405 and the BRLM – JM Financial Limited, Tel: +91 22 6630 3030, Avendus Capital Private Limited, Tel: +91 22 6648 0050, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited Tel: +91 22 7193 4380 and Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited, Tel: +91 22 4037 4037.

SYNDICATE MEMBER: JM Financial Services Limited, Tel: +91 22 8136 3400, Spark Institutional Equities

Private Limited, Tel: +91 22 6885 4503/ +91 44 4344 0078/ +91 99209 31711 and Motilal Oswal Financial Services Limited, Tel: +91 22 7193 4200/ +91 22 7193 4263 and the selection locations of the Sub-application Members (as given below), SCSBs, Registered Brokers, RTAs and CDPs participating in the Offer. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of BSE and NSE and the Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of which is available at websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

APPLICATIONS SUPPORTED BY BLOCKED AMOUNT (ASBA): Investors have to apply through the ASBA process. ASBA has to be availed by all the investors. For details on ASBA process, please refer to the details given in the ASBA Form and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to “Offer Procedure” on page 451 of the RHP. Further ASBA Application forms can be obtained from Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of banks that are available on website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in and website of Stock Exchanges at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com. The investors are required to fill the Bid Cum Application form and submit the same to the relevant SCSBs at the specific locations or registered brokers at the broker centers or RTA or DP’s. The SCSB’s will block the amount in the account as per the authority contained in application form. On allotment, amount will be unblocked and account will be debited only to the extent required to be paid for allotment of shares. Hence, there will be no need of refund.

UPI: UPI Bidders can also Bid through UPI Mechanism.

SUB-SYNDICATE MEMBERS: Spaisa Capital Limited, Alankit Imaginations Limited, Almondz Global Securities Limited, Ambit Capital Limited, Anand Rathn Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Arhant Capital Markets Limited, Asti C. Mehta Investment Intermediates Limited, Axis Capital Limited, Bajaj Financial Securities Limited, Centrum Finserve

Limited, DALAL & BROACHA STOCK BROKING PVT Limited, Eureka Stock & Share Broking Services Limited, Finwizard Technology Private Limited, Globe Capital Market Limited, HDFC SECURITIES Limited, ICICI SECURITIES Limited, IDBI Capital Market Services Limited, IIFL Capital Services Limited, Kantilal Chhaganlal Securities Pvt. Limited, Keynote Capitals Ltd, KJMC Capital Market Services Limited, Kotak Securities Limited, LKP Securities Limited, Nuvama Wealth and Investment Limited, Pantomath Financial Services Limited, Prabhudas Lilladhar Pvt Limited, Pravin Ratilal Share And Stock Brokers Limited, Religare Securities Limited, RR Equity Brokers Pvt. Limited, SBICAP Securities Limited, Sharekhan Limited, SMC Global Securities Limited, SS Corporate Securities Limited, Standard Chartered Securities, TradeBulls Securities (P) Limited, Trust Securities Limited, Upstox Securities Private Limited and YES Securities (India) Limited.

Bankers to the Offer: Escrow Collection Bank, Refund Bank: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited

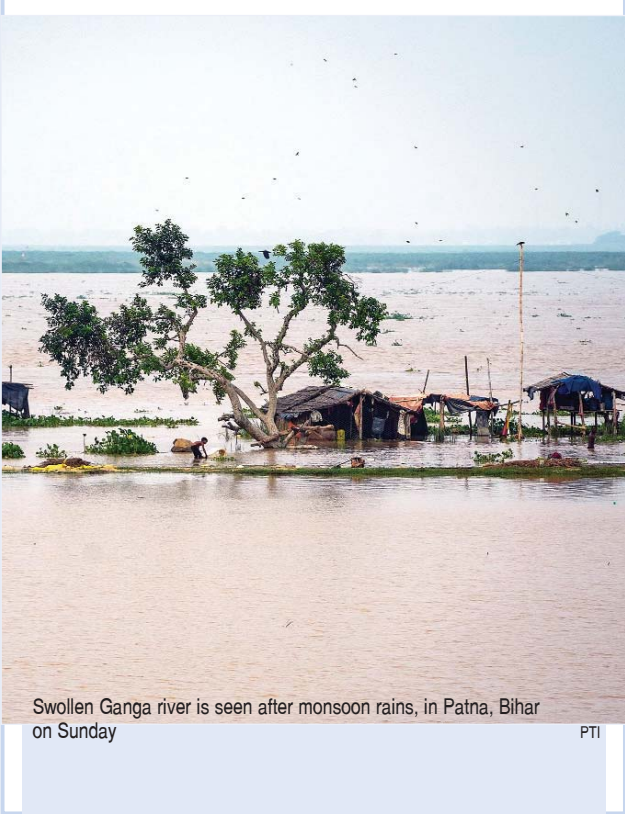
Public Offer Account Bank: Axis Bank Limited | Sponsor Bank: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and Axis Bank Limited. All capitalized terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them in RHP.

For Symbiotec Pharmalab Limited
On behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-

Place: Madhya Pradesh, India
Date: August 21, 2026

Symbiotec Pharmalab Limited is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to undertake an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with the Registrar of Companies, Madhya Pradesh at Gwalior, SEBI and the Stock Exchanges on August 18, 2026. The RHP is to be read with Addendum to the RHP dated August 19, 2026 (“Addendum”) which is available on the websites of the Company i.e. www.symbiotec.com and SEBI, BSE and NSE at www.sebi.gov.in, www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, and on the website of the Book Running Lead Managers i.e. JM Financial Limited at www.jmfi.com, Avendus Capital Private Limited at www.avendus.com, Motilal Oswal Investment

IN FOCUS



Swollen Ganga river is seen after monsoon rains, in Patna, Bihar on Sunday

PTI

UP-Japan ties to deepen through green hydrogen, energy security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Varanasi (UP)

Yamanashi Governor Kotaro Nagasaki on Sunday said ties between Japan's Yamanashi Prefecture and Uttar Pradesh would be strengthened further, with cooperation in green hydrogen, energy security and other sectors aimed at promoting development and contributing to world peace.

"We wish to advance cooperation in several important sectors together with Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath. One of these important initiatives is to promote the development of Uttar Pradesh and Yamanashi Prefecture through a green hydrogen system. Along with this, our desire is also to contribute to



Yamanashi Governor Kotaro Nagasaki with UP CM Yogi Adityanath

the establishment of world peace through energy security," Nagasaki said.

The governor was interacting with the media on Sunday after offering prayers at Baba Vishwanath along with the Japanese delegation, the Uttar Pradesh gov-

ernment said in a statement.

"By coming here, one can clearly feel the devotion and respect that all of you have towards God. I too have prayed here for world peace," he said.

Under Nagasaki's leadership, about 15 prominent

members of the Japanese delegation visited Shri Kashi Vishwanath Dham, offered prayers to Baba Vishwanath, and sought blessings.

Devotees welcomed the Japanese guests with chants of "Har Har Mahadev" upon their arrival at the temple, and members of the delegation joined in the chanting, showcasing the warmth of India-Japan cultural relations on the temple grounds.

On Saturday, the Japanese guests experienced the spiritual essence of the grand Baba Vishwanath Dham and visited Sarnath, where Lord Buddha delivered his teachings. Later that evening, they participated in the Ganga Aarti at Namoh Ghat, immersing themselves in Kashi's spiritual and cultural heritage.

ED arrests ex-Andhra minister Nageswara in liquor transport scam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

The Enforcement Directorate on Sunday arrested former Andhra Pradesh minister Karumuri Nageswara Rao in a money laundering case linked to alleged irregularities in transport of liquor during the previous YSRC Government, officials said.

Rao was taken into custody under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), they said.

In June, the central probe agency had arrested his son Karumuri Sunil Kumar in this case after the premises of the father-son duo were raided.

Rao has served as the



civil supplies minister in the previous YS Jagan Mohan Reddy Government. The probe pertains to an allegation that the accused persons caused wrongful loss to the tune of Rs 195.33 crore to the Government exchequer through financial irregularities in the transport of liquor in the State.

A case was registered by the ED under the PMLA in May to probe these charges.

ED raids IAS officer in Karnataka exam money laundering case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru/New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Sunday raided the premises of IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar in Bengaluru and Bareilly in connection with a money laundering investigation linked to alleged irregularities in an exam conducted by the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC), officials said.

Gangwar is a 2016-batch IAS officer and is currently posted as Director-MSME in the Karnataka Department of Industries and Commerce. He earlier served as the Controller of Examinations at the KPSC and was replaced in March this year.

Officials said Gangwar's premises in Bengaluru's Jayamahal area and UP's Bareilly were searched under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). It was not immediately known if the officer was found on the premises by the central agency. A controversy erupted on Saturday after Gangwar was reported missing for a few hours. Later, Karnataka Home Minister Priyank



IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar, who earlier served as the Controller of Examinations at the KPSC

PIONEER PHOTO

Kharge denied the reports and clarified that Gangwar was in his native place in UP following a family emergency involving his father's health.

The probe is linked to a money laundering investigation into a Veterinary Officers recruitment exam 'scam'. It is alleged by the ED that some middlemen called the candidates, including the complainant, and demanded bribes ranging from Rs 70 lakh to Rs 80 lakh

(per candidate) for selection.

Additionally, the agency is looking into allegations of paper leak, OMR answer sheet tampering and facilitation in final selection of relatives of KPSC officials, ED officials had said. Last week, the Karnataka Cabinet decided to recommend to Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot the suspension of KPSC Chairman Shivashankarappa Sahukar.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's wife, Gurpreet Kaur, rejected charges that she sought ₹5 crore to suppress a rape case, challenging her accusers to either prove them or face legal action.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of a Teej function in Patiala on Sunday, Gurpreet Kaur termed them baseless and said she was not scared of such accusations and was prepared to face them.

"I think it is easy to level baseless allegations. I am fully prepared to face these baseless allegations. I was not scared earlier nor am I now. I challenge them (those who are levelling such charges) that either they prove what they are claiming or be prepared to face legal action," she said in her first public response to the allegations.

The development follows a notice issued by the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) to the Punjab government and its police chief over a complaint alleging that Mann's



wife demanded ₹5 crore to suppress a rape case.

Subsequently, Gurpreet Kaur, according to AAP MLA Amandeep Kaur, on Saturday

sent a legal notice to a former Punjab and Haryana High Court judge in connection with the allegations.

The notice sought an

2 inmates arrested under POCSO escape from Srinagar jail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Two inmates booked in separate cases under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act escaped from the Central Jail here on Sunday after scaling the front-side wall of the high-security prison, officials said.

The escaped inmates have been identified as Farman Khan, a resident of Sadanpora, Rajasthan, and Mukhtar Ahmed Gujar, a resident of Sanglan Chittergul in south Kashmir's Anantnag district, the officials said.

A massive manhunt was launched to trace and apprehend the escaped inmates, they said, adding that further details regarding the cir-



cumstances of their escape from the jail were awaited.

The jail is guarded by personnel of the Central Industrial Security Force

(CISF), who were deployed to provide armed cover to the facility in October 2023 along with the Central Jail in Jammu. The force is responsible for

securing both the inner and outer perimeters of these sensitive facilities through a combination of trained manpower, modern surveillance systems and access control measures.

According to the officials, Khan was lodged in the Srinagar jail on June 23 in connection with an FIR registered against him at Lar police station in Jammu and Kashmir's Ganderbal district under various sections of the BNS and sections 3 and 4 (penetrative sexual assault) of the POCSO Act.

Similarly, Gujar was lodged in jail on April 13 in connection with a separate FIR registered at Srinagar's Soura police station under various sections of the BNS and sections 3 and 4 of the POCSO Act, they said.

Is Government planning a Parliament return?

Speculation over the Government's next move on the delimitation-linked women's reservation Bill has refused to die down after Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay raised the issue at the August 21 Southern Zonal Council meeting in Mahabalipuram, which was chaired by Shah. "I urge the Union Government to provide a clear legislative assurance that no State will suffer a reduction in its percentage of representation in Parliament on account of its success in population stabilisation," Vijay had said.

His remarks indicated a shift from the categorical opposition to delimitation through the resolution he moved in the Tamil Nadu Assembly on August 12. However, Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, who also attended the Mahabalipuram meeting, demanded that the Government retain the existing number of Lok Sabha seats -- 543 -- for the next 25 years.

Adani-Shivakumar meet sparks BJP ire

Isn't this a double standard," Ashoka, Leader of the Opposition in the Karnataka Assembly, said. He said the Karnataka government had "laid out a red carpet" for Adani.

Askoka urged Shivakumar to tell Rahul Gandhi that Adani was a businessman and was only doing business.

He also took a swipe at Rahul Gandhi, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, over his environmental activism, asking him to come to Bengaluru and hug a tree at Lalbagh or Sankey Tank, which will be affected by the proposed Tunnel Road. The BJP has been opposing Tunnel Road, especially party MP Tejasvi Surya, who has even approached the Karnataka High Court on this issue.

Arunachal Pradesh's raging rivers become...

He referred to a conversation with Rijiju again while speaking in the Lok Sabha during the Budget session in February. Rahul Gandhi said Rijiju had once asked him how he remained fit and that he had told the minister about his practice of jiu-jitsu. Gandhi then used the martial art to make a political point, describing how a fighter establishes a "grip", moves to a "choke" and eventually forces the opponent to "tap".

The exchange continued in June after Rijiju

wished Rahul Gandhi on his 56th birthday. "Thank you for the warm wishes, Kiren Rijiju ji. When are we doing our jiu-jitsu session?" Gandhi had responded.

Nabin holds key meet to map BJP's poll strategy

During the meeting on Sunday, Nabin also reviewed the status of various programmes currently being conducted by the party and discussed measures to ensure their effective implementation and wider outreach. The discussions were part of the BJP's broader organisational strategy to strengthen its grassroots presence, expand membership base and intensify public outreach ahead of Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Uttarakhand, Goa and Manipur in early 2027.

This comes a day after Nabin held his first meeting with all newly appointed national office bearers of the party.

After the day-long meeting concluded on Saturday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi also visited the BJP headquarters and interacted with all 67 newly-appointed national office bearers of the party. The prime minister's meeting lasted for more than five hours.

NSA Doval heads to Beijing for border talks

There has been no official confirmation of Xi's visit so far. However, officials on both sides are optimistic about his participation. If the visit goes ahead, it could provide an opportunity for Xi and Prime Minister Narendra Modi to meet on the sidelines of the summit and discuss measures to further stabilise and strengthen bilateral ties.

The two leaders last met in August last year on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Tianjin.

Ahead of the Doval-Wang meeting, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Saturday stressed that peace and tranquillity along the border areas remain a prerequisite for improving relations between India and China.

His remarks came amid reports of increased Chinese military activity and aggressive posturing in Arunachal Pradesh's Upper Subansiri region in recent weeks.

"We went through a particularly bad patch between the summer of 2020 and the autumn of 2024, and that was primarily an outcome of the situation in the border areas," Jaishankar said at the *Economic Times* World Leaders Forum in

New Delhi.

"At the end of the day, peace and tranquillity in the border areas is a prerequisite for good relations, and the state of the border, to a very large measure, naturally would determine the state of the relations," he said.

China has maintained that the situation along the border is currently stable. Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun said on August 12 that the China-India border situation was "generally stable at the moment".

Guo also said that the two countries had held the 36th meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on China-India Border Affairs.

According to him, both sides agreed to maintain communication through diplomatic and military channels and jointly safeguard peace and tranquillity in the border areas.

India, meanwhile, has repeatedly underlined the importance of maintaining peace along the Line of Actual Control (LAC).

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on August 11 that India regards matters concerning the border areas with China as "most serious" and that maintaining peace and tranquillity along the LAC is of "utmost importance". He also asserted that the situation along the frontier would determine the overall trajectory of India-China relations.

The latest round of tensions comes against the backdrop of continuing differences over Arunachal Pradesh.

New Delhi has rejected China's objections to India's decision to formally identify 27 places and geographical features in the state by their standard names.

India has repeatedly maintained that Arunachal Pradesh is an "inalienable and integral" part of the country and that such naming exercises by China cannot alter that reality.

China claims Arunachal Pradesh as part of what it calls South Tibet and has, since 2017, periodically issued its own names for locations in the Indian state. New Delhi has dismissed the Chinese move as "vain and preposterous", maintaining that such actions cannot change the fact that Arunachal Pradesh "was, is, and will" remain an integral part of India.

Against this backdrop, the Doval-Wang talks are expected to focus on maintaining stability along the LAC and sustaining the broader dialogue on the boundary issue, while the two countries seek to consolidate a gradual improvement in bilateral ties following the tensions that erupted after the 2020 border crisis.

Gujarati man shot dead in US store

Before escaping, the suspect fired several shots inside the premises, striking Patel, who was pronounced dead at the scene.

Police said the suspect was a Black male wearing a grey hoodie, jeans and black work-style boots. His face was concealed by a paintball-style mask. He reportedly fled in a white sedan. The shooting also injured a 70-year-old employee, who fell during the incident and suffered a fractured wrist. Patel's daughter, who was reportedly next to her father when the shooting occurred, was not injured.

Patel was originally from Akhaj village in Kadi taluka of Mehsana district, Gujarat. Local reports said his family had taken over the store only days before the shooting.

Police have launched an investigation and appealed to the public for information that could help identify the suspect and locate the vehicle used in the getaway. The killing has renewed concerns over the safety of Indian-origin convenience-store and business owners in the United States, particularly those working late hours and operating establishments that can become targets for armed robberies.

Patel's death is also the latest in a series of fatal attacks involving people of Gujarati origin in the US. In May 2025, 30-year-old Paresh alias Prince Patel was reportedly shot dead during a robbery at a Tennessee gas station. In another recent incident, Gujarati woman Meghna Patel was shot dead inside her store in Norfolk, Virginia. In September 2025, Kiran Patel, originally from the Charotar region of Gujarat, was shot in a parking lot after confronting an armed robber.

Authorities are continuing to investigate the circumstances surrounding Patel's death, including the suspect's identity and motive.

Goldy Brar allegedly claims Nijjar killing...

Brar says the killing was both revenge and a way to remove a rival who mixed separatism with drugs. Some reports mention personal reasons. Brar believes people connected to Nijjar were involved in the murder of his brother, Gurlal, and that some of them lived in properties linked to Nijjar. India has called Nijjar a terrorist and linked him to the Khalistan Tiger Force. He was shot and murdered in the parking lot of the Guru Nanak Sikh Gurdwara on June 18-19, 2023.

Reacting to the murder, the then-Prime Minister Justin Trudeau accused Indian agents,

leading to expulsions, suspended trade talks, and strong statements from both countries. New Delhi called the accusations absurd and said the death was due to ongoing gang rivalries among the diaspora, challenging earlier claims.

Brar has been involved in gangs in both Punjab and North America.

US indictments released earlier this year named him and Bishnoi as those who ordered the Surrey killing as part of a larger organised crime network across Canada, the United States, and other countries.

Neither the Canadian nor Indian government has released a statement yet. Alleged confession supports what investigations have been finding: Nijjar's murder was not just a political act, but part of a gangwar.

Delhi minor missing after drain fall

According to the Delhi Fire Service, information about the incident was received at 11.54 am on Saturday, following which two fire tenders were dispatched to the spot and a search operation was launched.

Mithun's aunt, Kusum, questioned the initial response to the incident, alleging delays in the rescue effort. "If the police had put efforts to rescue him then, then he could have been saved. The police came to the accident scene twice since 11 am yesterday but couldn't rescue him," she said. The family originally hailed from Badaun in Uttar Pradesh and had moved to Delhi in search of work. Mithun is the youngest of four siblings, with one sister and two brothers.

The NDRF resumed its search operation on Sunday, combing through the drain and adjoining stretches in an effort to locate the teenager. However, no trace of Mithun has been found so far, and his body has not been recovered as of the latest update.

Officials said the search operation would continue until the boy is located, with teams working through the drain's flow and adjoining areas in coordination with district authorities. The open nature of the drain, combined with the continuous water flow, has made the recovery effort particularly challenging for rescue personnel involved in the search.

As the search entered its second day, family members remained at the site, anxiously awaiting updates from the rescue teams. Authorities have not provided a timeline for when the search operation might conclude, given the ongoing challenges posed by the water flow in the drain.

GRAPEVINE

Education ministry’s distinction

Union Education Ministry, over the decade, has earned the rare distinction that neither the Minister nor any of its Secretaries could complete their tenure. Smriti Irani, Prakash Javadekar, Ramesh Pokhriyal Nishank, and Dharmendra Pradhan all had an abrupt end, surrounded by some of the controversies. Nonetheless, the Education Secretaries, except for Amit Khare (now Secretary to the VP of India) and Sanjay Kumar, who got embroiled in controversy due to the CBSE OSM issue, superannuated in June 2026. He, however, missed the bus for a further assignment committed at the Centre, according to grapevines. R Subramanyam was removed as Education Secretary over JNU controversy, SN Mohanty was transferred allegedly due to autonomy issues of IITs and confrontation with then Minister in this regard, Vinay Sheel Oberoi too could not finish tenure and KK Sharma was appointed OSD Education one day before his transfer, Ashok Thakur too confronted the govt during the fag end of his career saving his scalp with the sarcasm ‘go play and golf’ and the latest to fall victim was another high profile career-bureaucrat Vineet Joshi.

My Adani vs your Adani

Industrialist Gautam Adani must be enjoying various political parties playing My Adani Vs Your Adani syndrome. While Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi was blaming Adani for everything to attack PM Narendra Modi, Congress ruled States Karnataka and Kerala are rolling out red carpet for him. While Adani was given rousing reception in Karnataka in connection with a multi-crore road project, Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy was publishing a full page advertisement in newspapers against Adani’s project, accusing huge corruption with Shivakumar’s Congress Govt. Previous week, Kerala Govt was all out reception to Adani for his port projects Customs Terminal inauguration project. Nonetheless Congress ruled State of Himachal Pradesh and party supported JMM-led Jharkhand Govt have also projects from the baskets of Adani and the concerned CMs maintain silence not to annoy Rahul’s anti-Adani ideology.

QRTs to counter fake contents

In the age of multiple social media platforms which goes viral within seconds, the Government has asked all ministries and departments to urgently set up Quick Response Teams (QRTs) to detect fake content on social media in real time. Sources said that the QRT will be an independent boy to be headed by a Joint Secretary level officer and the hunt is on, a recent Government communication stated that the QRTs should detect fake content related to their respective ministries and departments and post a response on their official social media handles within two hours of the origin of the fake or misleading content. Concerns were raised that rumours spread rapidly on social media and hence there is a need for quick official response.

Rahul Gandhi as Batman!

Posters calling Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi “the real life Batman” were put up near the Congress’ Indira Bhawan headquarters and in parts of central Delhi by a party functionary. The posters has Rahul Gandhi’s picture alongside the picture of Batman. They had the captions “The Silent Guardian” and “A Watchful Protector” written on them. The other caption on the posters was “LOP Rahul Gandhi – The Real Life Batman”. The posters come days after Rahul Gandhi, during an ‘Ask Me Anything’ session on Instagram, had given a witty response to the poser – Are you Batman. Rahul had answered, equally straight up, sidestepping any comparison to the caped crusader: “Let’s just say that no one has ever seen me and Batman in the same room together.” “Ask me anything,” he said in a fresh outreach to Gen Z. And they did, the questions had poured in right through the session on Instagram.

24 tribal children die in MP’s Balaghat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Nearly two dozen children from the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group Baiga community have reportedly died in Balaghat district’s Birsra block amid an outbreak of illnesses including measles, malaria and malnutrition, triggering concern over healthcare conditions in the remote tribal belt.

Local tribal representatives have claimed that 24 children have died in affected villages, while the district administration has officially linked eight deaths to seasonal illnesses since June. Officials have said malaria and measles were among the major causes, while some other deaths were attributed to genetic or unrelated medical conditions.

Protesting against the deaths, members of Sarv Adivasi Samaj took out a rally on Sunday evening and demanded action against officials allegedly responsi-



ble for lapses in healthcare and disease prevention.

Tribal woman representative Sandesh Saiyam said substantial funds were allocated for tribal welfare, yet communities in remote areas continued to face inadequate development and healthcare access.

The organisation demanded immediate financial assistance for families of the deceased children and said the situation in several affected villages remained

serious. The deaths have been reported from villages under Adori, Machhorda, Lalpur, Ghummur and other gram panchayats in the Birsra development block.

The affected children belonged largely to Baiga families living in remote forested areas where access to health facilities remains difficult.

Government data cited in recent reports also indicate nutritional concerns. Of 1,149 children below six years

weighed across 28 Anganwadi centres in the affected region in July, 213 were found moderately underweight and 18 severely underweight. Officials said 125 affected children had recovered and been discharged, while several others were undergoing treatment.

The state Government has intensified health surveillance in the region. Senior officials have visited affected villages in Birsra and Baihar blocks and reviewed nutrition, sanitation and healthcare arrangements.

Authorities have also been directed to monitor malnourished children, strengthen regular health check-ups and ensure safe drinking water and sanitation.

Special vaccination and disease-control drives are also being carried out in the affected villages. The Government is continuing medical screening and treatment as officials work to determine the exact cause behind each reported death.

Assam in final stage of partner selection to build satellite, says Himanta



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

The Assam Government is in an advanced stage of evaluation to select a partner from the private sector to launch its own satellite, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said on Sunday.

Claiming that Assam will be the first state in India to have its own earth observation system, he said that the Government will have the satellite under the “DBLOTT model”, which is design, build, launch, operate, train and transfer.

“Earlier this year, we invited Expressions of Interest to select an implementation partner under the DBLOTT model (Design, Build, Launch, Operate, Train & Transfer).

“Following strong interest from India’s private space sector companies, we are now in the final and critical stage of partner selection, with dedicated committees evaluating the proposals,” Sarma said in a social media post.

He said ‘AssamSAT’ marks a landmark shift — from Assam being a user of satellite data to an active participant in the space-tech ecosystem, enabling faster and evidence-based governance.

Heavy rain lashes Odisha; flash floods in Hati River

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Flash floods were reported in the embankments of the Hati River in Odisha’s Kalahandi district on Sunday amid low pressure-triggered heavy rainfall across the state that also prompted the administrations of two other districts to announce school holidays the next day, officials said.

Under the impact of the low-pressure area in north-western Bay of Bengal, heavy rainfall is expected in several districts of Odisha till August



26, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said.

Authorities released 412 cuses of water from the Mangalpur Barrage of the Indravati Project into Hati River, which was already in spate, causing flash floods in

its embankments this morning, officials said.

Floodwaters entered low-lying areas of Talpada, Bankapala and Jampadar villages under Kalampur block. The block administration, led by BDO

Vijay Kumar Marandi, rescued 293 people from both Paruaguda and Bodelbandh villages and provided them with free ration, an official said.

Road communication from Junagarh to Kalampur and Thuamul Rampur Road to Kashipur has been disrupted due to heavy rain.

In view of the rainfall forecast, district administrations have announced that all schools and anganwadi centres in Nabarangpur, and 89 schools in vulnerable areas of Bhadrak would remain closed on Monday.

 सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India 1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911		Regional Office Delhi (North) 1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk, Delhi-110006		E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE (Under SARFAESI Act 2002)											
APPENDIX- IV-A (SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES															
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.															
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the Central Bank of India (secured creditor), the constructive/ physical Possession of which have been taken by the authorized officer of Central Bank of India(Secured creditors), will be sold on “As is where is”, “As is what is” and “whatever there is” basis on date 11.09.2026 for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and Earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties.															
E-AUCTION SCHEDULED TO BE HELD ON 11.09.2026 (15 DAY'S NOTICE)															
S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer / B.M.	Name of the Account Property ID on E-Baanknet Portal	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (In Rupees)	Date & Type of Possession	In Rupees Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase								
1.	Arthala Ghaziabad	Mr. Naveen Kumar Mobile: 9220402685	CHANDER KALI CBIN402401	Flat No SF-2, Lig, Second Floor, Back Side, Plot No. A-2/15, DLF Ankur Vihar, Loni, District Ghaziabad-Uttar Pradesh. Area 37.16 Sq Mtr Owner: Chander Kali	20.09.2021 Rs.8.90 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	21.07.2022 (Physical)	₹ 7,92,000.00 ₹ 79,200.00 ₹ 10,000.00	12.	Patel Nagar Ghaziabad	Mr. Vinod Meena Mob: 9694707646	Soniya CBIN402508	Residential Flat No. Nyaykhand-3/487, E.W.S Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Indirapuram Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area-24.65 Sq Mtr Owner- Ms. Soniya W/O Vikram Singh	01.03.2025 Rs.9.67 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	05.12.2025 (Physical)	₹ 9,90,000.00 ₹ 99,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
2.	Bhagirath Palace Delhi	Mr. Sandeep Kumar Mobile: 9999463960	DHARMENDRA CBIN028704	Shop No. C-30, Ground Floor, Block-B, Brij Vihar, Sector-8, Ghaziabad. Area 12.34 Sq M Owner: Dharmendra Kumar	01.08.2019 Rs.7.76 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	15.05.2025 (Physical)	₹ 12,00,000.00 ₹ 1,20,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00	13.	Patparganj New Delhi	Mr Mohit Kumar Mobile: 8800013534	Shefali Aqua Solution CBIN166901	First Floor (Adjoining To Property No. 87), Without Roof Rights,Part Of Property Bearing No. 86 Out Of Khasra No.5/30, Situated In Layout Plan Of Ram Nagar In The Area Of Village Khureji Khas, Illaqa Shahdara, Delhi-110051,Area- 85 Sq Yard Owner- Sapna W/o Rakesh Kumar	26.10.2018 Rs.29.28 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	12.01.2026 (Physical)	₹ 36,65,000.00 ₹ 3,66,500.00 ₹ 25,000.00
3.	Daryaganj New Delhi	Mr. Swati Kumari Mobile: 7428926731	Mohd Nafees 3a-Fit Jeans CBIN029006	First Floor, Pvt Flat No 202, C-1410, Central Portion, Without Roof/Terrace Rights, Kabir Nagar, Gali No 08, Block-C, 33 Ft. Road, Babarpur, Shahdara, Delhi-110094. Area 549 Sq Ft Owner: Mohd. Nafees & Mohd. Waseem	30.07.2017 Rs.26.11 Lakh + Rs.3.11 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	26.02.2018 (Physical)	₹ 14,30,000.00 ₹ 1,43,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00	14.	Pitampura New Delhi	Ms. Poonam Kumari Mobile: 8383803088	Feba Sabu & Subhin T CBIN3490001	First Floor No.203 Without Roof/Terrace Rights Built On Property Bearing Plot No. B-63, Admeasuring 57.25 Sq Yard I.E 47.87 Sq Mtr(Out Of 229 Sq Yard) Out Of Khasra No.317 Situated In The Revenue Estate Of Village Bindapur Area Abadi Known As Colony Sanjay Enclave , Uttam Nagar New Delhi -110059 Area-515.25 Sq Ft Owner -Smt Febu Sabu & Sh. Subhin T	03.02.2025 Rs.16.86 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	27.10.2025 (Physical)	₹ 18,90,000.00 ₹ 1,89,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
4.	Daryaganj New Delhi	Mr. Swati Kumari Mobile: 7428926731	Amit Kumar CBIN029005	Flat No-301, 2nd Floor, Front Side, MIG, Deep Apartments-VI, Plot No. A-4/18, DLF Ankur Vihar, Loni, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201102 Area 750 Sq Ft. Owner: Amit Kumar	10.04.2019 Rs.12.59 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	04.06.2022 (Physical)	₹ 14,95,000.00 ₹ 1,49,500.00 ₹ 15,000.00	15.	Sadar Bazar Delhi	Mr. Sanny Kumar Mobile: 8800013540	Amit Saini & Vandana Saini CBIN029301	Flat Bearing No. J-44/ SL-4 On Second Floor Without Roof Rights, Area Measuring 600 Sq Feet, Under Lig Category Situated At Dilshad Garden Extension No 1 Now Known As Dilshad Colony, Village- Jhilmil Tahirpur, Shahdara, Delhi- 110095. Area: 55.74 Sq Mt Owner- Amit Saini And Vandana Saini	17.02.2021 Rs.31.03 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	30.12.2024 (Physical)	₹ 16,80,000.00 ₹ 1,68,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
5.	Ghaziabad	Mr. Bhawani Deen Mobile: 9999467102	Manish Pandey CBIN025702	Ground Floor, Residential Builder Flat No- GF-3 (Back/ Northern Portion), Plot No- D-9/12, DLF Ankur Vihar, Ghaziabad- 201102. Area- 58.53 Sq Mtr Owner- Manish Pandey	30.01.2023 Rs.7.91 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	19.08.2023 (Physical)	₹ 6,85,000.00 ₹ 68,500.00 ₹ 10,000.00	16.	I.T. Park Usmanpur Delhi	Mr. Husnain Ali Mobile: 9568431985	Deepak Tiwari CBIN3524001	Free Hold Residential Property Bearing No. A-113, Second Floor, Pvt Flat No. SF-1, Front Left Side (South West), With Roof /Terrace Rights, Situated At Colony Known As Sif Ved Vihar, Pargana Loni, Tehsil & Distt Ghaziabad , Uttar Pradesh, 201102. Area- 400 Sq Ft Owner- Sh. Deepak Tiwari S/o Shri Ganesh Tiwari	21.05.2024 Rs.11.29 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	19.07.2025 (Physical)	₹ 10,45,000.00 ₹ 1,04,500.00 ₹ 10,000.00
6.	Ghonda Delhi	Mr. Arvind Kumar Mobile: 9999917130	Prem Pal Bhardwaj CBIN127806	All Part And Parcel Of Built Uttar Pradesh Property, Constructed Of Whatsoever Uttar Pradesh on Property No. X-16, Land Area Measuring 100 Sq Yd Out Of Khasra No.142/2, X Block Vill- Ghonda, Street No.2, Gujran Banger , Abadi Brahampuri, Ilaga Shahdra Delhi. Area 100 Sq Yd Owner - Prem Pal Bhardwaj	30.08.2024 Rs.151.12 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	23.04.2025 (Physical)	₹ 1,13,50,000.00 ₹ 11,35,000.00 ₹ 1,00,000.00	17.	I.T. Park Usmanpur Delhi	Mr. Husnain Ali Mobile: 9568431985	Mushahid Alam CBIN3524002	Property Bearing No. F-32 & F-33, Ground Floor, Pvt Flat No. GF-2, Without Roof/Terrace Rights, Situated At Colony SLF Ved Vihar, Pargana Loni, Tehsil And Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh- 201102 Area - 400 Sq Ft Owner- Mushahid Alam S/o Jamshed Alam	28.05.2024 Rs.10.45 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	19.07.2025 (Physical)	₹ 10,40,000.00 ₹ 1,04,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
7.	Ghonda Delhi	Mr. Arvind Kumar Mobile: 9999917130	M/S Kartikey Trading Co. CBIN127801	Residential Third Floor, With Roof Rights, Part of Property No.1/2787, Near Krishna Dairy Ram Nagar, Mandoli Road, Shahdara, Delhi-110032. Area 429.70 Sq Ft Owner - Umesh Rani W/o Sanjeev Kumar Dubey	14.01.2022 Rs.13.75 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	19.04.2022 (Physical)	₹ 17,05,000.00 ₹ 1,70,500.00 ₹ 15,000.00	18.	Vasundhara Ghaziabad	Mr. Anand Jaiswal Mobile: 8800013545	Vishal Kumar Sharma CBIN497215	Residential Flat, 1st Floor (Without Roof Rights), Part of Rudra Niwas On Khasra No. 380, Indergarhi, Vill. And Paragna Dasna, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201001. Area 70 Sqm Owner: Vishal Kr Sharma And Premlata Sharma	02.09.2020 Rs.18.78 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	20.12.2021 (Physical)	₹ 14,40,000.00 ₹ 1,44,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
8.	Indirapuram Ghaziabad	Mr. Shruti Kumari Mobile: 8800013517	Ramesh Kumar CBIN374912	SF4-MIG, 2nd Floor Front Side With Roof Rights, Plot No. F33, SLF Ved Vihar Hadbast Village Sadullabad Pargana Loni Dasna Tehsil And District Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh. Area 65.03 Sq Metre Owner-Ramesh Kumar	01.07.2021 Rs.17.25 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	09.09.2021	₹ 13,11,000.00 ₹ 1,31,100.00 ₹ 15,000.00	19.	Vasundhara Ghaziabad	Mr. Anand Jaiswal Mobile: 8800013545	Anita Sharma CBIN497216	Residential Builder Flat, On Part of Khasra No.380, Out of Four Storey Building, Ground Floor, Without Roof Rights, Vill-Indergarhi, Paragna Dasna, Near Block-C, Govindpuram, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201001, Area 60 SqMt Owner - Anita Sharma	29.02.2020 Rs.21.30 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	16.11.2021 (Physical)	₹ 15,60,000.00 ₹ 1,56,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
9.	Indirapuram Ghaziabad	Mr. Shruti Kumari Mobile: 8800013517	Bhairab Ghosh CBIN3749001	Residential Builder Flat, 2nd Floor, Flat No. S-2, Plot No. 88, Shalimar Garden Extension-1, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, Area- 520 Sq Feet Owner- Mr. Bhairab Ghosh	21-10-2015 Rs.17.77 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	09.09.2017	₹ 12,50,000.00 ₹ 1,25,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00	E-AUCTION DATE: 11.09.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 04:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES							
10.	Kashmere Gate, Delhi	Mr. Arvind Kumar Mobile: 8318025882	Sahil (Taj Fruit Company) CBIN029103	First Floor Without Roof Rights Of Freehold Commercial Shop Bearing No. B- 183, Block- B, Area Measuring 636 Sq Ft, Situated At New Sabzi Mandi, Azadpur, Delhi- 110033 Owner- Taj Fruit Company	26.12.2023 Rs.92.92 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	09.08.2024	₹ 65,70,000.00 ₹ 6,57,000.00 ₹ 50,000.00	Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 11.09.2026 Upto 03:30 PM.							
11.	Patel Nagar Ghaziabad	Mr. Vinod Meena Mobile: 9694707646	Sanjay Chaudhary CBIN402509	All That Part And Parcel Of Property In the name of Sanjay Chaudhary Bearing House No.875/C, 3rd Floor, Naya Khand-1, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, Pin-201014. Area- 209.95 SqFt Owner: Sanjay Chaudhary	11.11.2024 Rs.13.08 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	20.02.2026 (Physical)	₹ 11,40,000.00 ₹ 1,14,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00	Bidder will register on website: https://BAANKNET.com and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in BAANKNET EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer / Generation of challan from (https://BAANKNET.com).							
The auction will be conducted through common landing platform BAANKNET.com Portal (https://BAANKNET.com). E-auction will be held “As is where is”, “As is what is” and “whatever there is” basis. (All other charges/ dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).															
For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or auction platform (https://BAANKNET.com). Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com															
STATUTORY 15 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002															
Borrowers/Guarantors/ Mortgageors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.															
DATE: 23.08.2026															
PLACE: DELHI															
Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, RO Delhi (North), Delhi															

Central agencies issue SOP to Delhi Police on handling protests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Central agencies have created and shared a detailed advisory and Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) with Delhi Police on how to handle protesters, especially younger demonstrators who record interactions for social media.

The guidelines, sent to all 15 districts and the Railway and Metro police units, stress the importance of staying calm, de-escalating situations, and acting positively to avoid creating viral videos that show police in a negative light.

The advisory was issued after clashes broke out during the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar on July 20. Protesters tried to march to Parliament over claims of exam irregularities. Security forces responded with lathis, tear gas, and once with a pellet gun. More than 118 police officers and about 60 protesters were injured, leading to criticism and questions about the level of force used.

A CRPF inquiry later confirmed that a Rapid Action Force (RAF) member fired pellet rounds. One key message in the SOP says, “Your angry face is their

content. They are not fighting you. They are making a film in which they want you to play the villain.

Refuse that role.” Officers are told to assume that every interaction is being recorded on mobile phones and could be shared widely online as reels, memes, or point-of-view videos.

Protesters, especially those between 18 and 28, might cry loudly, fall at officers’ feet, or ask personal and emotional questions about family, salary, pride in their work, sleep, or what they would tell their children. In these situations, the guidelines tell officers not to argue, agree, or



react emotionally.

If needed, officers can give a brief reply such as “Please cooperate; we are doing our duty” and then remain silent. They are told to look straight ahead and treat any provoca-

tions, such as jokes, mockery, songs, dances, mock salutes, placards, or slogans using police names, as just background noise.

Officers are told not to push away phones, grab

items, throw objects, shout in anger, or overreact to offers of flowers, sweets, water bottles, or tea.

The SOP notes that these gestures may be meant to provoke a reaction that goes viral online, so officers should politely accept or refuse.

The SOP strongly encourages positive behaviour. Male officers should not touch women protesters and should let women officers handle them. If a protester faints, falls, or gets hurt, officers should help first, lift the person carefully, call an ambulance, and clear the way. Barricades should be moved to let ambulances, schoolchildren, or

patients pass. Officers must look after separated children until their parents are found. They are required to use respectful language, such as “Uncle, come this way,” “Aunt, please go to this side,” and “Sir, please cooperate.” When asking a crowd to move, officers should join their hands to make a request rather than raise a lathi. The main instruction is clear: “Let them (the protesters’ cameras) see only two things, your calm face and a helping hand.”

Sources say this approach is intended to prevent viral content while emphasising professionalism and de-escalation. A senior officer said

similar instructions were given during the earlier CJP protest. The guidelines show a wider understanding of how social media can amplify confrontations now that everything is recorded.

Statutory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) remain in force in parts of New Delhi, limiting unauthorised assemblies; the SOP focuses on conduct during permitted or inevitable interactions.

Officials hope the measures will reduce backlash and maintain public order without providing ammunition for online narratives.

Three police personnel attacked with bricks, chilli powder in Bhalswa Dairy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Three Delhi Police personnel were injured after a group allegedly attacked them with bricks and sticks and threw chilli powder into their eyes during patrolling duty in the Bhalswa Dairy area, police said on Sunday.

The incident took place around 3:30 pm on Saturday in Mukundpur, after staff from the Bhalswa Dairy police station returned to the area following the seizure of a motorcycle allegedly being driven without valid documents.

Head Constables Dinesh and Rajesh had spotted the motorcycle during patrolling and brought it to the police station for deposition. “Later, the motorcycle owner and some of his family members allegedly confronted the policemen and turned violent. The accused allegedly threw chilli powder into the eyes of the police personnel and attacked them with bricks and sticks,” a police officer said.

Head Constable Tinu, who reached the spot to assist his colleagues, was also attacked during the confrontation. All



three personnel sustained injuries in the assault, with Dinesh suffering a head injury. They were provided medical treatment and are stated to be in stable condition. A video purportedly showing the assault on the police personnel went viral on social media following the incident, drawing attention to the confrontation.

With help from local residents, police apprehended a 17-year-old juvenile from the spot, while the other accused managed to flee before further arrests could be made. An FIR has been registered at Bhalswa Dairy police station in connection with the incident.

Police identified the main absconding accused as Sunil alias Pankaj, describing him as a known troublemaker in

the area with five previous criminal cases registered against him. Officers said efforts are underway to trace and apprehend the remaining accused who fled the scene.

The attack occurred as police were carrying out routine enforcement action against a vehicle being driven without proper documentation, a common patrolling duty that turned violent when family members of the vehicle’s owner confronted the officers upon their return to the area.

The use of chilli powder as a weapon against the police personnel, combined with physical assault using bricks and sticks, has drawn attention to the risks faced by patrolling staff during routine enforcement duties in the

area. Officials said the swift response from local residents helped in the apprehension of the juvenile accused at the scene.

The case highlights ongoing challenges faced by police personnel while enforcing traffic and documentation-related regulations, particularly in situations where family members or associates of an offender intervene and escalate what begins as a routine procedural matter into a violent confrontation.

Police said the investigation into the incident is ongoing, with efforts focused on tracing Sunil alias Pankaj and the other accused involved in the attack. The registered FIR is expected to form the basis for further legal action against those identified as participants in the assault on the police personnel.

Officials have not disclosed further details regarding the specific charges filed or additional evidence gathered from the viral video circulating on social media, though the footage is likely to support the ongoing investigation into identifying all those involved in the attack.

Govt issues health advisory as H1N1 cases rise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has issued a health advisory urging people to follow respiratory hygiene, avoid crowded places and seek timely medical advice as cases of H1N1 (swine flu) rise in the national capital.

The advisory asks people to cover their mouth and nose while coughing or sneezing, wash their hands regularly with soap and water, wear masks in crowded places and avoid close contact with people suffering from respiratory illnesses.

The Influenza A (H1N1) pdm09 viruses currently circulating in the country belong to the A/Missouri/11/2025 (H1N1) pdm09-like virus strain, sources at ICMR said. These viruses belong to clade 6B.1A.5a2a, subclade D.3.1.1, and have been in circulation since 2025.

People have also been advised to avoid touching their eyes and nose, refrain from spitting in public places and take adequate fluids. If symptoms such as fever, cough, sore throat, breathing difficulty, body ache or headache appear, seek medical advice instead of taking medicines without



consulting a doctor, the advisory said.

The health department earlier said Delhi was fully prepared to deal with the seasonal rise in influenza cases, with adequate beds, doctors, medicines and essential medical equipment available in hospitals. It said 35 hospitals have been kept under special surveillance and two referral laboratories have been designated at AIIMS and the National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC).

Technical guidelines covering patient categorisation, treatment protocols, ventilatory management, use of masks and home care have also been issued.

Advisories have been sent to chief district medical officers, district surveillance officers and hospitals regarding

screening, reporting and monitoring of influenza-like illness (ILI), severe acute respiratory infection (SARI), influenza and COVID-19 cases on the Integrated Health Information Platform (IHIP) portal as per the guidelines.

Training and orientation of healthcare workers on the existing guidelines, signs and symptoms of these illnesses and the required follow-up action are also being undertaken, the department said.

According to health department data, 159 influenza cases were reported on Thursday. Of these, 155 were Influenza-A cases, including 114 H1N1, two H1, one H3 and 38 other Influenza-A cases. Four Influenza-B cases were also reported.

The total number of influenza cases reported in

Delhi this year stands at 2,602, including 2,392 Influenza-A and 210 Influenza-B cases till Friday.

Among the Influenza-A cases, 1,777 are H1N1, 37 H1, 138 H3 and 440 other cases. The Influenza-B tally includes 200 Victoria strain cases and 10 other cases.

An inter-sectoral meeting was held on August 20 under the chairpersonship of the secretary, Health and Family Welfare, with officials from the MCD, NDMC, Cantonment Board, Education Department and DDA. The departments were directed to step up public awareness and information, education and communication measures for prevention and control of seasonal influenza.

Daily review meetings are also being held with all chief district medical officers under the chairpersonship of the mission director, Delhi State Health Mission, to review the influenza situation.

Health facilities and hospitals are conducting awareness activities through health talks in outpatient departments and displaying information, education, and communication (IEC) material. IEC material approved by the Centre has also been sent to local bodies and hospitals for wider circulation.

Delhi crosses 50 lakh saplings mark; minister joins plantation drive in Vikaspuri

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Health and Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh joined a plantation drive at Shaheed Bhagat Singh Park in Vikaspuri’s Kunwar Singh Nagar on Sunday, as the government’s green campaign crossed 50 lakh saplings planted toward its target of 70 lakh across the Capital.

Addressing residents at the event, Singh said the plantation drive was progressing rapidly with active citizen participation. He said the campaign was not just about the number of trees planted but about ensuring their survival through proper protection, watering and long-term care.

“Planting a tree is only the first step, our real responsibility begins with protecting it,” Singh said, appealing to



citizens to partner in the mission by planting and caring for trees.

Singh linked the initiative to Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s “Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam” campaign, urging residents to dedicate a tree to their mothers as part of the effort to build a greener and more sustainable Delhi.

He called on residents of Vikaspuri and other parts of the city to actively join plan-

tation drives and treat tree protection as a shared community responsibility, saying every sapling nurtured today would contribute to a healthier environment for future generations.

Singh also appreciated the participation of local residents in the drive, saying such community-led initiatives strengthened the collective push toward making Delhi greener.

Tillu Tajpuriya gang associate arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An alleged active associate of the Tillu Tajpuriya gang, wanted in the murder of a member of a rival gang, has been arrested from Sonipat in Haryana, the Delhi Police said on Sunday.

Arjun Pandit alias Parmod, 36, was arrested by the the Crime Branch on Saturday in connection with the July 30 murder of Harish Mathur in Karala area of Delhi, the police said.

Mathur (36) was allegedly associated with the rival Gogi-Dinesh Karala gang. The case was registered at Kanjhawala police station.

According to the police, three shooters--Rahul Ranga, Sahil alias Vishal and Arjun--were allegedly involved in the killing. Rahul and Vishal were arrested on August 2, while Arjun remained

absconding and allegedly changed his hideouts to evade arrest.

Investigation revealed that Arjun allegedly rode the motorcycle used by the trio to follow Mathur. The accused first conducted reconnaissance of Mathur’s office before chasing him towards his residence.

When they reached near Mathur’s residence, Arjun stopped the motorcycle while Rahul and Vishal allegedly opened fire, killing him, the police said.

The trio then fled, with Rahul and Vishal allegedly dropping Arjun in Sonipat and asking him to hide until they contacted him for another task, the police said.

According to the police, the accused came in contact with Arjun through his maternal cousin, who had met Rahul through an online game.

CJP national working committee to meet, review Govt’s assurances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) will convene a meeting of its national working committee on Monday to review the status of the commitments made by the Centre after the withdrawal of its nationwide agitation on July 25, saying the government is yet to formally communicate the steps being taken to fulfil the assurances.

All steps to secure fulfilment of the commitments would be considered, including the possibility of launching another peaceful nationwide agitation, the CJP said.

“The CJP called off its agitation in good faith because the government gave its word to the young people of this country,” it said, adding that it would not allow that “good faith” to be mistaken for “weakness”.



The CJP also asked students, young citizens, its supporters and volunteers to remain prepared for the outcome of its Monday meeting.

The announcements came days after the Supreme Court on August 18 sought a consolidated list of FIRs registered against students and protesters across

the country.

The CJP said the top court asked the Centre thrice to provide the list so that it could consider exercising its powers under Article 142 to quash the cases.

“Despite the court repeatedly asking for this list, the Union government did not commit to providing it,” the CJP said.

SFI forms 84-member election committee for DUSU polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Students’ Federation of India has formed an 84-member election committee and launched its “Dream DU of Daafi Gang” to outline the organisation’s strategy for the Delhi University Students’ Union (DUSU) elections, the student body said on Sunday.

The meeting, in which Students’ Federation of India (SFI) activists from 28 DU colleges participated on Saturday, elected Sooraj Elamon as chairperson, Nadia as convener, Mehina Fathima as vice-chairperson, and Noel Benny as co-convener of the election committee, the SFI Delhi said.

Polling for DUSU is on September 18, counting is on September 19, and results are expected that same day.

The election committee is tasked with formulating a strategy for the DUSU polls.



SFI Delhi also launched its “Dream DU of Daafi Gang” campaign, outlining its vision for “progressive and accessible education” at the university. The campaign will also focus on what SFI described as the “repeated failure” of the ABVP-NSUI-led DUSU to fulfil promises made to stu-

dents. The student organisation said it would contest the central panel of DUSU and field candidates in 10 colleges across the university. The Left-wing student organisations’ SFI-AISA alliance failed to win any seats in the 2025 elections.

The meeting resolved to

take SFI’s “alternative politics” to students across DU, the statement said.

The organisation also linked its election campaign to the recent student movement at Jantar Mantar, claiming that the protest had led to the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

On July 25, 2026, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) called off its 49-day sit-in protest at Jantar Mantar after Pradhan resigned and the government agreed to meet its key demands.

In the 2025 DUSU elections, the RSS-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) stormed back to power, winning three of the four central panel posts, including the president’s post. The Congress-backed National Students’ Union of India (NSUI) managed to secure only the vice-president’s post in 2025.

Retired railway employee put under ‘digital arrest’, duped of ₹30 lakh; one apprehended

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has apprehended one person in connection with the ‘digital arrest’ of a retired railway employee who was allegedly duped of ₹30 lakh by cybercriminals impersonating NIA and RBI officials, police said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Sunil Singla, a resident of Fatehabad in Haryana, was arrested May 11.

According to police, the complainant, a retired Indian Railways employee residing in Dwarka, was contacted via phone calls and video conferencing by persons posing as officials of the Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS), National Investigation Agency (NIA), and Reserve Bank of India (RBI).



The accused allegedly implicated the complainant in terror funding and money laundering in connection with the Red Fort blast case and threatened to arrest him.

The accused allegedly showed forged documents, including manufactured notices and bonds, to instil fear and further the psychological coercion. The victim was allegedly directed to disclose details of his bank accounts and assets and

transfer money for verification, police said.

“A total of ₹30 lakh was transferred through RTGS into bank accounts controlled by the syndicate.

“During investigation, the police team found that ₹15 lakh was transferred into an account in the name of M/s Shri Balaji Tractor, operated by Singla,” a senior police officer said.

Analysis of banking records, KYC details, digital

evidence and transaction trails revealed that the account had suspicious high-value transactions and was linked to at least seven other cyber fraud cases registered across states, police said.

The syndicate allegedly isolated victims through continuous video calls, threatened them with arrest and compelled them to liquidate their funds before routing the money through mule accounts and shell accounts.

Singla had been previously arrested in a similar cyber fraud case registered by the IFSO (Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations) unit of Delhi Police’s Special Cell, the officer said.

Police said ₹12 lakh of the cheated amount has been recovered so far or refunded to the complainant.

Police unearth Arsh Dalla-linked narco-terror funding nexus

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi Police probe has uncovered an alleged terror-funding and drugs-for-weapons nexus linked to designated pro-Khalistan terrorist Arsh Dalla, with opium smuggled to Canada allegedly generating funds while weapons were pushed into Punjab through cross-border drone drops.

Four members of the alleged syndicate have been arrested, and over 5.10 kg of opium has been recovered during the investigation, which began following interception of a single courier parcel in Delhi — eventually exposing a network spanning Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan and extending overseas.

“The case dates back to February 7, when Delhi Police’s Crime Branch received specif-

ic information that a parcel booked through a courier company in Delhi for dispatch to Canada contained narcotics concealed beneath food and household items,” Special Commissioner of Police (Crime Branch) HGS Dhaliwal said in a statement.

A team reached the courier company’s premises in Moti Nagar and intercepted the parcel. Although declared to contain food items and household articles, a search revealed a false bottom beneath the parcel, concealing nearly 3 kg of opium, police said. The false bottom was designed to evade routine security screening and customs inspection, they added.

A case was registered in this connection at the Crime Branch police station. “Instead of treating the seizure as an isolated drug recovery, teams began tracing the entire courier chain. They identified

the dispatcher, examined digital devices, scrutinised financial transactions and analysed technical evidence,” the official said.

The investigation culminated in raids across Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan — leading to interception of two more consignments of opium. One of the parcels — destined for Canada — contained 921 grams of the contraband, while 1.19 kg was found concealed in the other.

Another 23 grams was recovered from the possession of one of the accused, taking the total seizure to 5.138 kg. The recovered opium has an estimated value of Rs 3.5 crore in Canada, according to the Crime Branch.

The investigation also established that different agents were tasked with handling different aspects of the illicit operation. While some were responsible for procuring nar-



cotics, and some took care of concealment and transportation, others prepared consignments and dispatched them abroad through courier companies.

The four arrestees have been identified as Hardeep Singh (28), a resident of Barnala in Punjab; Simranjeet Singh (24) from Punjab’s Bathinda; Yadvinder Singh alias Jashan Sandhu (30) from Sirsa in Haryana; and Jivan

Singh (23), a resident of Rajasthan’s Balotra.

“The investigation subsequently took a more serious turn when forensic examination of mobile phones, encrypted communications, banking records and technical data allegedly revealed links with foreign-based handlers and the network of Arsh Dalla,” the official said.

According to police, the opium being trafficked abroad

was meant for Dalla and his associates. After being sold in Canada, the proceeds were allegedly used for two purposes — financing and expanding the activities of the terrorist-linked gang and making payments to hostile foreign-based handlers. The payments allegedly formed part of a drugs-for-weapons arrangement. Police said in exchange for opium, weapons were pushed into forward areas of Punjab via cross-border drone drops, which were intended for associates of the Arsh Dalla network operating in the state.

“Narcotics trade was not merely a profit-making exercise but part of a larger cycle in which drugs generated money; the money helped finance the network, and arms were brought into India in return,” the official said.

Police said the large profit margin in international opium trade made the arrangement

particularly lucrative.

Opium, allegedly procured in India for around ₹1.5 lakh per kg, about ₹150 per gram, could fetch between 50 and 100 Canadian dollars per gram in Canada. At prevailing exchange rates, this translates to roughly ₹3,300 to ₹6,700 per gram, he said.

According to the official, the network allegedly used several methods to conceal the narcotics and obscure the identities of those behind the operation. Opium was concealed beneath silver-foil false bottoms inside cartons containing food items or, in some instances, inside garments. Forged KYC documents and fictitious consignor details were allegedly used to book consignments in names of unsuspecting persons. The parcels were routed through multiple intermediaries to obscure the identity of handlers.

The accused allegedly com-

municated through encrypted applications, while proxy bank accounts and UPI channels were used to move proceeds and meet operational expenses. Digital and financial evidence helped investigators identify communications, consignees and transactions linked with the syndicate, police said.

The probe has also established the involvement of Arshdeep Singh Gill alias Arsh Dalla, a native of Punjab’s Moga, who fled to Canada in 2018. He was designated terrorist under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act in January 2023, and is among the top leaders of the Khalistan Tiger Force, a proscribed pro-Khalistan terrorist organisation. Dalla was arrested by Canadian authorities in Ontario in November 2024, and the Indian government has been pursuing his extradition.

Pregnant defence ministry officer found dead in Dwarka, husband booked

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

A 30-year-old pregnant woman working as an Assistant Section Officer in the Ministry of Defence was found dead at her home in Bharthal village, southwest Delhi’s Dwarka, on Friday. The Delhi police has registered a case of cruelty and abetment to suicide against her husband and in-laws a day after her family initially made no allegations against them.

Police said the information was received through a PCR call at 4:21 pm on August 21, reporting an alleged suicide at Village Bharthal. The call was assigned to Sub-inspector Satpal Dagar, who reached the spot with police staff and took the body into possession.

The concerned SDM was

informed immediately, and the body was shifted to DDU Hospital’s mortuary as per procedure.

“Police acted promptly upon receipt of the PCR call, and all necessary legal and procedural steps were taken without delay,” the DCP of Dwarka district said in a statement, adding that further investigation into the matter remains in progress.

The deceased was identified as Nazia Khanam, daughter of Towab Khan. She had married Mohammad Azam Ali Khan, who works as a supply chain manager in Gurgaon, on April 11 this year, according to Muslim rites and customs. She was three months pregnant at the time of her death.

According to police, the couple had gone to a hospital for a checkup on the day of the incident. After return-



ing home, they got into an argument, following which Khanam locked her husband in one room and herself in another, before taking her own life, a senior police officer said.

On the same day, family members of Khanam appeared before the Executive Magistrate and submitted written statements. At that point, they raised no suspicion or allegation

against her husband or any member of her matrimonial family, police said.

However, the next day, on August 22, Khanam’s parents appeared again before the SDM and submitted a fresh statement, this time levelling allegations against her husband and his family. In their complaint, the family alleged that the husband had been physically assaulting and mentally harassing

Khanam, which drove her to take the extreme step, according to a senior police officer.

Based on this subsequent complaint, police registered FIR No. 214/2026 on August 22 under Sections 85 and 108 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at Sector 23, Dwarka police station. Section 85 pertains to a husband or his relative subjecting a woman to cruelty, while Section 108 relates to abetment of suicide. Khanam’s family has additionally demanded that Section 80, relating to dowry death, be added to the FIR.

Khanam’s husband is currently absconding, police said. The exact circumstances leading to her death, along with the allegations raised by her parents, are being examined as part of the ongoing investigation.

The case has drawn atten-

tion for the shift in the family’s account within 24 hours, from submitting statements without any allegations on the day of the death to filing a formal complaint naming the husband and in-laws the very next day. Police said the discrepancy between the two statements would form part of their investigation as they work to establish the sequence of events leading up to Khanam’s death.

Officials said further legal action would follow as facts and evidence emerge during the course of the investigation, with the case currently being probed under the cruelty and abetment to suicide provisions, pending additional findings that could determine whether further charges, including those related to dowry, are warranted.

Government to shift dangerous prisoners to jails in other States



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a move to curb organised crime, the Delhi government has prepared a plan to transfer undertrial gangsters, organised criminals and other high-risk prisoners lodged in the capital’s jails to prisons in other states, if required.

For this, the Government will implement the Transfer of Prisoners (Punjab Amendment) Act, 2025, in Delhi. According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the move aims to enable the interstate transfer of such prisoners in the interest of prison security, law and order and public interest, while strengthening cooperation among states in tackling organised crime.

Under the Delhi government’s proposal, undertrial gangsters, organised criminals and other high-risk prisoners can be transferred from one state to another with the mutual consent of the states concerned or the approval of the Ministry of Home Affairs. The move is also expected to make the criminal justice system more effective and help improve prison management.

According to a Chief Minister’s Office (CMO) statement, a large number of hardened and notorious criminals are lodged as undertrials alongside convicts in Delhi’s jails. In May 2026, 188

members belonging to 26 identified gangs were identified in Delhi, of whom 107 gangsters had been arrested. Despite being jailed, these “hardened criminals” exploit prison welfare facilities and local networks to run extortion rings, orchestrate targeted killings, trigger gang wars, and expand alliances, the CMO said.

Under the existing system, such undertrial gangsters and notorious criminals cannot be transferred from Delhi’s prisons to those in other states. The Transfer of Prisoners Act, 1950, provides for the transfer of convicted prisoners only. Undertrials, meanwhile, are kept in custody under special remand warrants issued by the concerned trial court, and their transfer is governed by the Prisons Act, 1900, which permits the transfer of prisoners only within a state. Moving them outside Delhi aims to isolate them, preventing them from influencing witnesses, disrupting trials, or conspiring from behind bars.

To address this legal gap, the Punjab government had introduced the Transfer of Prisoners (Punjab Amendment) Act, 2025. The amendment received the President’s assent on April 21, 2025. The amended law provides for the transfer of undertrial prisoners from one state to another to maintain security and law and order or in the public interest.

Several detained as anti-reservation protesters gather at Connaught Place

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Around 300 people gathered at Connaught Place’s outer circle in Delhi on Sunday to protest against caste-based reservation and demand reforms in the quota system, with police detaining over 20 protesters from the site, officials said.

The protesters, who raised slogans and carried placards, called for greater emphasis on economic criteria in deciding eligibility for reservation and government support, arguing that assistance should reach economically disadvantaged people irrespective of caste.

Police said over 20 people gathered at Connaught Place were detained and removed from the site, as no permission had been granted for the demonstration.

Police maintained a presence at Connaught Place as



the gathering was cleared from the protest site.

A key demand raised during the demonstration was the introduction of a creamy-layer criterion and a review of the existing reservation framework.

Protesters also sought changes in policies concerning Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes.

“We are not against reservation. We want reforms in reservation. The government should understand that poor people from all communities also face difficulties,

and their concerns should be heard,” a protester said. Another participant said the existing system should be examined to ensure that its benefits reach those who genuinely need support.

The protesters also raised concerns over the University Grants Commission framework and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, seeking a broader review of policies they said affected opportunities in education and employment.

The demonstration is part of a mobilisation that has largely taken place through social media. The “Reservation Hatao Andolan”, an Instagram-based page with around 5.6 million followers, had called on its followers to join a physical demonstration in Delhi after building an online campaign around reservation reforms.

19-year-old killed as truck hits motorcycle at IP flyover, driver flees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 19-year-old man died and another was injured after their motorcycle was allegedly hit by a truck at the IP Flyover in central Delhi early Sunday morning, with the truck driver fleeing the scene following the collision, police said.

The deceased was identified as Aman, a resident of Madanpur Khadar, who was riding a black Hero Honda Splendor toward Sarai Kale Khan when the accident occurred. His pillion rider, 22-year-old Alber, a resident of Batla House in Jamia Nagar, was also injured in the crash.

“Aman was riding the motorcycle towards Sarai Kale Khan when the two-wheeler was allegedly hit by a truck on the IP flyover,” a senior police officer said, adding that Alber fell from the



motorcycle during the collision and sustained injuries.

Police said a PCR call regarding the accident was received at IP Estate police station around 6:21 am, after being transferred from Civil Lines police station. Local police staff reached the spot soon after and a crime team was called in to collect evidence from the scene.

Aman sustained fatal injuries and died at the spot, while Alber was rushed to the Trauma Centre along with him. Alber is currently undergoing treatment, with his condition stated to be stable, police said.

According to the police

officer, the truck driver fled the scene immediately after the collision, leaving both riders on the road. A case has been registered, and necessary legal action is being taken. Police said efforts are underway to identify the truck involved in the accident and trace its driver.

Investigators are also examining whether any CCTV cameras installed on the flyover or in the surrounding areas captured the accident or the truck’s movement before and after the collision, which could help identify the vehicle and the driver responsible.

The incident adds to a series of road accidents involving heavy vehicles on Delhi’s flyovers and arterial roads, with hit and run cases involving trucks remaining a persistent challenge for traffic enforcement in the capital.

Police raid two spas in Kalkaji, rescue 21 women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police arrested two spa managers and rescued 21 women after raiding two spa centres in southeast Delhi’s Kalkaji on suspicion of alleged prostitution activities, an official said on Sunday.

According to police, the raids were carried out on Saturday at two separate spa establishments after officers received information regarding suspected illegal activities taking place at the locations.

Before conducting the raids, police teams first carried out separate decoy operations at both spa centres to verify the information received. “In different raids, our teams arrested two managers of the spa centres. Teams have registered two FIRs and launched further investigation,” the officer said. During the operations at the two establishments, a total of 21 women were rescued from the premises, police said.

The rescued women were

sent for medical examination following the raids, and their statements are currently being recorded in accordance with legal procedure, according to police.

Officials said the two FIRs registered in connection with the raids would form the basis for further investigation into the alleged activities at both spa centres. Police have not yet disclosed additional details regarding the identities of the arrested managers or the specific charges being pursued against them.

The Kalkaji raids add to a series of similar enforcement actions carried out by Delhi Police against spa centres and massage parlours across the city, where authorities have periodically found evidence of illegal activities operating under the guise of legitimate wellness services.

Police said the decoy operations conducted ahead of the raids played a key role in gathering preliminary evidence before officers moved in to conduct the searches and subsequent arrests at both locations.

DDA to hold over 20 stakeholder meets to push MPD-2047 implementation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Following the notification of the Master Plan for Delhi-2047, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) plans to launch a major outreach drive to accelerate its implementation. Under the directions of Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the DDA will hold more than 20 stakeholder meetings over the next three months, engaging directly with elected representatives, Government agencies, professional bodies, industry,

residents, landowners, and other stakeholders.

“The meetings will provide a platform for focused interaction on various provisions of MPD-2047 and facilitate greater coordination in translating the plan’s vision into action,” the DDA said.

To boost industrial growth, the DDA will consult industry bodies and chambers, including CII, FICCI, PHDCCI, ASSOCHAM and DSIIDC, on measures to promote industrial development and facilitate land availability for industry, it said.

The DDA said, “Architects, plan-



ners, professional institutions and private developers will be engaged in discussions on development opportunities under TOD, HDC and Land Pooling.”

As part of the initiative, the DDA will hold separate interactions with

MPs and MLAs on key provisions of MPD-2047, including Transit-Oriented Development (TOD), High-Density Corridors (HDC), Land Pooling, and Low-Density Areas (LDA).

“The DDA will reach out to RWAs, Group Housing Societies, Cooperative Group Housing Societies and other stakeholders on redevelopment of Group Housing. For Land Pooling, interactions with farmers, landowners and local stakeholders will be undertaken through area-based meetings. The outreach programme will also cover

Low Density Areas; rejuvenation of the Yamuna and development of Delhi’s blue-green network; heritage conservation; mixed-use development; development and redevelopment of commercial centres; in-situ slum redevelopment; and measures for decongestion and improved mobility,” it said.

Focused stakeholder interactions are also proposed on developing Delhi’s education and medical hubs, with participation from educational institutions, universities, health-care institutions and other concerned stakeholders.

DMRC becomes first Indian metro to earn ISO 55001:2024 certification

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation Limited (DMRC) has achieved ISO 55001:2024 certification for its Asset Management System for Mumbai Metro Line-3, becoming the first metro organisation in India to receive certification to this latest international standard for asset management.

The achievement marks a significant milestone in

DMRC’s journey from conventional maintenance practices towards strategic, risk-based and lifecycle-oriented asset management.

Anuj Dayal, Principal Executive Director, DMRC, said it reflects a shift from simply maintaining assets to managing their performance, risk, cost and long-term value in alignment with organisational objectives.

ISO 55001:2024 provides a globally recognised framework for managing assets



across their entire lifecycle. Its implementation enables

organisations to take more informed decisions by bal-

ancing asset performance, operational risk and lifecycle costs, thereby enhancing reliability, resource efficiency and long-term sustainability.

In a statement, DMRC said it achieved this certification in record time through a comprehensive strengthening of its asset management framework. This included enhancing the Strategic Asset Management Plan (SAMP), aligning asset management objectives with organisation-

al priorities, strengthening risk assessment and lifecycle controls, and undertaking extensive training and capacity building of personnel. The system is continuously monitored through Key Performance Indicators (KPIs), audits and management reviews.

DMRC is responsible for the Operations & Maintenance (O&M) of the 33.5-km Mumbai Metro Line-3 corridor, connecting Colaba, Bandra and SEEPZ.



Editor's
TAKE

Confidence is India's new neighbourhood doctrine

As India navigates an uncertain China, Bangladesh and an strategic Pakistan, the real question is if New Delhi can turn confident rhetoric into a neighbourhood policy

Speaking at the Economic Times World Leaders Forum on Saturday, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar offered a phrase that will likely outlive the event itself: India, he said, must engage Beijing "from a position of confidence." It was meant to describe China policy alone, but by the time he had finished fielding questions on Bangladesh and Pakistan, it had become something closer to a governing philosophy for India's entire neighbourhood.

On China, the confidence has some substance behind it. Jaishankar was candid about the "particularly bad patch" between the 2020 Galwan dash and autumn 2024, and credited the border disengagement at Depsang and Demchok, followed by Modi's Kazan meeting with Xi Jinping, for the thaw since. His formula – deal with Beijing confidently, stand India's ground, while building the manufacturing muscle to compete rather than merely coexist – is coherent as doctrine. Whether it is coherent as fact is another matter: India still runs a yawning trade deficit with China and remains dependent on it for rare earths, APIs and electronics components that Atma Nirbhar Bharat has yet to meaningfully dislodge.

Confidence, here, is as much aspiration as description. Tellingly, he also cautioned against reading the US-China relationship as a simple "G2" – a reminder that India's confidence is partly about not being a bystander to bigger powers. On Bangladesh, the "mutual interest" test he prescribed is the right instinct, but it is presently failing its own standard. Jaishankar declined to be drawn on Dhaka's demand for Sheikh Hasina's extradition, even as her August 5 virtual address from a Delhi platform has poisoned the run-up to Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's now-uncertain visit – a visit meant to anchor ties with Bangladesh's first elected government since 2024. New Delhi's reluctance to hand over Hasina is defensible on its own terms. But it sits awkwardly with talk of confidence when the relationship with an elected, potentially India-friendly government hangs on a single unresolved question. Pakistan is where the doctrine faces its least examined test.

Jaishankar's description of Pakistan as "unique" in its use of terrorism is accurate and well-worn. What is new is the company Islamabad now keeps: the Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement with Saudi Arabia, extended in August into a trilateral pact with Turkey at Mecca, complete with unresolved questions about a nuclear umbrella. A confident China policy and an unresolved Bangladesh relationship matter less if India's western and eastern flanks both begin orbiting a Gulf-anchored security architecture it has no part in. None of this makes "confidence" the wrong vocabulary. But confidence works as diplomacy only when it is backed by demonstrated capability – industrial, military and diplomatic follow-through – not merely asserted. Jaishankar has named the right posture for a fragmenting world. Whether Rahman visits Delhi, whether Dhaka joins the Mecca pact, and whether Indian manufacturing narrows the China gap will determine whether it was substance, or simply well-chosen words.

Maps matter, but people matter more

India's latest assertion of its territorial identity in Arunachal Pradesh is important, but an inhabited and thriving frontier will remain the strongest answer to China's persistent claims



SABIR NISHAT

India has put another marker on the map in its long-running contest with China over Arunachal Pradesh. The latest Survey of India map formally identifies 27 locations in the state by their Indian names, including mountain passes, settlements, a lake and places associated with the 1962 India-China war. It is an important assertion of sovereignty at a time when Beijing continues to insist that Arunachal Pradesh is part of China and repeatedly attempts to impose its own names on places across the state.

But maps, however important, cannot by themselves hold a frontier. During a recent visit to Arunachal Pradesh in the monsoon, I was struck by something far more consequential than the disputed names appearing on competing maps. Valley after valley close to the China border appeared largely uninhabited. In many remote stretches, the most visible signs of India's presence were the personnel of the Indian Army and the Border Roads Organisation.

That stark landscape raises a difficult question: can India effectively counter China's cartographic and territorial claims if large portions of its frontier remain without a permanent civilian population?

China's claims go beyond changing names. China's claim over Arunachal Pradesh is neither new nor limited to the periodic renaming of places. Beijing describes the state as 'Zangnan', or southern Tibet, and lays claim to a large part of its territory. Since 2017, it has repeatedly announced what it describes as standardised Chinese names for places in Arunachal Pradesh. Each such exercise is intended to reinforce the impression that these are Chinese territories awaiting recognition rather than Indian lands under an established system of administration.

This is not merely a linguistic exercise. Place names are instruments of territorial politics. Repeatedly naming a mountain, river, village or pass in official documents, maps and public communication creates an alternative geographical narrative.

The strategy is part of a larger Chinese approach in which maps, infrastructure, settlements and administrative structures work together. The objective is to establish a sustained presence and make territorial claims appear increasingly normal and irreversible.

India's response, therefore, cannot stop at rejecting Chinese names.



The memory of 1962 remains powerful

The new Indian map's emphasis on locations associated with the 1962 war carries particular significance. Longju, Thag La and other places in the eastern Himalayas are not simply dots on a military map. They are reminders of a conflict that shaped India's understanding of its northern and eastern frontiers.

The 1962 war remains one of the defining moments in the history of independent India. Indian forces fought under extraordinarily difficult circumstances in Arunachal's unforgiving terrain. Memorials such as Jaswant Garh have since become symbols of that resistance and sacrifice.

The significance of recalling 1962 today is not to reopen an old conflict, but to underline a historical reality: India's relationship with this frontier did not begin with the latest roads, military posts or cartographic exercises. The region has been administered as part of India for decades, and its people have their own distinct histories, cultures and connections to the land. The memory of the war also demonstrates why the frontier cannot be viewed purely through the lens of military deployment. Empty valley is a serious strategic concern

This is where India's border policy faces its most difficult test. The Indian Army can guard a remote post. The BRO can carve a road through mountains. New bridges and tunnels can reduce distances that once took days to cover. But neither soldiers nor infrastructure can substitute permanently for communities.

An inhabited frontier is a lived assertion of sovereignty.

The government has recognised this through initiatives such as the Vibrant Villages Programme, aimed at improving connectivity, housing, electricity, communications, education, healthcare and liveli-

INDIA IS RIGHT TO RESPOND TO CHINA'S CARTOGRAPHIC ASSERTIONS. NAMING ITS OWN PLACES, DOCUMENTING ITS HISTORY AND MARKING THE LOCATIONS WHERE INDIAN SOLDIERS FOUGHT AND DIED ARE IMPORTANT ACTS OF NATIONAL ASSERTION.

The writer is Deputy Director, Assam Information Centre, New Delhi

The right tree, in the right place

Indian tradition has an answer, of sorts. Trees have never been merely trees in our imagination. They are witnesses to stories, shelter for travellers, sources of food and medicine, symbols of life itself. The forests of the Ramayana, especially Panchavati, are not empty wilderness - they are full of trees, rivers, animals, birds, people. The Skanda Purana celebrates the planting of Ashvattha, Neem, Banyan, Tamarind, Kapiththa, Bilva, Amla and Mango. This thread runs through our festivals, literature, songs and cinema, where trees appear again and again - not as scenery, but as memory, shelter, spirit, livelihood. Our culture has always known that nature isn't separate from us. Ecology now gives us the vocabulary to explain why. A tree is never really alone. Its roots work with soil and microorganisms; its canopy shapes the microclimate around it; its flowers and fruit feed insects and birds; its fallen leaves return nutrients to the ground. So plantation can't just mean picking a fast-growing species and sticking it wherever there's space. Soil, rainfall, temperature, groundwater, root behaviour, surrounding vegetation, maintenance - all of it matters. A tree that thrives in a park may not belong on a narrow road. A tree with a wide canopy under power lines becomes a problem waiting to happen. A thirsty species has no place in a water-stressed landscape.

Consider *Conocarpus erectus*. It grew fast, stayed green year-round, and became a favourite for urban and roadside planting - until its ecological and infrastructural costs became clear, and several states pulled back.

The lesson isn't "native good, exotic bad." It's simpler: right tree, right place, and right ecosystem.

We also need to stop measuring success by numbers. Saplings planted, hectares covered - these tell us about effort, not outcome. What matters is survival, growth, whether the tree actually does its job in the ecosystem. Schools can adopt and monitor trees. Resident associations can keep neighbourhood tree registers. Panchayats can protect old groves and mature trees. Geotagging and survival audits can track what actually lives. Because planting without follow-up care means nothing. A photograph of a sapling is not an outcome. Our traditions carry a relationship with nature that has lasted generations. It's time to turn that into everyday practice. The tree planted today might shade a child we'll never meet, shelter a bird decades from now, hold soil and water long after today's headlines are forgotten. So afforestation shouldn't stop at planting more - it should mean planting more of the right species, in the right place. The next plantation drive should start with three questions: Which tree does this land need? What ecosystem will it support? Who will look after it in the years ahead? India's green future depends on planting more - but planting wisely - and on caring faithfully for what grows.

Mahesh Kumar is Chief Executive Officer, National Medicinal Plants Board, Ministry of Ayush, and Gaurav Sharma is Media & Communication Officer, Press Information Bureau.

PIC TALK



Devotees carry an idol of Lord Ganesh to a worship venue ahead of the 'Ganesh Chaturthi' festival, in Mumbai

PHOTO: PTI



MAHESH KUMAR DADHICH



GAURAV KUMAR SHARMA

2ND OPINION

A tree planted today may live for decades. Where it is planted, which species is chosen, how it is cared for - all of this shapes a landscape long after the people who planted it are gone. This is worth remembering as India urbanises. Rising temperatures, air pollution, water stress and biodiversity loss make the case for greener landscapes urgent. Trees give shade, cool the air, support biodiversity, protect soil and improve our well-being.

So what do we actually mean by afforestation? Is it just putting saplings in the ground? Or is it about building living landscapes, where the right trees grow in the right places and become part of a working ecosystem?

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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VIJAY'S FREEBIE POLITICS: FROM CRITICISING THE DMK TO BECOMING DMK

Actor-turned-politician Vijay Joseph rose to prominence by attacking the DMK government for emptying the state treasury through populist schemes instead of creating jobs, opportunities and sustainable growth.

It is therefore deeply disappointing to see his government now following the very path he once criticised. The Tamil Nadu government's decision to provide gold worth ₹1.28 lakh to newborn babies, with a budget allocation of ₹220 crore, is the latest example of this growing freebies culture. Earlier, Vijay's government also approved higher salaries and perks for MLAs, including cars. Soon after taking office, the Chief Minister appears to have joined the same populist race that governments across states

are pursuing, placing increasing pressure on both state and national finances. Many voters had hoped Vijay would bring a different kind of politics—one focused on employment, investment, education and opportunities rather than handouts.

Sadly, the emerging picture suggests little difference: DMK in new clothes.

If political parties cannot resist the temptation of freebies, perhaps the Supreme Court must step in suo motu and consider prescribing a reasonable ceiling on government spending on such schemes, linked to a state's or the Centre's fiscal capacity and GDP. Public money must create public wealth, not merely political goodwill.

YASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

R. NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

The wisdom of feast and fast

Festivals across civilisations teach us a profound lesson: celebration is not merely about having more, but also knowing when to have less. The feast and the fast, though seemingly opposite, are two expressions of the same spiritual instinct. Onam, celebrated in Kerala, offers a magnificent example. Its sumptuous sadhya, served generously on a banana leaf, is more than a culinary tradition. It is an expression of gratitude—to nature, providence and the larger order of life that sustains us. Christmas, Thanksgiving, Chinese New Year and harvest festivals across Africa, Asia and Latin America similarly celebrate abundance, gratitude and fellowship. But alongside the feast stands the fast.

Hindu traditions embrace fasting as an act of devotion and restraint. During Lent, Christians practise voluntary deprivation; in Ramadan, hunger becomes an exercise in discipline and empathy; Yom Kippur uses abstinence as a path towards repentance and reflection. The festivals of the world differ greatly, yet they share an ancient wisdom: receive with humility, celebrate with others and learn to renounce with dignity. The feast teaches gratitude for abundance; the fast reminds us that we must never become prisoners of it.

The report, 'Delhi horror: Family dispute ends in engineer's murder' (August 23), is deeply disturbing. Beyond the horror of the crime itself, it raises a troubling question: have anger, frustration and personal disputes become far too easily transformed into violence? The alleged killing of a young software engineer following a family quarrel is not merely a criminal incident. It points to a disturbing erosion of patience, empathy and respect for human life.

Several factors may contribute to such tragedies, including financial pressures, strained relationships, untreated mental-health concerns, easy access to weapons and, above all, an inability to control anger. None, however, can ever justify taking another person's life. There is an urgent need to strengthen counselling and mental-health support and to promote healthier ways of resolving conflicts. Schools, workplaces, families and community organisations must encourage emotional resilience, empathy and peaceful communication. Disagreements are inevitable in human relationships. Violence must not be. A society that loses its ability to resolve differences peacefully risks losing something far more fundamental—the sanctity and value of human life.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

Mumbai's potholes need more than concrete

Mumbai's continuing pothole problem raises questions about both the condition of the city's roads and the effectiveness of its ambitious road-concretisation programme. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation received 8,032 pothole complaints between June 10 and August 20, with 7,829 reportedly resolved. The eastern suburbs accounted for the largest share, with Bhandup, Govandi, Deonar, Mankhurd, Chembur, Tilak Nagar, Kurla and Saki Naka among the worst affected areas. Most complaints concerned existing bituminous roads that have yet to be concretised.

The BMC's Rs 17,000-crore concretisation project, launched in 2022, aims to replace more than 700 km of the city's 2,050-km road network. While 475 km had reportedly been fully concretised and another 101.91 km partially completed before the monsoon suspension of works, thousands of pothole complaints show that the transition will take time. Concretisation may reduce the problem over the long term, but Mumbai cannot afford unsafe roads in the interim. The civic administration must ensure timely repairs, better road quality and strict accountability for recurring failures. Citizens deserve roads that are safe and durable—not merely promises of better roads tomorrow.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Reading the enemies: India’s unseen shield

India’s intelligence battle is changing—and the most important battles may be the ones the public never sees. From China and Pakistan to terrorism, cyber warfare and AI-driven disinformation, the country’s security challenges increasingly demand the ability to distinguish truth from deception and anticipate what comes next.



There are battles that make headlines and battles that never should be. The Indian intelligence network largely belongs to the second category. Its success is rarely measured in photographs, medals, or captured territory. It is measured in the attack that never happened, the infiltration detected in time, the hostile network disrupted before it became operational, and the warning that reached a decision-maker before a crisis reached the border.

For India in 2026, that invisible contest has become far more important. And growing day by day. The country’s security environment is no longer defined by a single battlefield. The threat can come through a terrorist network, an unmanned aircraft, a cyber intrusion, a financial trail, a manipulated video, or a military manoeuvre along the Himalayas. That makes India’s intelligence agencies not merely institutions of national security, but increasingly institutions of national anticipation. Previously, the appointment of P. Jain as Secretary of the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) assumes particular significance in this environment. A career intelligence officer with experience in sensitive assignments, including the Pakistan desk and the Aviation Research Centre, Jain took charge of India’s external intelligence establishment at a time when the country’s principal security challenges increasingly overlap: Pakistan-backed terrorism, China’s expanding strategic footprint, technology-driven warfare and information manipulation.

The story of India’s intelligence community, however, did not begin with R&AW. The Intelligence Bureau traces its institutional origins to 23 December 1887, when the Central Special Branch was established. It was subsequently renamed the Criminal Intelligence Bureau and eventually the Intelligence Bureau. The IB completed a century of existence in 1987, a reminder that India’s intelligence machinery has been evolving for well over a hundred years. R&AW came much later. Established in 1968, in the aftermath of the painful intelligence lessons of the 1962 war with China, it gave India a dedicated external intelligence organization. Its early years coincided with one of the most consequential periods in India’s neighborhood.

The 1971 Bangladesh war is perhaps the most prominent example of intelligence operating behind a historic military victory. R&AW’s contribution to the larger Indian strategy surrounding the Bangladesh Liberation War has been documented in historical accounts, particularly in relation to intelligence collection and support to the forces fighting in what was then East Pakistan.

Some of the agency’s other historical roles remain less publicly debated. Accounts available through India’s National Academy of Administration’s library record R&AW’s subsequent involvement in covert operations and intelligence activity across countries including Afghanistan, Sri Lanka and Fiji. Many of the details remain classified, which is perhaps appropriate for an organisation whose effectiveness depends upon precisely that silence.

There is also the lesser-known story of Sikkim. R&AW’s presence in Gangtok in the early 1970s coincided with a period of profound political change in the Himalayan kingdom. Public accounts, including those of former intelligence officer G.B.S. Sidhu, describe the interaction between local political developments, New Delhi and Indian intelligence officials before Sikkim became India’s 22nd state in 1975.

That distinction is important. Intelligence history is particularly vulnerable to mythology because the best operations are rarely documented in full. And shouldn’t be in this digital age. India’s intelligence community also learned some of its hardest lessons through failure. Kargil conflict in 1999 exposed gaps in surveillance, intelligence assessment, and information sharing. The reforms that followed recognised that information trapped within one organisation has limited value unless it reaches the organisation capable of acting upon it.

That principle has become even more important today. Consider the recent controversy over alleged Chinese activity in Upper Subansiri, Arunachal Pradesh. Reports claimed PLA personnel had entered areas claimed by India and established temporary camps. The Indian Army rejected the reports as incorrect and without basis, while political and local groups continued



ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE CAN PROCESS IMAGERY AND COMMUNICATIONS AT A SPEED NO HUMAN TEAM CAN MATCH. BUT THE SAME TECHNOLOGICAL ENVIRONMENT ALLOWS ADVERSARIES TO CREATE DEEPFAKES, SYNTHETIC AUDIO, MANIPULATED PHOTOGRAPHS AND CAREFULLY DESIGNED MISINFORMATION

The writer is an educationist and senior columnist

to raise concerns and called for further probe. For intelligence professionals, this is precisely the kind of situation in which ground truth becomes a strategic commodity. Is an unfamiliar group of troops a patrol, an intrusion or routine movement? Has a structure been newly established or misidentified? Is an image genuine? Is information being deliberately planted? Does a seemingly minor movement form part of a wider pattern?

These are intelligence questions before they become military or diplomatic questions. Arunachal makes that challenge particularly acute. The Line of Actual Control is not a mutually demarcated international boundary, while the terrain is vast, mountainous and difficult to access. A road, bridge, settlement or temporary military structure can consequently acquire significance far beyond its physical dimensions. The challenge is that modern adversaries are generating information too. A satellite can provide extraordinary visibility. A drone can watch a frontier continuously. Artificial intelligence can process imagery and communications at a speed no human team can match. But the same technological environment allows adversaries to create deepfakes, synthetic audio, manipulated photographs and carefully designed misinformation.

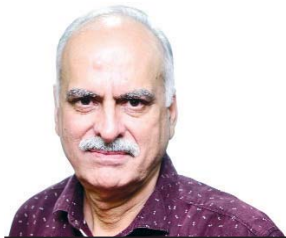
The intelligence challenge has therefore changed from simply finding information to establishing what is true. That may be the most important transformation of all. Imagine a hostile network preparing an operation. One agency detects unusual communications. Others notice suspicious financial movement. Border personnel report unfamiliar activity. A technical organization identifies a digital signature. Local police observe an unexplained change in behavior.

The same is true of deterrence. Good intelligence can prevent escalation because it allows a government to distinguish between an actual threat and a misunderstanding. Poor intelligence can produce either dangerous complacency or unnecessary confrontation. The Indian intelligence officer of tomorrow may therefore need to be part field operative, part technologist and part analyst. Artificial intelligence will help identify patterns, but human judgement will remain indispensable in deciding whether those patterns represent an actual threat or an elaborate deception. India’s intelligence story began with files, informants, coded messages and human sources. It now includes satellites, drones, databases, cyber networks and algorithms. Yet the central question has remained remarkably constant. What does the adversary intend to do before the adversary does it? That question connects the quiet intelligence work of the past with India’s present strategic environment.

The successes of 1971, the lessons of Kargil and the many operations that remain outside public knowledge should not be romanticised. Nor should intelligence agencies be judged only by dramatic stories of espionage. Their real value lies in something far less glamorous: producing reliable knowledge in time for the State to act. In an age of China, terrorism, drones, cyber warfare, artificial intelligence, and information manipulation, the first battle may no longer begin at the border. It may begin with whoever understands the situation first. Jain’s recent visit to Dhaka may therefore prove significant not for what made it to the headlines, but for what may quietly follow.

His meeting with Bangladesh’s security establishment comes at a delicate moment, when New Delhi and Dhaka are attempting to rebuild confidence while navigating questions of border security, terrorism, regional influence, and the future direction of Bangladesh’s foreign policy. If the visit succeeds in restoring a more dependable channel between Indian and Bangladeshi intelligence agencies, improving the exchange of security information and reducing the space for forces hostile to either country, its value could extend well beyond a single meeting. For India, Bangladesh is not merely a neighbouring country; it is a strategic land and maritime gateway to the Northeast and the Bay of Bengal. In that sense, Jain’s Dhaka visit could quietly mark the beginning of something more consequential—a recalibration of India’s intelligence presence in its eastern neighborhood, where knowing what is changing may matter as much as knowing what has changed.

Rumbling in poll bound Uttar Pradesh



ANIL ANAND

Adityanath’s independent style of governance, loath to any interference from top bosses in New Delhi. Many manifestations of this clash of titans have come to the fore in the recent past. From BJP’s internal battle of supremacy to control the organisational mechanism in Uttar Pradesh, to reports of the Centre’s desperate but failed attempts, up till now, to reign in Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath like the other BJP-ruled states headed by lightweights and political novices. And the huge controversy surrounding the alleged theft of donations in Ayodhya’s Ram Temple assuming a state versus Centre dimension. In all these manifestations the battlelines seem getting drawn more clearly. To cap it all, Governor Mrs Anandiben Patel choosing Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath’s home turf Gorakhpur, his political as well as spiritual ‘karambhoomi’, to impliedly target him on the pretext of poor facilities in local educational institutions for the students and other like issues, has generated curiosity both within the BJP-leaving them guessing as to what is transpiring ahead of the assembly elections- and the Opposition camp led by Samajwadi Party-Congress combine.

As it is the path to the coming assembly elections is strewn with serious hurdles for the BJP in view of rumblings in the party’s traditional vote-base. The recent set of developments with the Governor pitching in, taking upon herself the role of opposition rather than remaining within the confines of her Constitutional limits, has led to tongues wagging whether the Yogi will be projected as the CM face for his possible third consecutive term or not. Or is he destined to go the way senior BJP leaders such as Mrs Vasundhara Raje and Mr Shivraj Singh Chouhan- both shown the door despite being powerful chief ministers in Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh. A common thread connecting the three senior leaders of politically important states is that many consider them as possible Prime Ministerial hopefuls. And that has proved to be undoing of Mrs Raje and Mr Chouhan and the phenomena seems to be catching up with Yogi Adityanath.

The significance of Governor Anandiben’s diatribe lies in the selection of Gorakhpur which is strongly connected with the chief minister. She seized upon the opportunity to pull up the Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Gorakhpur University, in her capacity as its Chancellor, and local administration over hostel infrastructure and student amenities. Ostensibly, her message was designed to be sent where it was meant to target.

Apart from Gorakhpur being Yogi Adityanath’s seat of power, selecting it to indirectly target him has many dimensions attached to it. After all he was MP from Gorakhpur for five consecutive terms before taking over as the chief ministers. And more importantly, it is home to the Gorakhnath Math of which the Yogi is the powerful head. Could Mrs Anandiben have done this on her own will or she was ordained to do so by the party high command? It is to remember that she was a veteran politician from Gujarat and a senior minister before becoming Governor of one of the most politically significant state Uttar Pradesh which is central to BJP’s national politics and ambitions. Well, the Gorakhpur episode was not an isolated outburst by her but it has become significant being the home-turf of the Yogi who is in the eye of storm having managed to pursue a line independent of New Delhi. Credit goes to him for steadfastly standing his ground but that has also, of late, become a reason for him to court problems. Will he be able to offset the effect of these developments focused on him in the run up to not only the assembly election but the subsequent Lok Sabha polls as well?

Ordinarily Modi-Shah duo will never like to off-set the political equilibrium to BJP’s disadvantage as the road to victory in 2029 general elections passes through Uttar Pradesh. As it is, the central dispensation is facing plethora of problems including the serious challenge posed by the Gen Z protests propelled by an unknown Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) and the resultant strong police action against the protestors at New Delhi’s Jantar Mantar which has led to the washing out of the monsoon Session of Parliament on the issue. Mrs Patel has repeatedly used public platforms to question the functioning of institutions under the state government during the past few weeks. At the Chandra Shekhar Azad University of Agriculture and Technology in Kanpur on July 10, she raised fingers on the way the agricultural system was responding to farmers. She referred to farmers being given targets for seed production and then being forced to purchase seeds from large companies after meeting those targets. Likewise, in Lucknow University, she has questioned hostel Wi-Fi, drinking water, food quality and maintenance. She has also expressed displeasure over sanitation around academic departments and the Tagore Library.

At King George’s Medical University, she questioned the use of expired spice powder in a mess and raised concerns over food and cleanliness. Her intervention prompted the university administration to constitute a special task force for monitoring such facilities. And at Mahatma Gandhi Kashi Vidyapith in Varanasi, her attention again turned to hostels, messes, food, Wi-Fi and sanitation. On the face of it there is nothing wrong in the Governor intervening in the functioning of such institutions as she is entitled to discharge her responsibilities as Chancellor of state universities and other such institutions. But place, timing and possible motive in the face of approaching assembly elections, certainly raise doubts. However, what makes it more intriguing is the fact that her criticism of the state set-up has moved beyond the confines of universities. During her recent visit to Ayodhya, she did not hesitate to take a swipe at the bureaucratic functioning. Her statement that devotees could get darshan at the Ram Temple more easily than a government file could get cleared, took everyone by surprise. The obvious hint was to the bureaucratic Red-tapism prevalent in the state. Under this garb the obvious target seemed to be the political leadership of the ruling party in UP.



The writer is a policy analyst

When welfare schemes punish women for their family size



SWAPNA MAJUMDAR

Women between 21 to 60 will receive ₹2,500 a month provided they meet certain edibility criteria including the number of children. If the woman has more than two children, she automatically becomes ineligible. The reason for imposing this exclusionary clause according to Rekha Gupta, the chief minister of the BJP-led Delhi government was because ‘women are not baby producing machines’ But is it the woman’s fault that she has more than two children? Why is it that women are always held responsible for controlling their family size when most women lack the agency, choice and bodily autonomy to decide how many children they want to have.

Yet, several government programmes to empower women include the number of children as one of main eligibility criteria. Whether the aim is economic empowerment through cash transfer schemes or political empowerment by way of reservations of seats, these

policies benefitting only women with not more than two children, end up violating their reproductive, human and political rights. One of the biggest examples of this disempowerment is the two-child norm set as eligibility condition to contest local panchayat elections and followed by many states even today as a way to ‘control’ population. Women face negative consequences of implementation of the norm directly (as candidates) as well as indirectly (as spouse of those disqualified) in the form of desertion, forced abortions, neglect and death of female infant or female child being given up for adoption. One of the reasons for focussing on women for population stabilisation, whether directly or indirectly, is because they are soft targets. Despite India being a signatory to the programme of action of the International Conference on Population and Development (1994), and committed to providing a basket of contraceptive choices, national data shows that female sterilisation continues to over-



whelmingly dominate family planning procedures in the country. So, it is unsurprising that the national capital has shown a similar trend. In Delhi, over 97 per cent of the 14,543 sterilisation procedures carried out during 2024-25 were performed on women. Only 301 vasectomies took place in the same period, underlining the massive gender gap in sterilisations and unwillingness of men to take responsibility to limit their family size.

dened with an unwanted pregnancy, be punished? A more serious and worrying fall out of this conditional benefit will be the increased desire for the male child. If families stand to benefit from having only two children, the prevailing gender inequalities coupled with deeply entrenched patriarchy and preference for sons, is likely to sound the death knell for girls. More so if the first child is a daughter. How cash transfer schemes help to change percep-

But when women want to plan their families, they have no access to contraception or are not able to use it for spacing or limiting birth, thus increasing their risk of becoming pregnant. This unmet need for family planning increased to 7.3 per cent in 2023-24 from 6.1 per cent in 2019-21 (NFHS-6). While unmet need for spacing increased to 2.7 per cent in 2023-24 from 2.0 per cent in 2019-21, unmet need for limiting or for not wanting any more children, increased to 4.6 per cent from 4.1 per cent for the same period (NFHS-6). Then, why should women, who find themselves burdened with an unwanted pregnancy, be punished?

tion and attitudes of parents towards girls is still not clear according to a study on 15 such schemes by UNFPA. Alarm bells have been ringing for some time now with the continuing trend of declining sex ratio at birth in Delhi. Statistics for 2024 showed a fourth straight year decline in 2024, with 920 females born per 1,000 males, down from 922 in 2023 and 929 in 2022, according to the annual report on births and deaths released by Delhi’s Directorate of Economics and Statistics and the office of Chief Registrar (Births & Deaths). Concerns have been raised by health experts linking the trend to illegal prenatal sex determination in Delhi-NCR. This fear has been compounded by the unavailability of updated data for sex ratio at birth for Delhi in NFHS-6. This is among the several key indicators removed from NFHS-6 by the union health ministry along with mortality rates, and anaemia prevalence. Incidentally, Delhi has reported the country’s lowest total fertility rate (TFR) at 1.2. children per woman, lower than even the national TFR of 1.9 (Sample Registration System Statistical Report 2024). Delhi has also recorded the steepest decline in general fertility rate (GFR) which measures births per 1,000 women aged 15-49. So, the vital question remains- why link women empowerment programmes with the size of their family?

The writer is journalist writing on development and gender

NCB plans year-long drive to bust drug networks

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

India's anti-drug agencies will launch a year-long national enforcement campaign starting next month. The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has told all state and central agencies fighting drug crime to carry out 24 special drives, each lasting two weeks, until August 2027.

The mission is straightforward: find absconding offenders, stop the illegal use of pharmaceutical drugs, clear prisons of trafficking networks, and break up the syndicates harming communities across India. Officials said the NCB's recent message lays out a detailed action plan to support daily enforcement and meet the goals of the new National Vision Document for Narcotics Control 2026-29.

The main goal is still a "Nasha Mukht Bharat, or drug-free India. While awareness programs in schools and colleges have been underway since mid-August, the strict enforcement phase starts in September. In the first two weeks, the focus will be on finding foreign nationals involved in drug crimes and preparing them for deportation. After that, agencies will focus on tracking down narcotics offenders who have escaped justice.

In October, the focus will shift again. Teams from the NCB and state and Union Territory Anti-Narcotics Task Forces will visit medical stores and pharmacies, working closely with local drug controllers. They aim to stop the illegal diversion of legal pharmaceutical drugs into the narcotics trade, which has fueled addiction



and organised crime for years.

The campaign will become even more ambitious over time. In the two subsequent two-week periods, efforts will include creating detailed files on drug-crime fugitives, educating coastal communities about the risks of the maritime drug trade, and con-

ducting coordinated checks at all land, sea, and airport entry points in the second half of December.

In the second half of January 2027, the focus will be on finding and destroying illegal drug cultivation sites. Early February will involve working with the chemical industry to stop the misuse of precursor chemicals, fol-

lowed by joint prison inspections later in the month to ensure jails do not become safe havens for trafficking networks.

Sources say this ongoing campaign is not a typical crackdown. It is a planned, multi-step effort to improve coordination between agencies, increase public awareness, and target every part of the drug trade, from street dealers to international leaders.

By spreading these special operations throughout the year, authorities hope to prevent syndicates from finding gaps to exploit. For years, drug cartels have adapted by using pharmaceutical supply lines, remote growing areas, open borders, and even the privacy of prisons. The new two-week schedule is designed to prevent them from adapting

so easily. Every two weeks, a new focus will put traffickers on the defensive, while law enforcement agencies improve their intelligence, coordination, and progress. The stakes are high.

Each seized shipment and every arrest represents a community hurt by addiction, broken families, and lost futures.

By combining strict enforcement with ongoing student awareness programs, the campaign aims to dismantle drug networks and reduce the demand that sustains them. Hunt is about to intensify, and it will not pause for a full year.

"Syndicates that once operated with relative impunity now face a continuous, nationwide gauntlet designed to leave them nowhere to hide", sources added.

VHP slams Rahul over Manusmriti mindset remark, dares to quote other religions



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) on Sunday criticised Rahul Gandhi for his "Manusmriti mindset" remark and his call to girl students to "smash patriarchy", asking if the Congress leader will muster the same courage to publicly quote what is said about women in other religions.

Interacting with girl students at his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' outreach programme in Pune on Saturday, Gandhi quoted a verse from the Manusmriti that says a woman must obey her father in her childhood, in youth she belongs to her husband, and when he is dead, she belongs to her sons.

Gandhi said women belong to themselves and not to their fathers, husbands or sons, and termed Manusmriti's prescription that a woman should remain under the authority of her male relatives at every stage of her life "shameful".

Reacting to the remarks, VHP national spokesperson Vinod Bansal said in a post on social media, "Rahul Gandhi ji, it is very easy for you to pick a single shloka from the Manusmriti without understanding it and put the Hindu society in the dock... Do not poison the pure minds of the country's youth with your impure mindset."

15 months on, JeM rebuilds Bahawalpur HQ flattened in Operation Sindoor

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Fifteen months after Indian precision strikes destroyed its nerve centre, Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) has fully rebuilt its Markaz Subhan Allah headquarters in Bahawalpur, Pakistan. Fresh marble gleams where impact craters once scarred the central hall. Domes that collapsed under Indian missiles stand rebuilt. Walls carry new plaster and paint.

The sites targeted by the Indian Armed Forces during Operation Sindoor on May 7, 2025, have been thoroughly restored. Private images circulating among security officials show the large complex along the N-5 National Highway looking nearly new again. The main hall's deep holes have been filled, and debris has been cleared from nearby buildings, such as Madrasa Al-Sabir and former homes for Jaish commanders. New buildings are already going up on the cleared land. This was far from a routine repair.

Intelligence reports say the Pakistani establishment paid about 25 crore Pakistani rupees to JeM for the restoration, with around 11 crore spent just on rebuilding the central hall. These payments were made after the strikes that followed the Pahalgam massacre on April 22, 2025, where 26 people, mostly tourists, were killed. In response, India carried out targeted attacks on nine terror camps linked to Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), Lashkar-e-Tayyiba (LeT), and Hizbul Mujahideen in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.

One of the main targets was Bahawalpur's Markaz Subhan Allah, which has long been the operational and ideological centre for Masood Azhar's group.

For years, this facility was used to recruit and indoctrinate members and to plan attacks against India. It included a mosque, a madrasa, a gym, a swimming pool, and living quarters for the Azhar family and senior commanders. After the strikes, Masood Azhar



confirmed that ten of his family members and close aides were killed.

Satellite images taken soon after the event showed collapsed domes. For a while, the site looked abandoned. These images and reports showed collapsed domes, large holes, and piles of debris.

Google Maps marked the site as permanently closed, but this did not last. Central security agencies say fundraising appeals spread through Jaish-linked networks, and heavy machinery soon arrived.

By early 2026, satellite images showed construction

vehicles and workers repairing the damaged domes. All physical evidence of Indian military action was removed. The message is clear: Pakistan's security establishment has chosen to support the revival of a designated terrorist organisation instead of dismantling it.

Jaish-e-Mohammed is still listed as a terrorist group by the United Nations, the United States, and India for attacks like the 2001 Parliament attack and the 2019 Pulwama bombing. Even so, its headquarters in central Punjab province has been rebuilt and funded.

Security analysts say this

pattern is well known.

After every major Indian anti-terror operation, the infrastructure is rebuilt with official protection. Bahawalpur is just 100 kilometres from the international border and near a major Pakistani military corps headquarters. This location is no accident. It shows that groups like Jaish are seen as strategic assets rather than liabilities.

The rebuilt Markaz Subhan Allah is more than just a building. It shows that cross-border terrorism is still active. Recruitment can start again, young members can be indoctrinated, and planning cells can meet under the new roofs.

Fifteen months is a short time in the cycle of terrorism. The domes have been rebuilt, the marble is new, and the threat has returned in full. For India, this highlights a harsh reality: military action can destroy infrastructure, but without ongoing pressure on the state that shelters it, the same infrastructure quickly returns.

Nation Focus



INS SUDARSHINI REACHES LISBON ON 15TH STOP OF LOKAYAN-26 VOYAGE

The Indian Navy's sail training ship, INS Sudarshini, arrived at Lisbon, Portugal, on Saturday, as part of its ongoing Lokayan 26 transoceanic expedition. The three-masted barque made a grand entry through the Tagus River, showcasing traditional sailing and seamanship skills, the defence ministry said here on Sunday.

Giving details, it said during the port call, the ship's crew and trainees will participate in professional exchanges, cross-deck visits, and cultural engagements with Portuguese naval leadership, local authorities, and the Indian diaspora.

The visit to Lisbon marks the ship's 15th port visit in seven months of voyage, reaffirming India's enduring maritime connect and spirit of goodwill across the globe. As part of Lokayan 26, INS Sudarshini continues to carry the message of friendship, cooperation and camaraderie, strengthening bonds with partner nations. (PNS)



160 FOLK ARTISTS FROM 10 STATES FOR KERALA ONAM CELEBRATIONS

Folk traditions from across the country will find a place alongside Kerala's rich cultural heritage as 160 folk artists from 10 states arrive in the state capital to be part of this year's Onam-Tourism Week celebrations.

Artists from Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra, West Bengal, Telangana and Tamil Nadu will present their traditional art forms at various venues across Kerala during the week-long celebrations from August 24 to 30.

The artists will perform in different districts in two regions, offering visitors an opportunity to experience folk traditions from different parts of the country during the festive season, according to an official release here. The artists will also come together for the grand Onam procession on August 30. The procession will begin from Manaveeyam Veedhi at 5 pm and conclude at East Fort. (PTI)

Back women's quota, sing full Vande Mataram at Congress office: Smriti Irani to Rahul Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP general secretary Smriti Irani on Sunday asked Congress leader Rahul Gandhi to validate his words on supporting women by backing the implementation of 33 per cent reservation for them in legislatures and also organising the singing of a full version of Vande Mataram that includes invocation of Goddess Durga at his party office.

Interacting with girl students at his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' outreach programme in Pune on Saturday, Gandhi urged girl students to "smash patriarchy" and lashed out at "Manusmriti mindset", claiming that it forces a woman to remain under the authority of male relatives at every stage of her



life. The former Congress president also said violence is used in society to prevent women from progressing and that 80 per cent of them face harassment.

"Since I have invoked religion, I have a request to that prominent leader of the Congress. The verses of Vande Mataram, some of which were halted at the Congress headquarters, contain a reference to Goddess Durga," Irani, the

newly-appointed BJP national general secretary, told reporters here.

She was referring to the row over the Congress' decision to sing only two stanzas of the 'Vande Mataram' at their party programmes, which the BJP has decried as an "insult" to the national song.

Hitting back at Gandhi, Irani said, "Our religious ethos of Hindus not only upholds the tenet of 'Yatra

naryastu pujiyante ramante tatra devatah' (where women are honoured, divinity resides)", but we also worship Goddesses like Bhagwati, Lakshmi and Saraswati."

"We worship Goddess Durga as the embodiment of 'Shakti' (divine power). I urge that the full rendition of Vande Mataram, including the verses invoking Goddess Durga, be performed at the Congress headquarters," she said.

Gandhi can put his words spoken yesterday in support of women and their leadership into action by backing the "immediate implementation" of reservation for women and organising the rendition of the full version of Vande Mataram at the Congress headquarters, Irani said.

Indian Navy inducts INS Mangrol

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Indian Navy has strengthened its coastal and anti-submarine warfare capabilities with the induction of Mangrol, an Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft (ASW-SWC) built by Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL).

INS Mangrol is the third vessel in the ASW-SWC series and has been constructed with more than 80 per cent indigenous content, underscoring India's growing capabilities in designing and manufacturing defence platforms domestically.

The vessel has been designed primarily for detecting and countering enemy submarines in shallow and coastal waters. Its shallow-water operational capability is supported by a water-jet propulsion system, enabling greater



manoeuvrability in areas where conventional larger warships may face operational limitations.

The warship is equipped with modern sonar systems for underwater surveillance, along with advanced radar and weapons systems. Its armament includes torpedoes and rocket launchers, providing it with the capability to respond rapidly to underwater threats. The vessel can also undertake mine-warfare operations,

including measures aimed at dealing with maritime mines.

The induction has a special significance for Gujarat as the warship has been named after Mangrol, the historic coastal town and port in Junagadh district.

The Navy had earlier operated a minesweeper named INS Mangrol, which served the country until 2004. The commissioning of the new vessel with the same name revives that naval legacy and links the latest addition to the Navy with Gujarat's maritime heritage.

The induction of INS Mangrol also reflects the government's emphasis on Aatmanirbhar Bharat in the defence sector. With a high level of indigenous content, the vessel represents efforts to reduce dependence on imported defence equipment while enhancing India's capacity to build sophisticated naval platforms.

Safdarjung Hospital performs 1st free robot-assisted knee replacement under Ayushman Bharat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Institute of Orthopaedics (CIO) at VMMC and Safdarjung Hospital has performed its first robot-assisted total knee replacement, marking the introduction of advanced robotic orthopaedic surgery at the central government hospital.

The procedure was performed on August 22 on a 75-year-old economically disadvantaged male beneficiary and was carried out completely free of cost under the Ayushman Bharat scheme, the hospital said in a statement. The initiative has been undertaken with the leadership, support and encouragement of Dr Kavita Sharma, Director, VMMC and Safdarjung Hospital.

The procedure was performed under the clinical guidance of Dr Sumit Sural, Director, Central Institute of



Orthopaedics (CIO), with the surgical team led by Dr Bhagwati Prasad Sharma, Consultant Professor and Head of Unit.

The hospital said the introduction of robotic-assisted surgery would strengthen its capacity to provide technology-enabled orthopaedic care within the public healthcare system.

The newly introduced robotic platform is upgradable and can support a range of procedures, including total

knee replacement, partial knee replacement and hip joint replacement.

With future technological and software upgrades, the platform may also support robot-assisted spine surgery, further expanding the scope of advanced surgical services at the institute.

Robot-assisted surgery enables precise pre-operative planning and accurate surgical execution, particularly in implant positioning and alignment, the hospital said.

Create global aura for private space sector so talent comes to India: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has stressed creating an aura around the private sector in space research so that people worldwide feel that if they want to make a career, they should go to India. The prime minister also greeted everyone on the occasion of National Space Day on Sunday.

"Happy National Space Day," he said. Modi also posted a video showing different aspects of India's space research, innovations and success.

"Here's to dreaming even bigger, innovating more and pushing newer frontiers..." he said. National Space Day is celebrated to commemorate the Chandrayaan-3 mission that accomplished a safe and soft landing of the Vikram Lander on the lunar surface on August 23, 2023.

In an interaction with



CEOs and founders of 20 space startups on Friday, Modi also highlighted India's cost-competitiveness in launching space ventures.

He emphasised that the country's vast talent pool and high risk-taking capacity would allow India to rapidly establish a dominant position in the global space sector, according to the transcript of the interaction, which was released on Sunday.

The prime minister said the world must now be looking for Indian startups —

wondering who is leading in this space.

Because whenever a breakthrough happens, people's attention shifts immediately, he said.

One of the CEOs told the prime minister that after India opened the space industry for private players, a very positive trend was observed and many Indian citizens living in the US and Europe now want to return and work in the country.

In response, Modi said: "We need to connect with many people — people who

went abroad are now returning. I believe we should create an aura where people worldwide feel that if they want to make a career, they should go to India."

He said such people from across the globe should feel that they should connect with a startup in India, connect with a space agency in India. "I firmly believe that because of you, we can attract the entire talent pool like a magnet, and that can become a massive strength for us," Modi said.

The prime minister appreciated the CEOs of space startups who showed courage by entering a new sector, and said the biggest factor was that they trusted the government's word.

"My view has always been that whatever decision we make, we must remain consistent and avoid making frequent changes. This ensures that anyone willing to take a risk feels confident that while a mistake on their

end might cause issues, no one will abandon them. Creating that trust was our effort," he said.

Modi also said that India is highly competitive in terms of cost and there is no question about talent.

"We are very competitive on cost; there is no question at all about talent, and our people naturally have a higher risk-taking capacity anyway. Because of these, we can establish our place very rapidly," he said.

The CEOs said India's first space-tech unicorn, Skyroot Aerospace, successfully launched India's first private rocket into orbit, and that was just the beginning.

By mid-2027, they are aiming for one launch per month, the CEOs said.

They thanked the prime minister for opening up the space sector for private players, saying so far, factories have been built with a capacity of one rocket per month.

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‘Govt cannot force landowners to execute sale deeds for acquisitions’



The Allahabad High Court has ruled that government authorities cannot force private landowners to execute sale deeds for the acquisition of land.

The Lucknow bench of the court said on Friday that land can be purchased through a sale deed only when the owner voluntarily agrees to sell and both sides mutually agree on the sale price and if no such consent is forthcoming, the state government will have to follow the statutory land acquisition procedure. With this, the court directed the authorities not to harass the petitioners or forcibly obtain their consent for executing sale deeds. It also made it clear that voluntary sale and compulsory acquisition are two distinct legal processes. A bench of Justice Shekhar B Saraf and Justice Abdhesh Kumar Chaudhary passed the order on a petition filed by Akhilesh Kumar Pankaj and seven others concerning acquisition of their land in Devipatan Tulsipur village of Balrampur district for road widening. The state government told the court that the land was being purchased for widening the road. Nearly 80 per cent of the required land had already been purchased through sale deeds, with around 104 registrations executed by different landowners. However, the authorities had not been able to contact the petitioners or obtain their consent for the purchase of their land. The petitioners, on the other hand, submitted that they were not willing to sell their land. They alleged that the authorities were pressuring them to sell their property at a rate which was unacceptable to them.

After considering the issue, the bench observed that the law on the issue was clear and hence, if the landowners were willing to sell and the state was able to negotiate and arrive at an agreement on the sale price, they could sell the property to the state. However, in the absence of such consent, the state would have to issue a notification under the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, and acquire the land in accordance with law, the bench added. The court directed the authorities not to harass the petitioners or forcibly obtain their consent for execution of sale deeds. It clarified that if any petitioner voluntarily wished to sell the property, a sale deed could be executed in accordance with law. (PTI)

NGT seeks Govt’s response on plea against new Ganga rules



The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has sought a response from the Centre on a petition challenging recent changes to the rules governing the protection of the Ganga.

The National Mission for Clean Ganga and the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change are also among the respondents. The green tribunal was hearing a plea alleging that a government notification issued in August 2026 removed the crucial “no construction zone” along the river and its tributaries, which was contrary to the environmental rules.

According to the plea, the new notification is “ultra vires” of the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, and destroys the original scheme intended to protect the river. A bench of NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afroz Ahmad noted the claim that the notification amending the River Ganga (Rejuvenation, Protection and Management) Authorities Order of 2016 is contrary to the earlier judgments of the tribunal, constitutional courts, the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986 and the original notification. (PTI)

Delhi court grants probation to two in 2013 stabbing case for good conduct

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has released two men on probation for good conduct, 13 years after they were booked for stabbing a man with a screwdriver, saying that sending them to jail at this belated stage would serve no meaningful purpose.

Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Partap Singh Laler was hearing appeals filed by Amrith Thakur alias Mirchi and Yogender Lal alias Jhunjhun against a July 2025 magisterial court order that had sentenced them to six months of simple imprisonment under sections 324 (vol-

untarily causing hurt by dangerous weapons or means) and 341 (wrongful restraint) of the Indian Penal Code (IPC).

According to the prosecution, Thakur and Lal, along with another co-accused, Rakesh, accosted Deepak on October 19, 2013, and stabbed him with a screwdriver in the neck and shoulders. They also hit him on the head with a stone.

In an order dated August 3, the court said, “Section 4 of the Probation of Offenders Act, 1958, empowers a court, where a person is found guilty of an offence not punishable with death or imprisonment for life, to release such offender on probation of



SC to hear plea for CBI probe in JPSC Civil Services Prelims

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a plea seeking an independent, time-bound probe by the CBI into alleged malpractices in the Jharkhand Combined Civil Services Preliminary Examination.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana is likely to take up the petition filed by activist Harisharan Devgan, through advocate Satyam Singh Rajput, for hearing.

“The present writ petition under Article 32 of the Constitution of India is being preferred in public interest

seeking urgent intervention of this court in relation to serious and substantial concerns regarding the integrity, fairness, transparency and credibility of the Jharkhand Combined Civil Services Preliminary Competitive Examination-2025, conducted by respondent no. 2-Jharkhand Public Service Commission pursuant to Advertisement No. 01/2026 on April 19, 2026,” it said.

The plea has also sought transfer of the investigation from the state CID to the CBI to ensure an impartial probe into public officials and examination agencies.

“The petitioner submits that the controversy cannot appropriately be examined



merely as a dispute concerning individual candidates or isolated instances of alleged malpractice. “The allegations require examination of the entire examination chain, including preparation and printing of question papers, coding, storage, transporta-

tion, distribution, conduct of the examination, collection and custody of OMR sheets, scanning, coding and decoding, evaluation, storage and access to electronic examination data, generation of the result and publication thereof,” it said. It has also

Udan vs Udaan: Delhi court restrains pharma firm from using Udaan mark

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has permanently restrained a Hyderabad-based pharmaceutical company from using the trademark ‘Udaan’ or any similar mark, ruling that it was a clear violation of the rights of consumer goods major RSPL Health Private Limited, which had earlier registered its mark ‘Udan.’

District Judge Pankaj Sharma, in an ex parte judgment dated August 13, held that the defendant, Sainus Pharmaceutical Private Limited, used the mark ‘Udaan’ in a manner that was “identical and deceptively similar” to the plaintiff’s (RSPL’s) registered trademark ‘Udan’. The court noted that, according to RSPL Health, known for brands like ‘Ghari’ detergent, it had adopted the trademark or label Udan with respect to the



goods and business of sanitary napkins in 2007 and Sainus Pharma’s Udaan mark had infringed its proprietary rights in the said trademark.

“The defendant (Sainus) is not only making the retail sales but is also supplying the impugned goods bearing the impugned trade marks to various other dealers/shopkeepers/retailers in New Delhi, who are making the clandestine and surreptitious sales thereof to the ultimate unwary consumers in the markets of New Delhi viz. Parliament Street, Connaught Place, Barakhamba, Chanakyapuri, Gole Market,

Bengali Market etc.” RSPL said.

In its order, the court said that the defendant did not appear before it, and thus the plaintiff’s contentions remain unrebutted, unchallenged, and uncontroverted.

“The plaintiff has established that the defendant has infringed the said trademark and has also committed passing off of goods. Therefore, there is no doubt that the plaintiff is entitled to relief of permanent injunction against the defendant for using the trademark ‘Udaan’ or any other mark identical or deceptively similar to the word mark, label of plaintiff’s trademark Udan,” the court said. Besides the permanent injunction, the court ordered that all seized counterfeit products and infringing materials, including packaging, dies, and blocks bearing the falsified mark, be delivered to RSPL Health for destruction.

Kerala HC pulls up MVD over inaction against modified SUV used in flood rescue

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court has criticised the MVD for failing to take effective action against a modified SUV fitted with unauthorised lights and other alterations, which was used in flood rescue operations in Aranmula earlier this month.

A division bench comprising Justice Anil K Narendran and Justice Muralee Krishna S heard cases relating to road safety and illegal vehicle alterations and examined the Transport Commissioner’s report on the vehicle and the action taken against it on August 21.



The private vehicle came to the court’s notice after two Motor Vehicles Department officials in Adoor were suspended for issuing a challan against it for illegal alterations and lack of a pollution certificate while it was returning from a flood rescue operation. In its order, the bench noted that according to the transport commissioner’s report dated

August 20, 2026, the MVD Enforcement Wing had imposed only a ‘5,000 fine on the vehicle, despite it being fitted with six unauthorised additional lights and repeated directions from court.

The bench observed that the MVD Enforcement Wing and police had failed to take action against vehicles being used in public places with wheels projecting laterally beyond the protection provided by the vehicle’s body, wings or protective covers, potentially causing mud or water to be thrown up and endangering cyclists, two-wheeler riders and pedestrians. The court noted that an e-challan issued

against the vehicle on March 11, 2024, remained pending, and that it had again been used in a public place with unauthorised lights and other fittings, posing a serious threat to other road users.

The special government pleader submitted that a proper report from the transport commissioner would be placed on record and sought additional time to do so. The court directed the MVD Enforcement Wing and the police to take necessary steps to ensure strict compliance with its earlier directions on vehicle modifications. The case will be taken up again on September 7.

Delhi HC seeks NALSA’s stand on PIL seeking free aid for needy to tender electronic evidence

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Delhi High Court has sought the stand of the Centre and NALSA on a PIL seeking free forensic expert assistance for the needy to enable them to present electronic evidence in court under the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam.

A bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia issued notices to the National Legal Services



Authority (NALSA) and the Centre on the PIL filed by two lawyers, Zeeshan Ekhlague and Aman Bhide. The bench observed that prima facie, the inability of the needy to

present electronic evidence in the absence of means to seek assistance of an expert impinged upon their right to access to justice.

“We accordingly require the NALSA to consider the matter and apprise the court of a possible scheme which may be applicable,” the court said on August 19. The petitioners said that under the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam (BSA), tendering electronic evidence in a case by any person required a certificate

signed by an expert and those belonging to marginalised, vulnerable and poor backgrounds may lack the financial means to obtain this assistance.

The petition said that in response to an RTI application, NALSA specifically stated that “there is no provision of expert assistance” to persons entitled to free legal aid for preparing certificates as per Section 63 of the BSA, 2023. The court listed the case for hearing in October.

previous conviction, the benefit of probation ought ordinarily to be extended, subject to appropriate safeguards such as payment of compensation and furnishing of a bond for good behaviour.

“The convicts have already remained under the continuing strain of prosecution, trial, and appellate proceedings for nearly 13 years since the year 2013, which itself constitutes a substantial deterrent and reformative consequence, quite apart from any sentence of imprisonment,” it said.

The court said that the offence, though serious enough to warrant conviction, does not disclose any

sought direction to immediately secure all physical and digital evidence, including original and candidate-held OMR carbon copies, CCTV footage, and server audit logs, to prevent tampering. “The petitioner is conscious that the mere existence of allegations or public protests cannot, by itself, justify cancellation of an examination. The petitioner, therefore, does not seek cancellation merely on the basis of media reports or allegations. “The principal relief sought is for an independent, impartial, comprehensive and time-bound investigation by the Central Bureau of Investigation, so that the nature, extent, mechanism

and impact of the alleged irregularities may be objectively determined,” it said. It further added that the consequential question whether the preliminary examination can safely be relied upon must thereafter be determined on the basis of objective and scientifically verifiable evidence.

The petitioner said he raises a constitutional question concerning whether a public recruitment examination conducted by a constitutional authority has retained the minimum degree of fairness, transparency, reliability and institutional integrity necessary for its result to constitute the lawful basis for public appointments.



jumped bail granted in 2010, resulting in the proceedings against him remaining pending, the spokesperson said. In a significant breakthrough, he said the NCB subsequently traced him to Jammu’s Amphalla jail, and secured his production before the competent court in August last year, thereby bringing him back within

the judicial process.

It wasn’t immediately clear under which case the accused was sent to Amphalla jail.

Following sustained legal proceedings, a special NDPS court here sentenced Bharti to three years’ imprisonment and imposed a fine of ₹10,000 on August 11, the official said.

UP: HC slams alleged attempt to influence civil judge in land dispute case



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court has deplored an alleged attempt to “influence” a civil judge in a land dispute by the Divisional Commissioner of Dehri Patan, a litigant in a three-decade-old case, saying it struck at the independence of the judiciary and obstructed the administration of justice.

Citing a Supreme Court precedent on threats or pressure against judges in relation to judicial proceedings, the High Court’s Lucknow bench held that the matter required consideration by the court dealing with criminal contempt cases.

Justice Syed Qamar Hasan Rizvi directed that the matter be placed before the appropriate court after seeking directions from the Chief Justice or a senior judge.

The High Court said it could not ignore the allegations surrounding the phone call allegedly made by Divisional Commissioner

Durga Shakti Nagpal to the Civil Judge, Shabina Khan, and said it was shocking that a litigating party could approach a court through such a call in the context of a pending matter. Justice Rizvi passed the order on Friday in the course of hearing a transfer application filed by the applicant Jyoti Vidya Mandir School against the Municipal Council of Gonda in 1997 in a regular suit pending in the court of Judge Khan. The dispute concerns several parcels of Nazul land recorded in the name of the Commissioner, Devi Patan Division. According to the Divisional Commissioner’s version placed before the bench, the land had been reserved for construction of an office building and other government purposes.

The state authorities alleged that a school building had been constructed on the land and that the dispute over it had remained pending before the civil court for nearly three decades.

element of moral turpitude, premeditated cruelty, or repeated criminal conduct that would militate against the grant of probation.

“This court is satisfied that this is a fit case for the grant of the benefit of probation... and that sending the convicts to prison at this belated stage would serve no meaningful or deterrent purpose, but would, on the contrary, be productive of the very harm that the (the Probation of Offenders) Act seeks to avert,” Judge Laler said.

He modified the magistrate’s order “without disturbing or interfering with the finding of conviction” and said that the convicts be

released on probation of good conduct for a period of one year, in lieu of undergoing the substantive sentence of imprisonment imposed upon them.

As part of the conditions for their release, the judge directed each convict to deposit Rs 10,000 as compensation to be paid to the victim. They were also ordered to furnish a bond of Rs 15,000 each to maintain peace and good behaviour for a period of one year. The court warned that if they fail to deposit the compensation or breach the peace during the probation period, they would be liable to serve the original six-month jail sentence.

Climate Proofing the Future with Ancient Rice: India’s Heirloom Varieties

As climate change tightens its grip on Indian agriculture, the search for resilient crops has become one of the defining challenges of our time. Floods are inundating fertile plains, prolonged droughts are exhausting groundwater, and rising sea levels are pushing saltwater into coastal farmlands. Scientists are investing heavily in developing climate resilient crops, yet some of the most promising solutions may not lie in sophisticated laboratories but in the forgotten seed baskets of India’s farmers. Long before climate resilience became a scientific objective, generations of cultivators across the subcontinent had already developed rice varieties capable of surviving floods, droughts, saline soils and other environmental extremes. In an age of climatic uncertainty, these heirloom grains are emerging as living repositories of genetic resilience.

For centuries, Indian agriculture thrived not because farmers cultivated a single superior variety of rice, but because they nurtured extraordinary diversity. Every landscape shaped its own seed. River valleys favoured varieties that could withstand seasonal flooding, dry uplands required drought tolerant grains, while coastal communities preserved rice capable of growing in saline conditions. Farmers patiently selected seeds from the healthiest plants, refined them over generations, and adapted them to local soils, rainfall patterns and cultural preferences. This continuous dialogue between nature and cultivator transformed India into one of the world’s richest centres of rice agrobiodiversity, where thousands of indigenous landraces evolved long before the emergence of formal plant breeding.

The Green Revolution fundamentally transformed Indian agriculture by dramatically increasing food production and helping the country overcome chronic grain shortages. However, its success also encouraged widespread cultivation of a relatively small number of high yielding varieties. As traditional landraces gradually disappeared from farmers’ fields, India lost an immense reservoir of genetic diversity that had evolved over centuries. This erosion of agrobiodiversity received little attention when productivity remained the overriding concern. Today, however, as climate change exposes the vulnerability of genetically uniform cropping systems, the value of these forgotten seeds is being reassessed by agricultural scientists worldwide.

Among India’s most remarkable heirloom varieties is *Pokkali*, cultivated for generations in the saline coastal wetlands of Kerala. Farmers had long recognised its ability to flourish in fields periodically inundated by seawater, but only recently has molecular research revealed the sophistication of its natural adaptations. Scientists have shown that



MEENAKSHI LEKHI
FORMER MINISTER OF
STATE FOR EXTERNAL
AFFAIRS, GOVT. OF INDIA



**Dr. NAVANEETH
KRISHNAN S.**
SENIOR RESEARCH
FELLOW, BHARAT
KI SOCH

drought conditions. *Kuzhiyadichan* combines tolerance to drought and salinity, *Mattaikar* adapts to drought and sodic soils, and *Poongar* and *Sorna Masuri* continue to thrive in saline environments. Such diversity demonstrates that climate adaptation was deeply embedded within India’s traditional farming systems centuries before the concept

Pokkali possesses unique genetic mechanisms that regulate salt balance within plant cells and activate complex stress response pathways, enabling it to tolerate not only salinity but also several related environmental stresses. What traditional farmers conserved through experience is now recognised by modern science as one of the world’s most valuable genetic resources for breeding climate resilient rice.

Pokkali is far from an isolated example. Across India, numerous indigenous varieties illustrate how farmers responded to different ecological challenges with remarkable precision. *Samba Mosanam* is known for surviving prolonged flooding, while *Kullankar* performs well under

entered scientific literature.

Equally significant is the nutritional wisdom preserved within these heirloom grains. Traditional farmers rarely separated productivity from human health. Rice varieties were valued not only for their ability to withstand environmental stress but also for their nutritional and medicinal qualities. *Mappillai Samba*, long associated with strength and endurance in Tamil Nadu, contains high levels of antioxidants, iron and dietary fibre. Kerala’s *Navara (Njavara)* has occupied a distinctive place in Ayurvedic practice for centuries because of its therapeutic properties, while *Kavuni*, an ancient black rice, is rich in anthocyanins and other bioactive compounds now recognised for their health promoting potential. These examples reflect an agricultural tradition that viewed food, health and ecology as interconnected rather than separate domains.

Behind every surviving landrace lies an equally remarkable system of indigenous knowledge. Farmers continuously selected superior seeds exchanged them through community networks and adapted them to changing environmental conditions. Women played a central role in conserving seed diversity within households, ensuring that valuable genetic resources were passed from one generation to the next. Every village effectively functioned as a living seed bank, conserving biodiversity through cultivation rather than storage.

The future of Indian agriculture will depend not on choosing between traditional knowledge and modern science, but on bringing the two together. Plant breeders increasingly recognise that heirloom rice varieties possess genes that can strengthen future cultivars against floods, drought, salinity and emerging climatic stresses. Conserving indigenous seeds is therefore not an exercise in nostalgia but a strategic investment in national food security. Among the many climate resilient landraces documented across India are *Pokkali*, *Mappillai Samba*, *Navara*, *Kavuni*, *Samba Mosanam*, *Kullankar*, *Kuzhiyadichan*, *Mattaikar*, *Nootripathu*, *Norungan*, *Poongar*, *Sorna*, *Sorna Masuri*, *Karuthakar Poha*, *Aijong*, *Balijira*, *Kalijira*, *Kushal*, *Lal Kartika*, *Maloti*, *Moniraj*, *Najira*, *Saada Kartika*, *Sornomoshari*, *Swarnabh* and *Khonkosh*, each preserving unique adaptations shaped by centuries of farmer innovation.

As India prepares for an increasingly uncertain climatic future, these ancient grains offer a powerful reminder that resilience is often inherited rather than invented. The farmers who patiently shaped these landraces were not merely cultivating crops; they were building a genetic insurance policy for generations they would never meet. Rediscovering and conserving this indigenous seed wisdom may prove to be one of the most important agricultural investments of the twenty first century.

“

INDIA'S HEIRLOOM RICE VARIETIES OFFER MORE THAN AGRICULTURAL HERITAGE; THEY HOLD GENETIC RESILIENCE SHAPED OVER CENTURIES. FROM FLOOD AND DROUGHT TOLERANCE TO SALINITY RESISTANCE AND NUTRITIONAL RICHNESS, THESE ANCIENT GRAINS REVEAL HOW TRADITIONAL FARMING WISDOM CAN HELP CLIMATE-PROOF INDIA'S FOOD FUTURE.

”

UNJUMBLE

1. Unjumble these scrambled words to form the terms from Ancient India often used in Agriculture & Food Security:

HKIRSI

ALH

OAIBL

AAUVR

1. Arrange the circled letters to answer the following:

Bull for ploughing: _____

Answer: 1. Krishi, 2. Vashi

Marvels of India

MONSOON KNOWLEDGE AND CROP TIMING

Rain Prediction

Long before modern meteorology, ancient Indian scholars built systematic frameworks to anticipate the monsoon. The *Krishni Parashara* (traditionally dated to 400 BCE, though some scholars place it between 6th and 11th centuries CE) details astrological and meteorological indicators for forecasting monsoon rains. It advises farmers to observe wind direction daily using a rod with a flag to forecast rainfall, blending astronomical observation with practical field guidance. It also contains specific instructions for seed collection, preservation and optimal sowing times.

Codifying the Seasons

Varahamihira’s *Brihat Samhita* (6th century CE) dedicated entire chapters to predicting monsoon patterns based on which *nakshatra* the moon occupied during specific seasons. It highlighted the vital role of monsoon rains in ensuring agricultural prosperity and food security.

State-Organised Planning

Kautilya’s *Arthashastra* (4th century BCE-3rd century CE) institutionalised this knowledge: the *Sitadhyaksha* (superintendent of agriculture) was tasked with seed preservation, irrigation oversight, regulation of manure and seasonal planning.

A Living Legacy

This astro-meteorological tradition was transmitted through the *Krishni Panchang*, structured by agricultural seasons and tailored to local climate, soil and cropping patterns, that rural Bharat still follows.

Fable with Moral

Nala and Damayanti

(Mahabharata, Vana Parva)

The tale of Nala and Damayanti from the Mahabharata’s Vana Parva is an epic story of love, separation and ultimate redemption.

Nala, the righteous king of Nishadha, and Damayanti, the beautiful princess of Vidarbha, fell in love through messages carried by a golden swan. At Damayanti’s Swayamvara, the gods Indra, Agni, Varuna, and Yama disguised themselves as Nala to win her hand. Unable to distinguish them, Damayanti prayed sincerely. Impressed by her devotion, the gods revealed their identities by not blinking or casting shadows, allowing her to successfully choose Nala. Their happiness was cut short by the demon Kali. Seeking ruin, Kali possessed Nala after he committed a minor ritual error. Under this evil influence, Nala played a game of dice with his brother Pushkara, losing his entire kingdom and wealth. Exile followed and out of grief and a desire to save Damayanti from suffering, Nala abandoned her while she slept.

Wandering alone, Nala rescued the snake king Karkotaka from a fire. The snake bit Nala, turning him into an unrecognizable, dwarfed charioteer named Bahuka to protect him from Kali and gave him a magic garment to regain his form. Nala then worked for King Rituparna of Ayodhya.

Meanwhile, Damayanti safely reached her father’s palace. To find Nala, she announced a fake second Swayamvara, knowing only Nala could drive a chariot from Ayodhya to Vidarbha in a single

day. Rituparna rushed to the event with Nala driving. Along the way, Rituparna taught Nala the ultimate secrets of dice in exchange for horse-riding expertise, which expelled Kali from Nala’s body.

At Vidarbha, Damayanti recognized Nala by his unmatched cooking skills and chariot speed. Nala donned the magic garment, regained his true appearance and happily reunited with his family. Armed with his new dice skills, Nala returned to Nishadha, defeated Pushkara and successfully reclaimed his kingdom.

MORAL OF THE FABLE : Never give up; perseverance is the key to success.

Did you know?

The lakeside settlement of Lahuradewa in Sant Kabir Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, has yielded some of South Asia’s earliest archaeological evidence for the use—and possibly cultivation—of rice. Excavations uncovered carbonised rice grains, husks and other plant remains from its earliest occupation levels, with evidence extending back to around the 7th millennium BCE. The excavators identified some remains as domesticated rice (*Oryza sativa*) and argued for an early farming tradition in the Middle Ganga Plain.

Lahuradewa is therefore central to an important debate about the history of rice. Its finds suggest that communities of the Ganga valley may have begun managing and cultivating local rice independently, pointing to an indigenous trajectory of rice agriculture in northern India rather than rice farming simply arriving there fully developed from East Asia.

It has also been suggested that locally managed or cultivated rice populations in northern India formed a proto-*indica* tradition, which much later interacted and hybridised with fully domesticated *japonica* rice arriving from East Asia. Whichever way we see it, the evidence from Lahuradewa does help to place the Middle Ganga valley as an important early centre in the long process through which wild rice became a cultivated crop.

QUIZ

Agriculture & Food Security

Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1 Which Neolithic site has shown the earliest evidence of farming in the Indian subcontinent, as early as 7000 BCE?	Gufkral	Burzahom	Mehrgarh	Maski
2 Which archaeological feature at Mohenjo-daro and Harappa provides a significant evidence of a centralized food security system during the Indus Valley Civilization?	Ploughed fields	Dockyards	Citadels	Granaries
3 In the Later Vedic texts, the term 'Vrihi' was used to distinguish a specific crop from 'Godhuma'. What crop did 'Vrihi' refer to?	Wheat	Rice	Barley	Pearl Millet
4 What was the irrigation tax collected from peasants who utilized state-built canals, reservoirs or tanks in the Mauryan period?	Udakabhaga	Pranaya	Pindakara	Shulka
5 Which of them was not a cash/commercial crop during the Tamil Sangam Age?	Cotton	Sugarcane	Sandalwood	Red Rice

Answers: 1-C, 2-Z, 3-B, 4-A, 5-D

Mahabharata

Protect The Nation

1 DRAUPADI

YUDHISHTHIRA

My sons are dead! I will not leave this spot until that cruel Ashwatthama is punished for his sins!

Patience, Draupadi. Our sons died as brave warriors. We do not even know where that sinner hides.

2 BHIMA

Brother! Grant me permission. I will hunt down Ashwatthama and avenge our children!

Go, dear brother. May victory be yours.

3 KRISHNA

You made a mistake, Yudhishtira. Ashwatthama is reckless! He holds the ultimate weapon—the Brahmarshira. He once even begged for my Chakra to become invincible, but couldn't lift it. He cannot be trusted!

YOUNG ASHWATTHAMA

4

Realizing the grave danger Bhima is in, Krishna, Arjuna, and Yudhishtira race to catch up with him.

5 ASHWATTHAMA

You leave me no choice! This is the end! I unleash the Brahmarshira... DEATH TO ALL PANDAVAS!

6 KRISHNA

Arjuna, look! The three worlds are burning! Quickly, release your weapon to stop him!

ARJUNA

May the heavens protect us! I release my Brahmarshira to neutralize his!

7 SAGE NARADA

STOP, brave warriors! If these celestial weapons collide, the earth will be shattered, and rain will not fall for twelve years!

SAGE VYASA

8 ARJUNA

SAGE VYASA

ASHWATTHAMA

Forgive me, O Sages, I withdraw my weapon for the sake of the world.

Ashwatthama! Withdraw your weapon now! The Pandavas, yourself, and above all, THE NATION, must be protected at all costs!

MORAL OF THE STORY:

"TRUE STRENGTH LIES NOT IN THE POWER TO DESTROY, BUT IN THE WISDOM TO EXERCISE RESTRAINT FOR THE GREATER GOOD OF THE NATION AND HUMANITY."

FROM THE WORLD

CHINA

Lunar mission postponed

China said on Sunday it was postponing its planned ambitious Chang'e-7 lunar mission, which was set to carry out explorations including searching for water ice on the moon.

The Chang'e-7 spacecraft was originally set to lift off in the coming days from the Wenchang Space Launch

The mission does not meet the launch conditions, said the China Manned Space Agency in a brief statement, and "cannot take place during the planned window this year."

The decision was made following a "comprehensive assessment," the agency added, and was based on the principles of "prudence, reliability and absolute mission success." It did not further elaborate on the reasons behind the decision. (AP)

BANGLADESH

Four of family killed, 2 held

A retired Hindu school teacher along with his wife and two children were allegedly killed at their residence in Bangladesh's Rangpur city, according to a media report.

The deceased were identified as Ganapati Chakraborty, 65, Pritilata Chakraborty, 50, Agami Chakraborty Prarthi, 23, and Priyam Chakraborty, 12, the Daily Star newspaper reported.

The police have detained two men, identified as Mugdhoo and Siddhartha, for their involvement in the killings. They are cousins.

The duo allegedly entered the rooftop of Chakraborty's house through a neighbouring building and took the drug yaba there on Thursday night, Rangpur Metropolitan Police Commissioner Mohammad Abdul Mabud said on Sunday.

Zelenskyy details rift with dismissed defence minister

SAMYA KULLAB ■ Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said he believes actions taken by dismissed Defence Minister Mykhailo Fedorov, including his involvement in mass protests and calls for elections, were misguided, as he publicly detailed their dispute for the first time.

Zelenskyy also alluded to problematic decisions over defence spending and said inaccurate information provided by the Defence Ministry contributed to an awkward encounter with US President Donald Trump over the use of Starlink in Russia.

Zelenskyy disclosed figures showing Ukraine's growing shortage of Patriot air-defence missiles needed to counter Russian ballistic attacks, with deliveries from Western allies declining in the past three years even as Russian missile strikes intensified.

He highlighted battlefield gains, however, saying Ukrainian forces have almost completely recaptured the Dnipropetrovsk region, with only about 10 square kilometres remaining under Russian control.

He made the remarks during a two-hour off-the-record meeting with reporters on Saturday, with a transcript released publicly on Sunday.



His comments ranged widely, covering the latest battlefield developments, efforts to counter Russian ballistic attacks, the state of peace negotiations, Ukraine's budgetary challenges and the political turmoil surrounding Fedorov's dismissal.

"I really had and still have a very positive attitude toward Mykhailo. We have been through a lot together. But I believe that he himself goes, or is pushed, into the wrong things," he said.

Fedorov, a popular minister credited with modernising Ukraine's armed forces and accelerating the military's embrace of technology and drone warfare, was dismissed last month after reportedly falling out with the country's top military commander. His removal triggered mass protests that lasted for weeks but ultimately failed to force a reversal of the decision. Fedorov later called for elections in a video address.

Zelenskyy said he had offered Fedorov four different options to continue working in Government. Fedorov, he said, rejected all four proposals.

The Ukrainian leader told journalists that he believes holding an election during the war would be a huge risk with potential to "split Ukraine apart."

"I believe elections during a war like this would gener-

ally pose enormous risks. Holding elections right now would be a tsunami for the state that would split Ukraine apart," he said.

Zelenskyy said he had previously faced pressure to hold elections during the war, but no partners had come up with a plan for how a poll could be held safely, legitimately and democratically.

Zelenskyy appeared to link Fedorov to an awkward episode involving Starlink and Elon Musk. Zelenskyy said that earlier this year the Defence Ministry had told him that SpaceX had agreed to allow Ukraine to use Starlink over Russian territory to carry out deep strike operations, subject to political approval.

Acting on that, Zelenskyy said he raised the issue directly with US President Donald Trump. He told Trump that Musk had confirmed the proposed use. Zelenskyy said the two sides subsequently sought Musk's confirmation and discussed financing for the project.

But at a later meeting, Zelenskyy said Trump told him that Musk had rejected the proposal and accused him of having misled the US president. Musk considered the move a dangerous escalation, according to Zelenskyy. (AP)

Cross-border crimes discussed at Nepal-India joint security meeting

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Security officials from Nepal and India discussed ways to curb cross-border criminal activities and illegal trade at a meeting, deciding to enhance joint border patrols and increase regular information exchange.

The coordination meeting of security officers from three districts of Nepal's Madhesh province and adjoining districts of India was held in the province's Jaleswar city on Saturday. It was jointly chaired by Chief District Officer of Mahottari district Indra Dev Yadav and District Magistrate of Bihar's Sitamadhi Tanay Sultania. During the meeting,



the two sides discussed various contemporary issues related to cross-border security and reviewed progress made in the implementation of decisions taken during the previous meetings, according to officials. The two sides also discussed strategies they could adopt to combat cross-border crimes, including arms

Bangladesh open to joining Saudi-Pak-Turkiye defence pact

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Bangladesh is open to joining the recently formed defence alliance between Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkiye, two junior ministers have said, while stressing that any decision would be guided by the country's national interests.

Signed in Makkah on August 7, the pact establishes a framework for collective deterrence and stipulates that an armed attack on any one of the three countries would be considered an attack on all three.

"Bangladesh maintains a positive approach towards the possibility of joining an economic or defence framework involving Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkiye, taking



Pakistan Saudi Arabia defence pact

into account its own interests and the changing dynamics of the global economy and trade," newly appointed state minister for foreign affairs Humayun Kobir said. In an interview with the Bangla service of state-run BSS on Friday, Kobir said the Government was pursuing a "Bangladesh First" policy and a balanced foreign policy with national inter-

ests at its core, which might lead Dhaka to join the defence pact. He said Bangladesh would also strengthen bilateral ties with Pakistan through normal diplomatic engagement, focusing on trade and people-to-people connectivity. Kobir, appointed as the second state minister for foreign affairs on Friday, said Prime Minister Tarique

Rahman is expected to visit Riyadh at Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's invitation and the tour schedule is likely to be finalised after the summer.

Another state minister for foreign affairs, Shama Obaed Islam, in a separate media interaction on Friday, supplemented Kobir's comments, saying Bangladesh's national interest and the interests of its people would determine Dhaka's stance on joining the pact.

"Whether we join any pact or any multilateral body will be decided primarily on whether Bangladesh's interests and the interests of the Bangladeshi people are protected," she said when asked whether Bangladesh would be part of the trilateral framework.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, No.14593898A Hav H Manglemma Singha (Retd), resident of Vill- Machpara, P.O- Machpara, PS- Silchar, Dist- Cachar, State- Assam, PIN- 788009 have changed my daughter's name and date of birth from Shyamalini Devi, DOB 02 Nov 1999 to H Shyamolini Devi, DOB- 02 Jan 1999 vide affidavit dated 21/08/2026 before 1st Class Magistrate, Silchar, Cachar, Assam.

I, Mejren Xalxo, W/o JC-562396A Sub Mel Prakash Xalxo, R/o- Chitarkota Barkatoli, Ranchi, Jharkhand - 835205, have changed my name from Mejren Xalxo to Mejhren Xalxo, vide affidavit dated 22/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, JC-562396A Sub Mel Prakash Xalxo, R/o- Chitarkota Barkatoli, Ranchi, Jharkhand - 835205, have changed my daughter's name from Prenna Xalxo to Prenna Xalxo, vide affidavit dated 22/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Vitthalrao, Father of No.4583548H Nk Bhange Lalkrishana Vitthalrao, R/o- Vill&PO- Wadhona (Bk), Teh- Udgir, Dist- Latur, Maharashtra- 413518, have changed my name from Vitthalrao to Vitthalrao Kondiba Bhange, vide affidavit dated 22/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Monika Challoo W/O Navvin Chalu employed as VP in the Barclays residing at Siddharth Vihar, Ghaziabad have changed the name of my minor daughter Titiksha aged 17 and she shall hereafter be known as Titiksha Chalu.

I, Monika Challoo W/O Navvin Chalu employed as VP in the Barclays residing at Siddharth Vihar, Ghaziabad have changed the name of my minor daughter Triaksha aged 17 and she shall hereafter be known as Triaksha Chalu.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Kailash Eye Care, 50-51 South Patel Nagar Market, New Delhi-110008 hereby brings to the kind attention of all concerned that it is being planned to destroy old impatent records pertaining to the period before 31st March 2016. In case any person/patient relative thereof wants to see their treatment records, please contact Medical Records Department, within 30 days from the date of notice.

Director Medical Services KAILASH EYE CARE, 50-51 South Patel Nagar Market, New Delhi-110008

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed that my client, Shri Pardeep Kumar son of Late Shri Hira Lal and his wife Smt. Hemlata Kumari both resident of C-437, Avantika Sector-1, Rohini, Delhi-110085 have severed all kinds of relationship with his brothers namely (1) Shri Roshan Kumar and (2) Shri Inder Mohan and their wives and children. Henceforth, my client and his wife shall have no relationship with them. Any person dealing with them will do so at their own risks.

Fanish K. Jain (Advocate) Off-D-847, Basement Floor, Saraswati Vihar, Pitampura Delhi

सार्वजनिक सूचना

मेरे मुवक्किलन बहादुर एवं उनकी पत्नी श्रीमती नीलमा देवीजी निवासी 8/189, बिजुवपुरा, दिल्ली-110091, ने अपने पुत्री बीना को उसके दुस्वर्गवार एवं गलत संत के कारण अपनी समस्त चल अचल सम्पत्ति से बेदखलकर कर, संबंध विच्छेद कर लिए हैं व उसका मेरे मुवक्किलन को चल अचल सम्पत्ति से किसी भी प्रकार कोई लेना देना नहीं है, भविष्य में उसके किसी भी कृत्य हेतु मेरे मुवक्किलन व उनके परिवार को कोई जिम्मेवारी नहीं होगी।

राहुल लाल अखरिया अधिवक्ता

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Vasu Bhutani who is purchasing Entire Freehold built up property bearing no. G-56 (plot no. -56 in block -G), built on land measuring 200 sq. Yds. (167.2 sq. Mtrs.), village Basal Darapur Delhi State Delhi, Colony Known As Mansarovar Garden, New Delhi-110015, from Mrs. Madhu Mehta wife of Lt. Mr. Anil Mehta vide Relinquishment deed dated 24/04/2026 duly registered as Document no. 2026/22/15042, in Advt. Book No.1, Volume no.31674 on pages 91 to 100 dated 21.04.2026, SRO-West Basal Darapur, New Delhi and initially the subject property was owned Suraj Prakash vide Sale Deed dated 08.08.1959. Suraj Prakash expired after his demise the property was owned by his wife Mrs. Savitri Mehta vide Relinquishment Deed dated 16.01.1992. Mrs. Savitri Mehta sold the same to Anil Mehta and after demise of late Anil Mehta the property was acquired by Mrs. Madhu Mehta wife of Lt. Mr. Anil Mehta vide Relinquishment Deed dated 20.04.2026. Now Mr. Vasu Bhutani intend to Purchase the subject property for the financial assistance from IDBI Bank Ltd. That, (1) Original Death Certificate of late Suraj Prakash, (2) SMC of Late Suraj Prakash and (3) Sale deed dated 08.08.1959 favouring Suraj Prakash has been lost/misplaced/not available. To comply the requirements of BANKINGFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, liens etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saire Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

Munir to visit Tehran amid stalemate in US-Iran peace negotiations

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan's Army chief Asim Munir will visit Tehran on Monday to discuss bilateral and regional issues, Iran's foreign ministry announced on Sunday.

The visit comes at a time when Islamabad is actively pushing to revive its mediation efforts in the stalled US-Iran peace negotiations.

An interim peace agreement, which Pakistan signed as a guarantor, derailed last month as tensions escalated in West Asia with the US and Iran resuming military strikes. Pakistan Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi also held talks



with Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in Tehran earlier this month.

On Sunday, Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baghaei told reporters that Field Marshal Munir will be accompanied by

and security in the region. However, Pakistan has so far not commented on Munir's Tehran visit. The visit, however, is widely perceived to be a follow-up on the stalled Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed in June by the US and Iran, aimed at opening a 60-day window for high-level talks aimed at restoring peace in West Asia.

But the talks collapsed after tensions between the two sides escalated again in mid-July. Pakistan's efforts to revive the talks have so far failed to yield results. The key sticking point is the Strait of Hormuz, where shipping has been disrupted because

of the war that started on February 28 after the US and Israel launched joint attacks on Iran, triggering retaliatory strikes. Roughly a fifth of the world's total energy supplies passed through the Gulf chokepoint in normal times.

Iranian President Pezeshkian on Sunday defended the MoU as the best way for the country to move beyond what he described as a situation of "neither war nor peace", while the hard-line new leader of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, Mohsen Rezaei, threatened Tehran's neighbours against joining the new US effort to hurt Iran's economy. (PTI)

Iran's four-decade war planning makes it difficult for US to decimate it: Indian expert

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

Iran had prepared for a potential war with the US for four decades, including contingencies such as the loss of its top leadership, making it difficult for its adversaries to decimate the country, an Indian military expert has said. Speaking at an interactive session in Washington organised by Observer Research Foundation (ORF) America on Friday, retired Indian Army officer Lt General KJS Dhillion said Iran had retained the capability for "attritional warfare" despite suffering heavy losses in the conflict with the US and Israel.

Dhillion, who previously served as the head of India's defence intelligence agency, said one of the key lessons



from the war was the need for a clearly defined national aim and a well-planned exit strategy. "Before you initiate a war, knowing a few things beforehand is a must. Your declared national aim should

be clear to yourself, your military and the people in the Government. There should also be clarity on the end stage where one can declare victory," he said.

"... then the exit strategy,

especially if it's an overseas war. How do I get out of that area?" he said, adding that countries going to war must also plan for and control the escalation, particularly when confronting powers such as the US and Israel together.

Dhillion said Iran had fought the war broadly along lines it had envisaged over the past 40 years, including preparing for the possible loss of its top leadership. He said Iran had adopted a "mosaic doctrine" and decentralised its armed forces into 31 independent headquarters that could continue functioning even if the central leadership was destroyed.

Iran has also retained the capability to wage attritional warfare, which can favour a weaker side in a prolonged conflict, he said.

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NEW DELHI | MONDAY | AUGUST 24, 2026

BUSINESS14

Gold and silver set to gain ahead of US inflation data

Gold and silver prices are expected to retain their upward momentum next week, though profit-booking at higher levels may temper the rally as investors await key US inflation data, analysts said.

US Core Personal Consumption Expenditures (PCE) inflation and GDP figures will be the key triggers for bullion. Developments surrounding West Asia geopolitics, particularly the US-Iran peace deal and reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, will also remain in focus, they added. "In the coming trading session, we expect bias to remain positive, but some profit-booking cannot be ruled out," Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd, said. On the domestic front, gold futures for October delivery gained Rs 7,932, or 5.13 per cent, to close the week at ₹1.62 lakh per 10 grams on the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX).

Silver for September delivery surged ₹10,673, or 4.52 per cent, to settle at ₹2.46 lakh per kilogram.

"Gold remained firmly positive this week, gaining more than 5 per cent to close near ₹1.62 lakh per 10 grams on the MCX," Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said. (PTI)

Some sugar imports may land before October 15: NFCSF

Some of the sugar shipments to India are likely to reach domestic shores before October 15, but the exact quantity remains difficult to estimate at this stage, a cooperative sugar mills body NFCSF chief said, even as the Centre's crackdown on hoarding has begun to cool prices.

Brazil is the only realistic source of imports for now, with Thailand, the other traditional supplier, ruled out as it is grappling with its own shortfall, National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories (NFCSF) President Prakash Naiknavare said on Sunday. Transit time from Brazil to Indian ports typically takes 40-45 days, and cargo needs additional time to move from port to mill once it lands, he noted. "So, it is difficult to put a number on how much can arrive before October 15th, but the possibility of some shipments arriving by then is good," Naiknavare said. (PTI)

Geopolitical developments, crude oil prices major drivers for market movement: Analysts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices and developments in the US-Iran conflict will remain the primary factors influencing stock market movements this week, according to analysts.

"Investors will closely monitor the Jackson Hole symposium, particularly comments from the US Federal Reserve Chairman, for indications on the future trajectory of interest rates. US GDP estimates, durable goods orders and consumer confidence will also provide important clues on the strength of the US economy and the Fed's policy outlook," Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

On the domestic front, investors will track rupee movement, foreign institutional flows and domestic liquidity conditions, he added.

"Global markets head into the coming week with investor attention centred on three key themes: the Federal Reserve's policy trajectory, Nvidia's quarterly results and the unresolved US-Iran conflict.

"Against a backdrop of volatile long-dated Treasury yields, Fed Chair Kevin Warsh's address at the Jackson Hole symposium will be closely scrutinised for clues

on how the central bank is weighing persistent inflation risks against signs of a softer labour market ahead of its September policy meeting," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Crude oil remains the other major external risk, he said. "The 60-day US-Iran agreement expired without a lasting settlement, leaving the Strait of Hormuz at the centre of an unresolved confrontation and normal energy flows through the region disrupted," Ponmudi added.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have accelerated buying in Indian equities this

Yogi Govt's dual strategy: Curb adulteration, boost dairy

For years, the people of Uttar Pradesh — farmers, cattle-rearers and ordinary consumers — endured the twin scourges of rampant food adulteration, administrative neglect and policy inertia. This was not merely an administrative failure; it constituted a profound assault on the State's economic fabric and cultural ethos.

Milk, a substance regarded as pure and life-giving, was routinely contaminated with water, harmful chemicals and starch. Under previous regimes, lax law enforcement and the absence of political will allowed adulterators to operate with complete impunity, while the hard-working cattle-rearer who nourished society struggled for a fair price. At the same time, indigenous cows — symbols of the State's cultural heritage — wandered the streets in distress, and the dairy sector languished in neglect.

A dual mandate: Uncompromising action against adulteration and a vision for inclusive development

Today the landscape of Uttar Pradesh has undergone a fundamental transformation. Under the leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the Government has charted a new developmental trajectory guided by a robust and nationalist vision. This far-sighted policy rests on two complementary pillars: first, the uncompromising application of the law against adulterators to safeguard public health; and second, the comprehensive revitalisation of the dairy sector so that cattle-rearers and farmers may achieve economic self-reliance.

The strategy is not a mere exercise in administrative reform; it is a transformative campaign that seeks to translate the national resolve of "healthy citizens, prosperous farmers and a strong India" into lived reality. A powerful nation remains an incomplete aspiration for as long as every citizen is denied

pure food and the village farmer is denied a just return for his produce.

Enforcing a zero-tolerance regime against adulterators

The Yogi Government's campaign against adulteration is neither a fleeting drive nor a public-relations exercise; it is a sustained and uncompromising policy offensive. Figures from the Food Safety and Drug Administration Department themselves testify to the rigorous establishment of the rule of law across the State.

Official data spanning nearly the last decade reveal that the department has conducted more than 14.49 lakh intensive inspections and carried out over 2.10 lakh raids. In the course of this extensive surveillance, more than 1.37 lakh food samples failed to meet prescribed quality standards. By instilling a genuine fear of the law among offenders, the Government has recovered penalties exceeding ₹368 crore.

In addition, more than 1.29 lakh criminal cases have been filed in the courts, several of which have resulted in rigorous imprisonment for the convicted.

Eradicating counterfeit products and toxic contaminants from the food chain

Special emphasis has been placed on preserving the purity of milk and milk products. Over the past two years, thousands of targeted inspections and raids have been conducted. As recently as June, July and August 2026, intensive statewide drives were launched in key districts including Ghaziabad, Mathura, Saharanpur, Meerut and Varanasi. During these operations, thousands of quintals of adulterated khoya, chemical milk, counterfeit paneer and unsafe materials were seized and destroyed on the spot.

Reinforcing its unwavering commitment to public health, the Government has imposed a complete ban on the manufacture and sale of "analogue" products — fake paneer, khoya and ghee manufactured from palm oil and synthetic substances. This stringent regulatory grip sends an unambiguous message: no mafia that tampers

with the health of citizens will be spared in Uttar Pradesh.

Ascending to National Leadership in Milk Production

Alongside punitive action, the second and equally vital dimension of the Government's nationalist vision has been the systematic transformation of the dairy sector so as to invigorate the State's economic cycle. Nutritional self-reliance constitutes the true strength of any nation, and today Uttar Pradesh stands as the undisputed leader in milk production across India.

According to figures for the financial year 2024-25, the State recorded a historic output of more than 388 lakh metric tonnes of milk — approximately 16 per cent of the country's total production. This landmark achievement is no accident; it rests on revolutionary initiatives such as the Nand Baba Dugdh Mission, through which defunct cooperative societies in villages across the state have been revived and strengthened.

Building a robust and transparent village-level dairy ecosystem

The most tangible outcome of this policy shift has been a dramatic expansion in rural milk-processing capacity — an increase of nearly 39 lakh litres per day. Modern, technology-enabled dairy units are being established across the State, attracting substantial national and international investment. Transparent systems of milk collec-

tion, chilling and marketing at the village level have liberated farmers from dependence on distant urban markets or exploitative middlemen. With the monopoly and exploitation of intermediaries dismantled, prosperity and economic stability are returning directly to the rural economy.

Conserving indigenous cattle breeds and empowering the rural producer

In this journey towards economic self-reliance, the Government has placed the cattle-rearer at the centre of policy design and devised interventions that deliver direct financial benefit. Through visionary schemes such as the Nandini Krishak Samridhhi Yojana and the Chief Minister's Indigenous Cattle Promotion Scheme, farmers and cattle-rearers are being provided substantial subsidies for the purchase and maintenance of high-quality cows. Special emphasis is being laid on the conservation and promotion of indigenous breeds — Gir, Sahiwal, Tharparkar and others. Indigenous cattle are not only emblems of the State's cultural and spiritual consciousness; their milk is also regarded as superior in quality and nutritional value. As toxic, chemical and counterfeit milk products are driven out of the market, demand for pure and authentic milk multiplies, delivering direct economic gains to the hard-working cattle-rearers whose every

drop of milk now commands a fair and remunerative price.

From Streets of Neglect to Sanctuaries of Care: The Gausshala Transformation

Where once abandoned cattle wandered the State's roads, prey to hunger, disease and accidents, today a robust network of shelters, gausshalas and proper nutrition has been established. Cattle conservation is being integrated with rural development and natural farming to create a circular economy. From the commercial utilisation of cow dung and urine to the production of organic manure, animal husbandry is ceasing to be a loss-making activity and is evolving into a highly profitable enterprise. This transformation is not confined to paper claims; it is visible in the improved living standards of ordinary cattle-rearers in every village of Uttar Pradesh, in the better education of their children, and in the prosperity that has entered their homes.

Forging the foundations of a prosperous and self-reliant Uttar Pradesh

The Yogi Government's dual strategy is, in essence, the practical expression of the national ideal of "security and prosperity," in which strict enforcement of rules and public welfare advance hand in hand. On the one hand, a firm regulatory grip on adulterators is protecting the health and lives of ordinary families; on the other, the strengthening of dairy infrastructure is working to double the income of the village farmer. The urban consumer is reassured by the availability of pure food, while the rural producer, assured of a fair price, grows in self-respect and strength. Where earlier regimes were characterised by corruption, adulteration and policy vacuum, today the authority of the law and welfare-oriented policies are together elevating the state to new heights. This is the genuine transformation that is propelling Uttar Pradesh towards becoming a leading and self-reliant state of the nation.

The author is a professor at Allahabad University and writes on social, political issues

FSSAI suspends license of Marche Retail; restrains SDP Industries from selling ghee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Food regulator FSSAI has suspended the license of Marche Retail Pvt Ltd for serious violations of law and also prohibited Daman-based SDP Industries from selling all variants of ghee.

In a social media post on Sunday, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) said it has suspended the license of Marche Retail Pvt Ltd, New Delhi, and has issued a prohibition order to SDP Industries Pvt Ltd, Daman, after "uncovering serious food safety violations".

The license of Marche Retail was suspended after it detected serious non-compliances during inspection and subsequent follow-up scrutiny of the food business premises, the regulator said.

In the case of Marche Retail, the FSSAI said the establishment was found operating with "deficiencies relating to design, operational controls, sanitation, personal hygiene, food-handler train-

ing and mandatory record-keeping during the inspection".

The FSSAI license has been suspended for 30 days.

The regulator has told the company to "cease and desist" from all food business activities and directed it to rectify mistakes.

In the case of SDP Industries, the FSSAI said that it has issued a prohibition order for "non-compliant ghee products and adulteration concerns".

During enforcement inspection and sample examination, the regulator said the company's multiple ghee products, including variants marketed under brands such as "Shraddha", "Shree Saras" and "Gokul", were found non-compliant with the applicable requirements under the FSS Act, 2006.

Need to scale storage capabilities amid growing RE capacity: Industry experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The growing renewable capacity has created an immediate need to scale up storage systems, industry stakeholders said, highlighting the huge gap between the demand and current capability to manufacture essential battery cell components.

Sharing their views with the media, industry members have also cautioned against treating import dependence as a reason for slow development.

Rising prices of steel and bitumen, geopolitical uncertainty, and continuing challenges in execution of infrastructure projects could moderate India's construction equipment industry growth in the current financial year, Shalabh Chaturvedi, Vice President of the Indian Construction Equipment Manufacturers' Association and Managing Director, India and SAARC, CASE Construction Equipment, has said.

The industry had entered FY27 with expectations of

Representative image

The experts' comments assume significance as India's domestic battery manufacturing currently accounts for less than 1 per cent (2 GWh) of its approximately 260 GWh demand pipeline from competitive tenders in 2026.

Battery energy storage systems (BESS) and pumped storage projects are gaining importance as India expands renewable capacity to meet rising electricity demand and balance solar generation with peak demand, Sunkind India founder and Managing Director Hanish Gupta said.

Batteries and other storage technologies are key to addressing the intermittency risk of solar power and unlocking its growth potential, Premier Energies Chief Business Officer Vinay Rustagi said.

Rising costs may slow construction equipment growth in FY27

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

stronger growth, but subsequent developments have necessitated a more measured outlook, Chaturvedi said in an interview.

"At the beginning of the financial year, the expectation was for double-digit growth. Considering the

developments since then, we are looking at a more moderate, single-digit kind of growth. It is still growth, nonetheless," he said.

Chaturvedi said escalation in input costs had emerged as an important challenge as the financial year progressed.

Commerce Secretary to visit South America

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India is enhancing its focus on South America as part of its trade diversification strategy, particularly Chile, Argentina, and Brazil, which present significant export opportunities and are expected to strengthen trade ties during Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal's visit from August 24 to 28, an official said.

The secretary will chair joint trade meetings in Argentina and Brazil and take stock of the progress of the proposed comprehensive trade agreement with Chile.

The official said trade pact talks between New Delhi and Santiago are at an advanced stage, and only a few issues need to be resolved.

The issues likely to figure in the Chile meeting include market access and critical minerals.

India and Chile implemented a Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA) in 2006 and are now negotiating to widen its scope for a CEPA (Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement).

CEPA aims to build upon the existing PTA between the two nations and seeks to encompass a broader range of sectors, including digital services, investment promotion and cooperation, MSMEs (micro, small and medium enterprises), and

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal

critical minerals.

Chile is India's fifth-largest trading partner in the LAC (Latin American countries) region. The two countries have held four rounds of negotiations, with the last round held here in December 2025.

Since the last engagement, there has been a change of Government in Chile following the December 2025 elections. A conservative Government led by Jose Antonio Kast, who won the 2025 presidential election, assumed office on March 11, 2026. Since then, no formal negotiation has taken place.

"The new Government in Chile is keen on the agreement. Both sides are looking to find solutions to the pending issues," the official said.

With Argentina and Brazil, a proposal to expand the preferential trade agreement between India and the South American nation bloc Mercosur may figure in the meetings during the secretary's visit.

Developments in West Asia had disrupted supply chains and contributed to increases in prices of several key commodities and construction inputs.

"Steel prices have gone up quite significantly. Bitumen prices have also gone up quite significantly," he said.

Bitumen is a critical input for road construction and blacktop surfacing. Its price increased from Rs 40,000-45,000 per tonne to nearly Rs 80,000 per tonne, Chaturvedi said.

While prices have subsequently eased to around Rs 75,000 per tonne this month, they remain substantially

above their earlier levels.

According to Chaturvedi, the sharp increase in construction input costs has affected project economics, particularly for contractors that had bid for projects before the escalation in commodity prices.

This has had an impact on the pace of execution in parts of the road construction sector, which remains one of the most important demand drivers for construction equipment in India.

Chaturvedi said sales across several major equipment categories had registered modest growth during the January-July 2026 period.

Expanding aspirations of *Bharat*: PM Modi's call from the Red Fort



Every time the Tricolour rises, it tells a story. A story of sacrifice, struggle, courage and an unbreakable national spirit. But this Independence Day, the Tricolour also represents something more: the confidence of a nation that has travelled a remarkable distance and is now marching towards a bigger dream.

"Har Ghar Tiranga, Har Man Tiranga" is not merely about putting the national flag on every rooftop. It is about carrying the spirit of *Bharat* in every heart. It is about remembering where we came from, recognising how far we have travelled and believing in how far we can go.

Eighty years after Independence, *Bharat* stands at a fascinating point in its journey. The country that was once described as one of the world's Fragile Five is today among the major economies of the world and has emerged as the fastest growing major economy. This transformation did not happen overnight. It is the result of millions of Indians participating in the nation's growth, backed by reforms, infra-

structure development, technology and a government determined to deliver at scale.

To understand this change, one does not always have to look at complicated economic reports. Sometimes, the story of a changing India can be seen in the everyday life of an ordinary family. A gas connection reaching a household. A toilet being built for a poor family. A home becoming a reality. A digital payment being made within seconds. A farmer receiving access to formal credit. A young person launching a startup. A woman becoming a Lakhpati Didi. A family installing solar panels and reducing its electricity bill. A modern train carrying passengers across an increasingly electrified railway network. These individual stories together tell the larger story of New India.

Twelve years ago, piped gas was available in only around 70 cities. Today, that network has expanded to nearly 700 cities. The number of households receiving piped gas has risen from barely 20 to 22 lakhs to nearly 1.75 crore. The speed of providing gas connections has increased six times.

The same transformation can be seen in India's energy journey. Twelve years ago, the country had only around 2 GW of solar energy capacity. Today, it has reached around 160 GW. Through the PM



Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana, more than 50 lakh households have already adopted solar energy. For many families, the rooftop is no longer simply a part of the house. It has become a source of clean energy, lower electricity bills and, in some cases, additional income through the sale of surplus electricity.

India's railway transformation tells an equally remarkable story. Railway electrification began in 1925, yet progress remained gradual for decades. What followed in the last decade, however, has been historic. Electrification has accelerated from just about 1.42 km per day between 2004 and 2014 to an average of more than 15 km per day between 2019 and 2025.

The pace underscores a transformative shift in how quickly the network is being modernised. Electrified track share rose from 24 per cent in 2000 to 40 per cent in 2017, and crossed 96 per cent by the end of 2024.

Today, that century-long journey is approaching its finish line. As of November 2025, India has electrified an impressive 69,427 route kilometres, covering about 99.2 per cent of its railway network, out of which 46,900 RKM have been electrified between 2014 and 2025. What once took generations is now being achieved in years. Modern railway coach production has increased 21-fold, reflecting the scale and speed of India's manufacturing push. The numbers

become even more striking when we look at technology and manufacturing. Mobile phone production has increased 35-fold. Digital transactions have increased 100-fold. Electric vehicle sales have risen from around 1.5 lakh in 2009-10 to 25 lakh in 2025-26.

India's transformation is also visible in the way the Government approaches governance. Thousands of compliances have been removed and hundreds of outdated laws have been repealed. A young nation aspiring to become a developed country cannot carry the administrative baggage of another century. The objective is clear: simplify governance, reduce unnecessary barriers and create an environment where citizens and businesses can move forward with confidence.

The SVAMITVA Scheme is another example of how development can change economic possibilities in rural India. Nearly 3.25 crore families have benefited from the scheme, unlocking assets worth around ₹140 lakh crore. A property that once existed only as an informal asset can now become a recognised economic resource, help families access bank loans and create new opportunities.

After 35 years, the country received a new National Education Policy. The number of universities has expanded significantly and

India is moving towards the milestone of 1,000 universities. Medical education has also expanded, opening more opportunities for young Indians to serve the nation in healthcare.

Then there is the entrepreneurial energy of a new generation. Startup India has helped create an ecosystem of more than 2.5 lakh registered startups. The young Indian is increasingly moving from asking, "Where will I get a job?" to asking, "What can I build?" The proposed ₹1 lakh crore Innovation Fund strengthens that confidence. It tells the youth that their ideas matter, their dreams matter and the nation is willing to stand behind their innovation.

The bioeconomy provides another glimpse of this new India. From a turnover of around ₹60,000 crore before 2014, the sector has grown to around ₹20 lakh crore. This is the story of young scientists, innovators, entrepreneurs and institutions turning knowledge into economic opportunity. And perhaps one of the most powerful transformations is taking place quietly in villages across Bharat. The goal of creating 3 crore Lakhpati Didis has been surpassed. Now the country is moving towards the target of 6 crore Lakhpati Didis.

India's growth story is therefore not confined to big cities, highways,

airports or corporate boardrooms. It is unfolding in villages, homes, farms, classrooms, laboratories, startups and small businesses.

The most important change, however, is psychological. India is increasingly moving from a mindset of limitation to a mindset of possibility. The journey from being counted among the Fragile Five to becoming the fastest growing major economy is not simply a story of GDP. It is a story of confidence. It is the confidence that Bharat can compete with the world, create at scale, innovate at speed and build for generations to come. That is why the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047 is not an abstract political slogan. It is a national resolve built on the foundations being laid today.

When we look at the Tricolour, we see the sacrifices of our freedom fighters. But we should also see the aspirations of a billion plus Indians who want to build an even stronger, prosperous and self-confident Bharat. The Tricolour belongs to every Indian. It flies over every achievement, every aspiration and every dream. And with every passing year, the Tiranga is not merely rising higher. The Bharat it represents is rising higher too.

The author is National Coordinator of Digital Library and Documentation, BJP

India, Mauritius sign long-term fuel supply pact

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Mauritius have deepened their energy partnership with a five-year agreement under which Indian Oil Corporation will supply the island nation's entire import requirement of petrol, diesel and aviation turbine fuel, strengthening New Delhi's role as a key energy-security partner in the Indian Ocean.

The agreement was exchanged during Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri's official visit to Mauritius on August 20-21, alongside a Government-to-Government memorandum of understanding (MoU) to expand cooperation in oil and gas, including petroleum product supplies, training and capacity building, and biofuels.

The long-term sales and purchase agreement between Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) and Mauritius' State Trading Corporation is designed to



Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri signing agreements with Patrick Gervais Assirvaden, Minister of Energy and Public Utilities of Mauritius on Friday in Mauritius

provide Mauritius with assured supplies and reduce its exposure to price volatility, an official statement said.

This, it said, was the first long-term supply agreement concluded by an Indian public-sector oil marketing company outside South Asia in recent years.

Under the pact, "IOC will supply the entire import requirement of Mauritius of motor spirit (petrol), high-speed diesel (diesel) and aviation turbine fuel (ATF)."

Separately, IOC said the 27,500 tonne bunker fuel storage facility at MAP Land in Mer Rouge, Mauritius, has been built at an investment of USD 25 million. "The facility will significantly boost IOML's bunkering capabilities and Mauritius' ambitions as a strategic bunkering hub. As Mauritius charts new horizons in its Blue Economy, IndianOil is proud to power the journey ahead."

The agreement comes as countries seek to strengthen

energy security against disruptions in global fuel markets, particularly amid continuing instability in the West Asia region.

India, which has emerged as a major refining hub, produces about 267 million tonnes of refined petroleum products annually from 23 refineries and is a net exporter of refined fuels. It already supplies petroleum products to neighbouring Nepal and Bhutan and exports significant volumes to other markets in the region and beyond. The ministry said India continued to meet its supply commitments to Nepal and Bhutan even during the ongoing West Asia crisis, underscoring its position as a reliable supplier to the region.

"The agreement with Mauritius positions India as the country's anchor fuel supplier and strengthens India's strategic and economic footprint in the Indian Ocean region," the ministry statement said.

SBI's total business may double to ₹200 lakh cr by 75th foundation year in 2030, says chairman

KUMAR DIPANKAR
■ New Delhi

State Bank of India's total business could potentially double to around ₹200 lakh crore by 2030, when the bank celebrates its platinum jubilee, given the current growth trajectory, Chairman CS Setty said.

SBI came into existence on July 1, 1955, through an Act of Parliament, which, among other things, provided for the transfer of the undertaking of the Imperial Bank of India. The country's biggest lender crossed the landmark of ₹100 lakh crore total business, which is an aggregate of total loans and advances in the second quarter of the last financial year. This further increased to ₹110.01 lakh crore at the end of June 2026.

Whether the bank had set a specific target for its platinum jubilee year, Setty said there was no formal milestone, but the bank's growth trajectory could take its total business to ₹170-180 lakh crore and potentially as high as ₹200 lakh crore by 2030.

"We don't have any milestone, but if you take the current growth rate, I



CS Setty

think we should be around ₹170-180 lakh crore, or maybe reaching ₹200 lakh crore. That would be another important milestone," he told PTI in an interview.

Setty said the scale of SBI's operations is closely linked to the performance of the Indian economy.

"For a bank of our size, scale is imminent, and it is fully intertwined with what is happening in the Indian economy," he said.

He noted that if the Indian economy continues to grow at 7-8 per cent, SBI's balance sheet has the potential to

expand around 11-12 per cent annually. "If the Indian economy grows at 7-8 per cent and our balance sheet has a potential to grow at 11-12 per cent, it means again coming to my favourite theme that every six years SBI's balance sheet gets doubled. So I think it's potentially possible by 2030 we may have ₹200 lakh crore overall business," he said.

Setty further said SBI has Vision 2030, which focuses on ensuring that all bank's activities benefit or address the requirements of four key stakeholders — customers, employees, shareholders, and the government and regulators, including the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

"We are working on the requirements of all these four stakeholders. When we benchmark ourselves against the best globally, we should be able to measure up to the best standards in each of these areas," he said.

For customers, he said, the focus is on improving service and experience. For employees, SBI aims to simplify processes, improve productivity and create an environment where they feel satisfied and can deliver their best. (PTI)

Gold loan portfolio to surpass ₹1.5 lakh crore by FY27-end: Indian Bank MD

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Public sector lender Indian Bank expects its gold loan book to cross ₹1.5 lakh crore in the current financial year, supported by robust demand for the product.

"Gold loan is safe lending for banks...it is not a consumption loan, but mostly it is income-generating and also helps small businesses to grow. Last year, we saw very significant growth of 30 per cent in the segment due to a jump in gold prices. It will be slower this year as there is a 30 per cent decline in gold prices," Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar told PTI in an interaction.

This growth would come from tonnage, he said, adding that the gold loan segment is likely to grow about 20 per cent.



Binod Kumar

Currently, the gold loan portfolio is around ₹1.25 lakh crore, and the book should exceed ₹1.5 lakh crore during this financial year at the anticipated growth rate, he said.

Kumar further said that RAM (Retail, Agriculture, and MSME) constitutes 65 per cent of the overall loan book, while the remaining 35 per cent is from corporate.

The bank wants to maintain the ratio going forward, he said, adding that RAM has huge capacity for growth with a lot of opportunity in agriculture and MSMEs.

On the liability side, Kumar said the bank has witnessed CASA growth at 15.30 per cent, with savings deposits growing by 13.54 per cent and current account deposits by 26.33 per cent during the first quarter of the current financial year. The bank's low-cost deposits, CASA (Current Account and Savings Account), are around 40 per cent.

"CASA remains a challenge, but with the support of our staff, we expect to maintain progress. One encouraging development is the increased participation of branches.

"During the corresponding period last year, only around

25-27 per cent of branches achieved their targets. This quarter, 51 per cent of branches achieved their targets. That is a good sign that branches have started participating more actively," he said.

Indian Bank has mobilised USD 400 million by issuing four-year bonds to global investors through its GIFT City Branch. The bank issued notes on August 18.

This is part of the bank's plan to raise \$1 billion from the overseas markets by the end of 2026 using the special regulatory window to boost dollar inflows. It is likely to mobilise the remaining \$600 million of the target in the third quarter.

On Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR (B) deposits, he expects the bank to garner about \$2 billion by August 31.

IIFCL initiates \$1.8-bn ECB fundraising programme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned India Infrastructure Finance Company Ltd (IIFCL) has kick-started its \$1.8 billion External Commercial Borrowing (ECB) fund-raising programme by mobilising \$200 million through international markets.

The mobilisation marks the first milestone in IIFCL's broader international fund-raising programme, following Government approval to raise about \$1.8 billion through ECBs, the company said in a statement on Sunday. The company is pursuing



opportunities across international financial markets with a focus on competitive pricing, prudent risk management and mobilisation of long-term resources to support India's infrastructure financing requirements. As part of the programme, IIFCL is envisaging raising about \$1 billion through long-term ECBs, with tenors of up to 15 years, under the MIGA Guarantee Facility, in multiple

tranches, it said. The Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA), a World Bank Group arm, provides guarantees against non-

commercial risks to facilitate the flow of foreign investment in developing countries and lift people out of poverty.

National Yuva Cooperative Society Ltd.
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NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that 25th Annual Representative General Body Meeting (RGB) of National Yuva Cooperative Society Limited (NYCS) will be held on 12th September 2026 at 01:30 pm at National Cooperative Union of India, BETA Hall, 3 August Kranti Marg, New Delhi-110016.
All the Members of the RGB and Central Registrar of Cooperative Societies are requested to participate in the meeting.
Detailed agenda of the meeting can be viewed in the website: www.nycsindia.com
Date: 24th August 2026
Place: New Delhi
Dr. R D Kulkarni
Chief Executive Officer, NYCS

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (22.8.26)

2	7	5	6	4	8	9	3	1
1	8	6	9	5	3	2	4	7
4	3	9	1	2	7	6	5	8
9	6	2	3	7	1	5	8	4
7	1	4	5	8	9	3	2	6
3	5	8	4	6	2	7	1	9
5	4	1	7	3	6	8	9	2
8	9	7	2	1	5	4	6	3
6	2	3	8	9	4	1	7	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

MONDAY | AUGUST 24, 2026

ACROSS

3 Something hard to pinch, we hear (5)
8 Communication by road, perhaps, around India (5)
10 Catches with spikes (5)
11 Just the chap to figure ahead (3)
12 Vituperous about the vermin? (5)
13 Welsh theatrical assistant? (7)
15 Do they go round cooking the roast? (5)
18 A pet to many? (3)
19 Legislators a chap has to check out (6)
21 Acceptable new belt for a woman to appear in (7)
22 It's no good being needy (4)

DOWN

1 Quiet, unusually dear sky pilot (5)
2 I leave a cleric in church (7)
4 Rush, causing damage (4)
5 Portion of green plant served at table (6)
6 Provide or supply only a blend (3,2)
7 What a drifter will do, making love flat out (5)
9 Female, yet named John? (3)
12 Observations concerning points (7)
14 His song never ends (3)
16 Four-legged source of a bleat? (5)
17 It's a bit of a bloomer, boys! (5)
19 Hitler's disastrous slide (7)
20 Being on the male side, it has point (5)

SOLUTION (22.8.26)

ACROSS
1. Spitz
6. Banks
9. W-ashd-ay
10. Creep
11. Lenin
12. Bills
13. Festoon
15. H-em
17. A-shy
18. Morose
19. He-MA-n
20. Crater
22. Cite
24. Ear
25. Lighter
26. Med-oc
27. Limit
28. Folly
29. Min-uses
30. Ant-ic
31. Weary
DOWN
2. P-u-rses
3. Twenty
4. Zap
5. Chain
6. B-all-oon
7. A-yes
8. Knives
9. Teller
12. Chews
13. Mi-mi
14. She-ar
15. Hop it
16. Meter
18. Magic
19. Heretic
21. Ration
22. Choise
(chews)
23. Teller
25. Lot-us
26. Mi-mi
28. Few

Padikkal hits ton, leads India to 300/5 on Day 1 against SL

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Colombo

Devdutt Padikkal conjured an extraordinary 117, powering India above Rishabh Pant's hand injury and untimely fall of wickets around him to a reasonable 300 for five on the opening day of second and final Test against spirited Sri Lanka here on Sunday.

Dhruv Jurel (7) and debutant Saransh Jain (4) were batting at close after a taxing day of Test cricket. Padikkal's 168-ball innings, his second hundred in as many Tests, was not laced with the customary elegance barring on a couple of occasions when he brought out those full-blooded pulls and drives. He

was dropped on 0 and 1 but remained solid after those reprieves. But the innings was still stunning because of the circumstances in which it was executed. Yashasvi Jaiswal (45) and skipper Shubman Gill (50), with whom he constructed a stabilising 120-run stand for the third wicket, were dismissed after raising visions of bigger knocks. Pant copped a blow on his forearm from pacer Lahiru Kumara and had to retire hurt on 3, leaving Padikkal to do the heavy lifting.

Then there were the constantly examining Sri Lankan bowlers and the scorching heat and humidity of Colombo for him to tide over. It was not that the

Karnataka man had oodles of experience on his back to fall back upon to counter such tough situations.

Padikkal was playing just the fourth Test of his nascent career but the circumstances forced him to play the lead firefighter's role. This century was vastly different from the one he scored at Galle, where the pitch was not remotely challenging in the first two days. But the SSC deck offered enough bounce and bite, especially for pacers, asking constant questions about his technique and patience.

Padikkal answered each of those searching questions with poise. He reached 50 off 90 balls, driving left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya



for a four.

Going past the little landmark only strengthened his resolve, and there was a streak for fortune when Lankan skipper Dhananjaya de Silva shelled a chance at backward point off Keshara

with short-pitched balls. Padikkal weaved away or tucked them around, and offered a dead bat whenever spinners found some turn and bounce. Eventually, the much-awaited moment came when he first drove Jayasuriya for a four to reach 99, and two balls later he nudged the spinner to long-on for a single to make a landing on the three-figure zone. Promptly came off the helmet and the bat was raised skywards for a quick celebration before focusing on the job at hand again.

But Nuwantha had his revenge finally when he pushed a ball through the defence of Padikkal to castle him, but, by then, he had

taken the ship to safer shores.

Each of KL Rahul, Jaiswal and Gill had a similar opportunity but failed to kick-on.

Rahul was as restrained as ever but showed a glimpse of his shot-making ability, lifting Jayasuriya for a six straight over the head of the bowler.

But the trouble came without any warning. Rahul went for a square cut off Kumara, but the laden feet shot only produced an edge to stumper Niroshan Dickwella. Jaiswal was impressive too as he eschewed the cut shot, which has led to his peril often in the past, to a good extent. The left-hander smashed Kumara for two boundaries in succession, before executing a wonderful cover drive off Jayasuriya just as he warmed-up for a more substantial score. Asitha Fernando produced a peach of a nip-backer to breach his defence and the dismissal followed a little piece of drama.

Fernando gave Jaiswal, who had sledged Dickwella in the second innings of the first Test at Galle, a send-off and the Indian opener turned back to have a few words with Lankan with his helmet touching the forehead of the pacer. But the situation was defused by home captain De Silva. Gill also was playing smoothly for his half-century, unfurling some lovely shots like a short-arm pull off Jayasuriya for a boundary. (PTI)

Saransh's Test journey: Letting go chance to be in IPL to work on red-ball game

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Colombo

Saransh Jain's journey to becoming India's Test cap Number 320 on Sunday is a touching story of never-dying belief in himself and diligent work to improve his skills in red-ball format, for which he was even ready to let go a chance to earn IPL contract.

Chandrakant Pandit, Jain's coach at Madhya Pradesh, clearly remembers that open conversation with his ward, which left him an immensely impressed man.

"He did mention to me, especially last season, that he wants to focus on his red ball game. He was very clear about it. It's not that he is not averse or keen to bowl with a white ball but he wanted to work on his red-ball



Saransh Jain

FILE PHOTO

bowling," Pandit said.

But that particular chat between Pandit and Jain, who handed his Test debut against Sri Lanka here at the SSC, took place during IPL 2024 when the off-spinner approached him with a

rather unusual demand.

Jain, who was with Kolkata Knight Riders as a net bowler, did not want to continue that stint. "The reason he said then was that rather than spending time with the white ball as a net bowler, he

preferred to work on the red ball game and eventually he became a state player," Pandit, who took over MP's coaching in 2020, added.

However, Pandit does not have any doubt over Jain's ability to excel in white-ball format as well. "He is good enough to play both the formats, he has necessary skills. I am sure if some franchise picks him up in the IPL next season, he will do well there also. "But he doesn't want to spend two months bowling with white ball as a net bowler. I really appreciated that he kept on working on his red ball game. He does bowl well, even white ball, when he plays for our state. So, this might just be the beginning for him," he said. But when Pandit took

over as MP's coach six years back, Jain was not a regular, often suffering from bouts of self-doubts.

"First season when I came in he was struggling to establish himself. The lack of game time had affected his confidence and I had to talk to him and give him that comfort, telling him to play freely without worrying about other things like selection." But what made Pandit zeroed in on a non-regular player like Jain?

"After the time of Harbhajan and Ashwin, we don't have a proper off-spinner now, and Jain struck me as someone who can play at the highest level, and he needed that backing. So, it made me talk to him, understand his mindset and

take him into my confidence," he noted.

Another thing that piqued Pandit's interest was Jain's ability to bowl from around the wicket, something off-spinners tend not to do at any level.

"Saransh is the only bowler, that I have ever seen, bowling round the wicket. I mean, there are no off-spinners I have seen who start the first delivery with a round the wicket. I mean, everybody has a different method of bowling and he has his. "But Saransh is the only unique bowler that I have found in terms of bowling around the wicket. Recently, I have seen many state level spinners, who have been copying his style," Pandit detailed. (PTI)

Clark pulls away for 5-shot lead at Bellerive over Rory McIlroy and Cantlay



DOUG FERGUSON ■ St Louis

Wyndham Clark was doing everything right until it all went wrong at the BMW Championship. Just not for long. Bogey-free through 36 holes, he went from the bunker left of the fairway to the right rough on the opening hole at Bellerive. He came up short of the green, chipped to 7 feet and missed the putt, taking a double bogey that cost him the lead.

The conversation on the second tee included a few choice words and a message from his caddie to embrace the challenge and move on. Clark wound up finding another gear. He had five birdies in an eight-hole stretch and turned a bad start into a big lead.

Even closing with a bogey, Clark had a 5-under 65 and a five-shot lead.

"Hit a bad shot on 2, but then really made a nice recovery and then got into a nice groove after that," Clark said.

It was the second time this year Clark has led by at least five shots going into the final

round. He had a six-shot advantage at the U.S. Open and held on to win by one for his second major.

Rory McIlroy ran off three straight birdies late in the round and saved par from a bunker on the 18th for a 65. Patrick Cantlay birdied the 18th for a 66. They were tied for second, a position far more relevant to Cantlay. He is at No. 43 in the FedEx Cup and needs a high finish to be among the top 30 who advance to the FedEx Cup finale next week in Atlanta.

"That's a lot to make up," McIlroy said of his deficit. "But if I focus on myself, try to shoot a good score - I shot a 64 and a 65 this week - shoot something similar tomorrow, you never know."

Gary Woodland, trying to cap off his remarkable year with a return to the Tour Championship, only managed two birdies in a round of 70. He was six shots behind, perhaps too far back to challenge Clark but high enough to extend his season another week. He was tied with Chris Gotterup (68). (AP)

Starc's 10 wickets leads Australia to victory in 2nd Test against Bangladesh

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Mackay (Australia)

Mitchell Starc's 10-wicket match haul lifted Australia to a morale boosting victory by an innings and 51 run in the second cricket test as it leveled the two-match series against Bangladesh inside two days.

Starc returned match figures of 10-51, after taking four wickets Sunday to go with his incredible 6-12 on a wild Day 1 which saw Bangladesh bundled out for 64 before the hosts also had its struggles on a spicy pitch at Mackay, in northern Queensland state.

It was the evergreen left-arm swing bowler's fourth ten-wicket haul in tests and also saw him move past

South Africa pace great Dale Steyn into 10th on the all-time list with 445 wickets, with Starc having no thoughts of finishing up yet.

(The body's) still hanging together, I thoroughly enjoy being a part of this group," said Starc, named player-of-the-series for his 12 wickets across the two matches. "Test cricket, I've said it before, it will always be the pinnacle for me. I'd like to milk my body for all I can for test cricket, and that's how it'll remain." Pat Cummins and Nathan Lyon (3-25) each took three wickets to support Starc as Bangladesh could only manage 95 in its second innings to hand Australia a comprehensive win after its shock loss in last week's first test at Darwin. Captain



Najmul Hossain Shanto top scored for the visitors with 31, while Mushfiquur Rahim had an unbeaten 29, but the pair had very little help from the remaining tourist batters with only two scoring above double digits.

I think this is a different condition (to the first test in Darwin) and there's a little bit more extra bounce and swing in the air," Shanto said. "So it's challenging for us, but as a team if we want to go forward we need to

adjust and I hope this experience will help going forward." Earlier Sunday, Australia resumed at 165-8 with Cameron Green and Nathan Lyon adding another 28 useful runs Sunday for the ninth wicket. After also taking six wickets on Day 1, Shoriful Islam soon picked up his seventh with a searing inswinging yorker which struck Green on the front foot and was given out leg before wicket on review.

Shoriful's 7-48 was the best bowling figures for a Bangladesh player away from home. Green's 67 off 105 balls with 10 boundaries was the top score of the match so far and follows his breakthrough home century in the first test at Darwin to lock down his place in Australia's

middle order. "We've got 20 tests coming up this year, so yeah, you want to get off to a good start, and I felt like I have done that, Green said. "So now it's just building on that and finding something that works and just continue with it.

Lyon (32 not out) and Josh Hazlewood then pushed Australia's score past 200 before Hazelwood (6) skied a catch off Taijul Islam (1-17) to end the innings at 210, and a significant first innings lead of 146 runs on a bowlers' wicket. Fresh from taking 6-12 in the first innings, Starc again tormented Bangladesh's top order in the second innings taking another two wickets in consecutive balls to have the visitors' reeling early in its chase.



Assam Chief Minister and BAI President Himanta Biswa Sarma attended the finals of the #BWFWorldBadmintonChampionships in New Delhi on Sunday, marking the successful conclusion of the global tournament, hosted in India after a 17-year hiatus

PIONEER PHOTO

‘Need to rework FTP so that we can have more Tests with India, Aus, Eng’

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Colombo

Sri Lanka Cricket interim committee chairman Eran Wickramaratne on Sunday suggested a suitable rejigging of ICC's Future Tours Programme so that the country can play more Test matches against top nations like India, England, and Australia. Sri Lanka played two Tests against the West Indies in June-July after a year-long hiatus, and currently are engaged in a two-match series against India.

The island nation is scheduled to play six more Tests this year - two each against Pakistan and New Zealand (away) and two against South Africa at home. "I think it's the international calendar which

is causing this issue of us not playing enough Tests, and this is the format we want to do well. But the tours are determined by the FTP and we're hoping to have more tours with India in the next (World Test Championship) cycle," Wickramaratne told select media here.

"We've heard that we'll have a few more (tours) in the next cycle so we're keeping our fingers crossed. But obviously India, England, Australia are the teams that the entire world is looking at playing and I think we want to make sure that we get tours from those countries."

Wickramaratne called for a more balanced scheduling in the upcoming international schedule.



"Yes, we need a balance and now we are scheduled to play 10 Test matches whereas we've played hardly anything this year. So, I think we need to rework our FTP and see how it goes. "I think it's the T20 and 50-over cricket which has congested the calendar in a sense. But we want to play India because the truth is we depend on

India a lot, and they are also the financial power in cricket," he reasoned. In that context, Wickramaratne hoped that the recent meeting with ICC president Jay Shah and BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia can bring in some good results.

"I had a conversation with Jay Shah, and recently we had a visit from BCCI's Devajit Saikia. We want to make sure that we work together in building cricket here and across the world. We need the support of India and we really appreciate the support we get. "India is also stuck with a tight calendar of their own and they struggle to come here. But for us it would be great if we can have more teams coming and playing

here but I guess it will depend on the international calendar. Yes, we had a very good meeting. They were very good with us," he noted. Former Lankan cricketer Sidath Wettimuny, now a member of the interim committee, underlined the effort of a new set of administrators to bring transparency into the running of SLC.

"Like India had the Lodha commission, other boards in South Africa, New Zealand and Australia did make some changes. So we need to change with the times and one of the most fundamental things that we have done in this current constitution is having independent directors as well, not all elected," said Wettimuny. (PTI)

Edmund hat-trick fires East Bengal to 17th Durand Cup title, end 22 years wait

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Edmund Lalrindika struck a dream derby hat-trick as a compact East Bengal produced a scintillating show to rout Mohun Bagan 4-1 and clinch a record-equalling 17th Durand Cup title here on Sunday. It also ended the Red and Gold's 22-year wait for the trophy, having last won in 2004 with a 2-1 win over Mohun Bagan.

The Antonio Lopez Habascoached side were at their fluid best, with skipper Mohammed

Rashid holding the midfield and orchestrating their attacks, as East Bengal handed their arch-rivals a nightmare start by scoring four goals in a breath-taking first half. Rashid set up Bipin Singh's opener in the 10th minute and later assisted Lalrindika's hat-trick goal in the 44th minute.

Playing as a lone forward in place of Jesin TK, Lalrindika also struck in the 12th and 22nd minutes as East Bengal virtually buried their arch-rivals' hopes in an action-packed first half.

Manvir Singh pulled one back for Mohun Bagan in the 33rd minute, providing a solitary moment of joy for the Mariners. But the reigning Indian Super League champions remained compact and disciplined to see out the match and exact revenge for their 0-1 defeat in the 2023 final that had given Mohun Bagan a record 17th title.

The result means the two city heavyweights are now even-stevens, with 17 Durand Cup titles apiece in the 135-year history of the Asia's oldest



competition. It was a dream start from the Habas's men as East Bengal virtually sealed Mohun Bagan's fate before

the half-hour mark, with the Red and Gold Brigade running riot in a pulsating first half.

Bipin opened the scoring in

the 10th minute with a composed left-footed finish.

Captain Rashid won possession in the opposition half, shaped as if to shoot before slipping the ball through to Bipin, who calmly drilled his effort from inside the box past Vishal Kaith. Before Mohun Bagan could regroup, East Bengal struck again. Edmund doubled the lead, bursting forward on the counter before unleashing a powerful 20-yard effort that took a deflection off Kaith and nestled into the net.

Edmund was at it again in

the 22nd minute, this time finishing into an empty net.

Hardik Bhatt picked up the ball on the left and fed Daniel Ramirez, who threaded it through to Lalrindika. The striker took a touch into the box, rounded the advancing Kaith with another touch and slotted into the unguarded goal. The captain was involved once again as Rashid delivered a teasing cross to the far side of the box, where Jay Gupta arrived at pace and squared it across the face of goal for Edmund to tap home and

complete his hat-trick. Manvir gave Mohun Bagan a glimmer of hope after the drinks break, pulling one back to make it 4-1, but the Mariners' revival never materialised. Their defensive gaps and lack of control in key areas left them with too much ground to make up for the Greek tactician Panagiotis Dilmeris as East Bengal comfortably protected their advantage. For Habas, the triumph carried an added emotional weight, given his deep ties with both sides of the Kolkata derby.